

Spanish, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one commute at a time

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This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they
are written.

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Preface

This book teaches Spanish one word at a time — and it teaches each word by taking it apart. A huge fraction of Spanish vocabulary is not arbitrary: it is Latin, lightly worn by a thousand years of use, and English borrowed from the same Latin so often that the two languages are full of hidden cousins. So no word here is a fresh thing to memorize. *gracias* arrives next to *grace*, *gratitude*, *gratuity*, *ingrate*, and *congratulate* — a family you have owned your whole life. The bet is simple and, as far as we can tell, how the brain actually works: you learn the new by welding it to the known.

Three things follow from that, and shape every lesson:

- **One word per lesson, gone deep.** Not “the ten greetings” — *hola* is a lesson, *buenos días* is a lesson. A few minutes each, the size of a single errand or commute.
- **The widest honest web of cousins.** Every word reaches for all the English relatives it can *truthfully* claim — because the more live connections a word has, the more places it sticks. False cousins are flagged, not smuggled in.
- **The reason, not the rule.** Why is it *buenos días*, plural? Because it is the fossil of a blessing, “*may God give you good days.*” We learn the culture and the idiom hiding inside the grammar — the things Spanish 101 skips.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Spanish out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind pronunciation. Each lesson names the one or two sounds its own word needs, exactly where they are needed. The whole system is gathered in a reference at the back of the book — somewhere to look things up when you are curious, never a chapter to sit through first.

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Chapter 1

Hola and Buenos Días

Modes: 🎧 voice (7) 🎧 Hands-free start: all 7 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can greet someone in Spanish, say how I am, and wish them a good day.

A short doorway greeting: hola, an answer to how you are, and buenos días on the way in.

1.1 hola — hello

The very first word, and the easiest to say — but there’s already one trap hiding in it, and one small mystery.

Sounds you’ll need

- **silent-h** — the **h** is **silent**. *hola* is said *OH-la*, never *HOH-la*. The letter is written but makes no sound at all. This is true of every Spanish *h* you’ll ever meet. → pronunciation reference
- **vowel-o, vowel-a** — two pure vowels: *OH*, *AH*. No glide, no drift.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hola — hello / hi.

This one is a genuine mystery, and honesty matters more than a tidy story: *hola*’s origin is **not settled**. It’s an old interjection — a hailing call — and that’s about as far as the evidence firmly goes. You’ll see it confidently linked to English *hello*, or to Arabic *wallāh* (“by God”), or

to a nautical shout. Treat all of those as **folk etymology**: plausible-sounding, not established.

In particular, the resemblance to English *hello* is a **false friend**. English *hello* comes from a Germanic hailing root (*hail*, *holler*, *hollo*) — a completely different family from anything Spanish. The two words sound alike by pure coincidence, not shared ancestry.

Why flag this so hard? Because the whole method of this book is building on real family resemblances between Spanish and English. A *fake* one is worse than none — it teaches a connection your brain then has to unlearn. So: enjoy *hola*, but don't file it next to *hello* in your head. They're strangers who happen to look alike.

Why it's said this way

hola is **informal**. It's the “hi” you'd say to a friend, a kid, a shopkeeper you know. It carries no time of day and no deference — which is exactly why, in more formal or first-meeting situations, Spanish speakers reach past it for *buenos días* and its siblings (the next lessons). Knowing *when not* to use *hola* is as much the lesson as the word itself.

Note the written form: an exclamation gets an **upside-down mark** at the front — *¡hola!* — so you know the tone before you start reading it aloud.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hola” — *OH-la*, silent h
- “¡hola!” to an imagined friend — light, informal

Before you move on

Two things to lock in: what sound does the *h* make? (None.) And is *hola* actually related to English *hello*? (No — a coincidence, a false friend.)

1.2 bien — “well,” a whole answer in one word

You have *hola*. Now the word that carries half of everyday small talk: *bien*. It answers “how are you,” it agrees to a plan, it stands completely on its own — and it opens a family of English words you already use.

What to know first

- *hola* — your first word; *bien* is what you say back when someone asks how you are.

Sounds you’ll need

- diphthong-**ie** — **ie** is a quick *YEH*: *bien* is said *byen*, one syllable. → reference
- **v-b** — the **b** is soft, halfway to a *v*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

bien — “well.” Root: Latin **bene** (“well”). That *bene* is the piece hiding in a shelf of English words, every one about something being *good* or *well*:

- **benefit** — literally “to do **well**” (*bene* + *facere*).
- **benevolent** — “wishing **well**” (*bene* + *volens*).
- **benediction** — “speaking **well**,” a blessing (*bene* + *dicere*).
- **benefactor**, **beneficial**, **benign**.

So *bien* is the Spanish member of the *bene*- family you’ve owned in English your whole life.

Using it on its own. This is the useful part: *bien* is a complete answer.

- “¿Cómo estás?” (how are you?) → “**Bien.**” — “Well.” / “I’m good.” Done.
- As agreement, when someone suggests something → “**Bien.**” — “Okay / fine.”

The adjective sibling: *bueno* / *buena*

bien is an **adverb** — it describes *how* something is done (“you speak *well*”). When you want the **adjective** — to describe a *thing* as “good” — Spanish uses **bueno** (for a masculine word) or **buena** (for a feminine word). These come from Latin **bonus** (“good”), *bene*’s sibling: Latin split the idea of “good” into an adverb (*bene*) and an adjective (*bonus*), and Spanish kept both. The Latin-descended English cousins of *bueno* are *bonus*, *bonanza*, and *bounty*.

English does the exact same split: *well* (adverb) vs. *good* (adjective) — “you did *well*” but “a *good* job.” English’s pair happens to be Germanic, not Latin, so *well/good* aren’t blood cousins of *bien/bueno* — but the *structure* is identical, and that parallel is your handle: **bien = well**, **bueno/buena = good**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “bien” as the answer to “how are you”
- “bueno” then “buena” — the adjective, masculine then feminine

Before you move on

Which is the adverb (“well”) and which is the adjective (“good”)? (*bien* / *bueno–buena*.) And name an English *bene-* cousin of *bien*. (benefit, benevolent, benediction...)

1.3 *el* and *la* — “the,” and the gender it carries

Before your first noun, meet two of the smallest, most frequent words in Spanish: *el* and *la*. Both mean “the.” Your job here is simply to recognize the pair and connect each form to its label.

What to know first

- *bien* / *bueno* — you saw *bueno* change to *buena*; this lesson explains the gender that made it happen.

Sounds you'll need

- vowel-e, vowel-a — two clean vowels: *el* (*ehl*), *la* (*lah*). → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el — “the” (masculine). **la** — “the” (feminine). English has one word, “the”; Spanish makes this two-way distinction.

Where they come from. Both are worn-down Latin **demonstratives** — words that meant “**that one (over there)**”:

- **el** ← Latin **ille** (“that one,” masculine).
- **la** ← Latin **illa** (“that one,” feminine).

Over centuries the pointing force faded and the initial *i*- dropped: *ille* → *el*, *illa* → *la*. What began as “that one” softened into a plain “the.” The same *ille/illa* spread across the whole family — French *le/la*, Italian *il/la* — every Romance “the” is eroded Latin “that.”

The twin thread. Those *same* Latin words, *ille/illa*, also became Spanish **él** (“he”) and **ella** (“she”). So the article *el* (“the”) and the pronoun *él* (“he”) are twins from one Latin parent — told apart only by the accent. (English “the,” by contrast, is Germanic and *unrelated* — a shared job, not a shared root.)

What you've built

el and *la* are **articles**: little words that mark “the.” Keep them apart from their accented relatives *él* and *ella*, the pronouns “he” and “she.” The next micro-lesson explains why Spanish needs two article forms.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el” then “la” — the two “the”s
- which article goes with a masculine noun? with a feminine one?

Before you move on

Which form is labelled masculine? (*el*.) Which is labelled feminine? (*la*.) Both come from Latin words meaning what? (“That one” — *ille* / *illa*.)

1.4 Grammatical gender — the two noun classes behind *el* and *la*

You know that *el* and *la* both mean “the.” Now give their two labels: *el* is masculine; *la* is feminine.

What to know first

- *el* / *la* — the two definite articles.

Grammar Lens: grammatical gender

Every Spanish noun belongs to one of two **grammatical classes**, traditionally called masculine and feminine. This is not a claim about biological sex. It is a matching system: a masculine noun uses *el*; a feminine noun uses *la*.

Latin had masculine, feminine, and neuter classes. Spanish reduced that three-way system to two, with most old neuter nouns joining the masculine class. The word *gender* itself comes through Latin *genus*, “kind” or “class.”

You cannot always predict a noun’s class from its ending. Learn each new noun with its article, as one small unit: *el* + *noun* or *la* + *noun*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the article for a noun labelled masculine
- the article for a noun labelled feminine
- what grammatical gender classifies — nouns, not people

Before you move on

How many noun classes did Latin have? (Three.) How many does Spanish keep? (Two.) What should travel with every new noun you learn? (Its article, *el* or *la*.)

1.5 día — your first noun

You just learned how Spanish tags gender with *el* / *la*. Now put it to work on your very first noun — *día*, “day.”

What to know first

- *el* / *la* — grammatical gender and the two “the”s; *día* is where you apply them.

Sounds you’ll need

- **accent-i** — the accent sits on the **í**: *día* is *DEE-a*, two beats. → reference
- **d-soft** — the **d** between vowels is soft, toward the *th* in *this*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el día — “the day.” Root: Latin **dies** (“day”). The family fans across English, mostly through French:

- **diary**, **diurnal** (“of the day”).
- **journal**, **journey** — French *jour*, “a day” (a *journey* was once “a day’s travel”).
- **quodidian** (“every-day”), **meridian** (“mid-day”), and *dismal* (*dies mali*, “evil days”).

Its two tags: gender and number

You already know gender from the last lesson; here’s how *día* wears it. **Gender.** *día* is **masculine** — *el día* — which is a small surprise, because it ends in *-a*, the ending that usually signals feminine. Why the exception? Because Latin *dies* was masculine, and *día* inherited that

gender whole, spelling be damned. (This is exactly why gender must be learned *with* the word, not guessed from the ending — and it’s the first of several “-a-but-masculine” nouns you’ll meet.)

Number. One rule for now: a noun ending in a vowel adds **-s**. *día* → *días* (“days”). (Consonant endings take *-es* — later.)

Grammar Lens: why the gender matters next

Gender isn’t a passive label — it *forces* the words around the noun to match. The very next lesson, *buenos días*, turns *bueno* (“good”) into *buenos* precisely because *día* is masculine and plural. So the gender you just attached to *día* is about to earn its keep.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el día” — with its masculine “the”
- “días” — plural, vowel + *-s*
- is *día* masculine or feminine, and why? (masculine — from Latin *dies*, despite the *-a*)

Before you move on

Which “the” goes with *día*, and why? (*el* — masculine, inherited from Latin *dies*, despite the *-a* ending.) How do you make it plural? (*días* — vowel + *-s*.)

1.6 buenos días — the greeting you say before noon

You can already greet someone at any hour with *hola*. Now the one you use in the morning — the greeting everyone knows.

What to know first

- *día* — the word *day*, which you have already met.

Sounds you'll need

- **diphthong-ue** — **ue** is a quick *WEH*: *bueno* is *BWEH-no*.
- **accent-i** — *días* keeps its stress on the *í*: *DEE-as*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

buenos días is, word for word, “**good days**” — plural, and nobody knows quite why the plural stuck. Spanish says it in the plural and always has.

Take it whole. It is one thing you say, not two things you assemble: *buenos días*, said as a single run, the way English says *good morning* without stopping to think about *good* or *morning*.

The shape of it — why *buenos* and not *bueno* — is a real rule, and a useful one. It is also not the rule you need in order to say hello before lunch. It comes later, once you have enough words for it to be worth explaining.

Why it's said this way

So why “good **days**,” plural at all? Because *buenos días* is a **fossil** — the worn-down stub of a blessing: “**Buenos días os dé Dios**,” “*may God give you good days*.” You weren’t wishing one good morning; you were asking heaven for many good days ahead. The plural is the last bone of that prayer — and it’s why *buenos días* feels warm and a little formal, where *hola* is casual. It is, almost literally, a small *benediction* (the *bien* lesson’s word). (*A widely-accepted account; exact history debated.*)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- build it slowly — “bueno” ... “días” ... “buenos días”
- “hola, buenos días” — casual + warm, stacked
- why is it *buenos*, not *bueno*? (out loud, in your own words)

Before you move on

Two things: why is it *buenos* and not *bueno*? (Agreement — *días* is masculine plural.) And what blessing was *buenos días* shortened from? (“May God give you good days.”)

1.7 Practice — hola and buenos días

End of the chapter. No new words — just the four you have, turned over until they’re automatic.

What you’ve built

In four short lessons you went from nothing to two full greetings and the first two rules of Spanish grammar:

- **hola** — the casual “hi.”
- **bien** — “well/good,” a complete answer on its own; and its adjective sibling **bueno** / **buena**.
- **día** → **días** — a noun, and the plural rule (vowel + -s).
- **buenos días** — assembled from *bueno* + *días*, with **agreement** turning *bueno* into *buenos* to match.

Your turn

Say each out loud; don’t just read.

Say these aloud:

- greet a friend casually — *hola*
- greet someone warmly in the morning — *buenos días*
- stack them — *hola, buenos días*
- answer “how are you” with one word — *bien*
- the four shapes of “good” — *bueno, buena, buenos, buenas* — and for each, is it masculine/feminine, singular/plural?

Twice through: Build *buenos días* from scratch, out loud: *bueno* → agree with masculine-plural *días* → *buenos días*. Do it until the “why” feels obvious, not memorized.

Before you move on

You can now greet two ways and give a one-word positive answer. The very next question is the one that opens a real conversation: when *someone else* says *buenos días* to you — **what do you say back?** That’s the whole next chapter, and it’s where these words start turning into an exchange.

Chapter 2

The Rest of the Greetings

Modes: 🗣️ voice (6) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 6 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can greet someone correctly at any hour — morning, afternoon or night — and say why the greeting changes shape.

The same greeting exchange run three times across the day, choosing the right form for each hour.

2.1 tarde — “afternoon,” and the “late” hiding inside it

You built *buenos días*. The afternoon greeting is coming, but first its key word on its own — *tarde* — and it’s secretly a word you already know from English.

What to know first

- buenos días — you’ll pair *tarde* with *buena* the same way you paired *días* with *bueno*.

Sounds you’ll need

- Regular stress: *TAR-de* — ends in a vowel, so the stress falls on the second-to-last syllable. → reference

la tarde (feminine) — “afternoon.” Root: Latin **tardus** — which did *not* mean afternoon. It meant “**slow, late.**” And *that* is the meaning English kept:

- **tardy** — late.
- **retard** — to slow down (literally “to make late”).
- **tardigrade** — “slow-stepper,” the real name of the little water-bear that plods under a microscope.

How did “late” become “afternoon”? Naturally — the afternoon *is* the late part of the day, the day growing old. Spanish took the Latin word for “late” and let it drift to name the lateness itself. Say *tarde* and you’re calling it “the late hours.”

Its gender: *tarde* is **feminine** — *la tarde*, not *el tarde*. (Contrast *el día* from the last lesson: your first masculine and feminine nouns, side by side.) Learn each noun *with* its *el/la*, because gender isn’t reliably guessable — and it will decide the shape of every word that describes the noun, starting next lesson.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “tarde” — *TAR-de*
- “tarde” then English “tardy” — hear the shared root
- “tardes” — plural, add *-s* (vowel ending), just like *día* → *días*

Before you move on

What did Latin *tardus* originally mean, before “afternoon”? (Slow, late — as in *tardy*, *retard*.) And how do you make *tarde* plural? (*tardes* — vowel + *-s*.)

2.2 buenas tardes — assembled, and now the *feminine* side of agreement

Same move as *buenos días*: take “good” and “afternoon” and snap them together. But watch the ending — this time it comes out *buenas*, and that difference teaches you the other half of the agreement rule.

What to know first

- bien / bueno — the adjective *bueno* and its four shapes.
- tarde — the noun *tardes*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

buenas tardes = **buena** (“good”) + **tardes** (“afternoons”) = literally “good afternoons.”

Why it’s said this way

Buenos días in the morning; **buenas tardes** in the afternoon. The ending changes, and there is a reason for it — the same reason that comes later, with the rest of the pattern. For now: two greetings, two shapes, both said whole.

Why it’s said this way

Same fossil blessing as the morning greeting: *buenas tardes* is short for “*Buenas tardes os dé Dios.*” One cultural note on timing — *tardes* runs from after the midday meal until it’s genuinely dark, which in much of the Spanish-speaking world is late. Spanish follows the daylight, not the clock; there’s no fixed “12:00 = afternoon” line.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “buenas tardes” — *BWEH-nas TAR-des*
- “buenos días” then “buenas tardes” — hear the *o* flip to *a*
- why *buenas* and not *buenos*? (out loud, your own words)

Before you move on

Why is it *buenas tardes* but *buenos días*? (*tarde* is feminine, *día* is masculine — the adjective agrees with each.)

2.3 noche — “night,” and a Latin sound-change you can now spot

The last time-of-day word before the evening greeting. *noche* — “night” — and it shows off a spelling pattern that will help you decode dozens of Spanish words later.

What to know first

- *tarde* — same build ahead: word first, then *buenas* + it.

Sounds you’ll need

- **soft-c** — the **ch** in *noche* is the *ch* of English *church*: *NO-cheh*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

la noche (feminine) — “night / evening.” Root: Latin **nox**, stem **noct-** — which was itself *feminine* in Latin, and *la noche* inherited that gender straight down (just as *el día* inherited its masculine from Latin). That *noct-* runs all through English:

- **nocturnal** — active at night.
- **nocturne** — a piece of night-music.
- **equinox** — *equi* (“equal”) + *nox*, the day when night and day are equal length.

A pattern worth banking: Latin *noctem* → Spanish *noche*. The Latin **-ct-** softened into Spanish **-ch-**. This happened again and again: *factum* → *hecho* (“done”), *lactem* → *leche* (“milk”), *octo* → *ocho* (“eight”). Once you know *-ct-* → *-ch-*, you can often guess the Latin root (and its English cousins) behind a Spanish *-ch-* word on sight.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “noche” — *NO-cheh*
- “noche” then “nocturnal” then “equinox”

- “noches” — plural, vowel + -s

Before you move on

What English word is *equi-* + *noche*’s root? (*Equinox*, “equal night.”)
And what Latin sound did the *-ch-* in *noche* come from? (*-ct-*, as in *noctem* → *noche*.)

2.4 buenas noches — good evening *and* good night

The fourth greeting, assembled the way you now expect — and it has one quirk the others don’t: it works both coming and going.

What to know first

- buenas tardes — feminine agreement (*buenas*); *noche* is feminine too, so the same shape applies.
- noche — the noun *noches*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

buenas noches = **buena** (“good”) + **noches** (“nights”). *noche* is **feminine** (*la noche*), plural here, so — exactly like *tardes* — the adjective is **buenas**. No new rule; you’re now just *fluent* in the agreement you learned two lessons ago: masculine *días* → *buenos*, feminine *tardes/noches* → *buenas*.

Why it’s said this way

The same amputated blessing (“*Buenas noches os dé Dios*”) — but with a twist. *buenas noches* is both a **greeting** and a **farewell**:

- Arriving at a dinner at 9pm → *buenas noches* (“good evening”).
- Leaving that same dinner at midnight → *buenas noches* (“goodnight”).

English splits these into two phrases; Spanish uses one and lets context tell you the direction. The blessing doesn’t care which way you’re going — you’re wishing good hours either way.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “buenas noches” arriving somewhere
- “buenas noches” leaving somewhere
- all four times of day — “buenos días, buenas tardes, buenas noches” — and notice which take *buenos* vs *buenas* and why

Before you move on

What’s unusual about when you can use *buenas noches*? (Both hello and goodbye.) And why *buenas*, not *buenos*? (*noche* is feminine.)

2.5 buenos or buenas — the rule you have been using all along

Say all three greetings, in order through the day: *buenos días*, *buenas tardes*, *buenas noches*.

You have been saying them for two chapters without being told why the first one differs. Now it is worth knowing.

What to know first

Two things you already have:

- Every Spanish noun is **masculine or feminine**. *Día* is masculine; *tarde* and *noche* are feminine.
- Adding **-s** makes a noun plural: *días*, *tardes*, *noches*.

Grammar Lens: the describing word copies the noun

In Spanish a describing word **copies** the noun it sits next to — it matches both the masculine-or-feminine and the one-or-many. *Bueno* is the describing word in all three greetings. It copies:

- *días* is masculine and plural, so *bueno* becomes **buenos**.
- *tardes* is feminine and plural, so *bueno* becomes **buenas**.

- *noches* is feminine and plural, so again **buenas**.

That is the whole rule. One word changing its last letter to agree with the word beside it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The **-o** and the **-a** are old. Latin marked masculine with *-us* and feminine with *-a*: *bonus* and *bona*, “good.” Spanish wore *bonus* down to *bueno* and kept *bona* as *buenas*, and the two endings have been doing this same job for two thousand years.

English lost this entirely. *Good* is *good*, whatever it sits beside.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “buenos días” — and say why it is *buenos*: *días* is masculine.
- “buenas tardes” — and why *buenas*: *tardes* is feminine.
- all three in order, morning to night.

Before you move on

Why *buenos días* but *buenas tardes*? (*Día* is masculine, *tarde* is feminine, and the describing word copies the noun.) Which Latin endings are hiding in *-o* and *-a*? (*-us* and *-a*.) Does English do this? (No — *good* never changes.)

2.6 Practice — the four greetings

You can now greet at any hour of the day. Let’s make the choice — and the grammar behind it — automatic.

What you’ve built

- **hola** — any time, casual.
- **buenos días** — morning (*días* masculine → *buenos*).
- **buenas tardes** — afternoon (*tarde* feminine → *buenas*).

- **buenas noches** — evening *and* goodnight (*noche* feminine → *buenas*).

The one grammar thread running through all of them: **agreement**. The “good” word copies the gender of the time-of-day word. That’s why it’s *buenos* días but *buenas* tardes and *buenas* noches.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- greet for the actual current time of day, correctly
- all three “buenos/buenas” greetings in a row; for each, say whether the noun is masculine or feminine and why the ending fits
- “hola, buenas tardes” — casual + timed, stacked

Twice through: Run morning → afternoon → night, out loud, without hesitating on *buenos* vs *buenas*.

Before you move on

Quick: is it *buenos* or *buenas* noches, and why? (*buenas* — *noche* is feminine.) Next chapter, someone finally greets *you* back — and you learn to say your name and ask for theirs.

Chapter 3

Saying Your Name

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say my own name in Spanish.

Saying Your Name — the chapter run end to end.

3.1 me — your first pronoun, and a *real* English twin

A tiny word doing big work. *me* is your first **pronoun** — and unlike *hola*, its English look-alike is the real thing: a true cousin, not a coincidence.

Sounds you'll need

- vowel-**e** — one clean syllable, *meh* (the *e* of *bed*).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

me — “me / myself.” Root: Latin **me** (the object form of *ego*, “I”). Here’s the satisfying part: English **me** is a **genuine cousin**, not a false friend. Spanish *me* comes from Latin *me*; English *me* comes from Proto-Germanic — but both trace back to the *same* ancient ancestor (the Proto-Indo-European root *me-*, “me”). So do English **my** and **mine**. This is the opposite of the *hola/hello* trap you saw earlier: here the resemblance is real, and you can lean on it hard. Spanish *me* = English *me*, all the way down.

Grammar Lens: what a pronoun is

A **pronoun** is a stand-in word that points to a person or thing without naming them — *I, you, he, me, it*. *me* specifically is an **object** pronoun: it marks the person the action lands on (“call *me*”, “give *me*”). In Spanish it usually sits **right before the verb** — you’ll see it next lesson in *me llamo*, literally “myself I-call.” For now, just hold *me* = “me / myself.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “me” — *meh*
- “me” then English “me”, “my”, “mine” — all one family

Before you move on

Is Spanish *me* a true cousin of English *me*, or a coincidence like *hola/hello*? (A true cousin — both from the same ancient root.) What part of speech is it? (A pronoun.)

3.2 llamo — “I call,” from a root that shouts

The verb inside “my name is.” On its own it means “to call” — and its Latin root literally means *to shout*, which is why it echoes through a whole family of English words.

What to know first

- me — you’ll bolt *me* onto *llamo* next lesson.

Sounds you’ll need

- ll-y — ll sounds like English y: *llamo* is *YA-mo*, not *LA-mo*. → reference

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

llamo — “I call.” The dictionary form (the infinitive) is **llamar**, “to call.” Root: Latin **clamare**, “to cry out, to shout.” That *clam-* shouts all through English:

- **exclaim**, **exclamation** — *ex-* (“out”) + *clamare*: to shout **out**.
- **proclaim**, **proclamation** — *pro-* (“forth”): to call **forth**.
- **acclaim** — *ad-* (“toward”): to shout praise toward.
- **claim**, **reclaim**, **disclaim**; and **clamor**, borrowed whole.

A sound-pattern to bank: Latin *cl-* became Spanish *ll-*. *clamare* → *llamar*. It happened repeatedly: *clavem* → *llave* (“key”), *flamma* → *llama* (“flame”), *plovere* → *llover* (“to rain”). A Spanish word starting *ll-* is very often a Latin *cl-/fl-/pl-* word in disguise — and its English cousin usually kept the original cluster (*clamor*, *flame*, *pluvial*).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “llamo” — *YA-mo*
- “llamo” then “exclaim”, “proclaim”, “clamor” — the shouting root
- “llamar” (to call), “llave” (key) — both from Latin *cl-*

Before you move on

What does the root *clamare* mean? (To shout / cry out.) Latin *cl-* becomes which two letters in Spanish? (*ll-* — *clamare* → *llamar*.)

3.3 me llamo — “I call myself”

Snap the last two lessons together — *me* + *llamo* — and you can introduce yourself. But notice Spanish doesn’t say “my name is” at all.

What to know first

- me · llamo

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

me llamo = **me** (“myself”) + **llamo** (“I call”) = literally “**I call myself.**” Then the name: *Me llamo Susana* — “I call myself Susan.”

Grammar Lens: reflexive verbs

When the action loops back onto the person doing it — you call *yourself* — the verb is **reflexive**, and Spanish marks it with that little pronoun in front: *me* (“myself”). *llamo* alone is “I call [someone else]”; *me llamo* is “I call **myself.**” English can do this (“I call myself Sam”) but usually doesn’t bother, flattening it to “my name is.” Spanish keeps the reflexive loop visible.

This matters because the pronoun **changes with the person**: *me llamo* (I call myself) → *te llamas* (you-informal call yourself) → *se llama* (he/she/you-formal calls himself). You’ll meet *te* and *se* in a few lessons; for now, lock in *me llamo* for yourself.

Why it’s said this way

Spanish presents your name not as a thing you *have* (“my name is”) but as what you *do* — what you call yourself. It’s subtly more active, and it’s the completely standard, neutral way to introduce yourself.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “me llamo” + your own name
- “hola, me llamo ____” — greeting + introduction
- what does *me llamo* literally mean, word for word?

Before you move on

Literally, what is *me llamo*? (“I call myself.”) What makes it reflexive? (The *me* — the action loops back on you.)

3.4 Saying your name — putting it together

Three lessons became one sentence. Say it to a stranger. Nothing new in this lesson — only what you already have.

The exchange

— Hola. **Me llamo** Susana. — Me llamo David.

What you've built

You can now put your own name into Spanish, which is the first thing anyone will ask you for.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole exchange, both parts, without stopping
- it again, faster, and let it sound like speech rather than recital

Twice through:

Before you move on

Run it once more from memory. If a word does not come, go back one lesson rather than pushing on — this chapter is short on purpose.

Chapter 4

The Three Words for You

Modes: 🔄 voice (5) 🔄 Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can choose between tú and usted, and recognise vos.

The Three Words for You — the chapter run end to end.

4.1 tú and usted — two of the three words Spanish says to one person

English has one word for “you.” Spanish has three for speaking to one person, and today you get two of them — the two you will use yourself. What the choice *means* socially, and the odd grammar *usted* drags along with it, comes next. The third word comes shortly after, and you will only ever need to recognise it.

The two words

tú — “you,” **informal**. For friends, family, children, peers, anyone you are on easy terms with.

Root: Latin **tū**. This is a **true cousin** of English **thou** — the word English used to have for exactly this job, the intimate “you” (*thou/thee/thy*), before it faded out around 400 years ago. Both *tú* and *thou* come straight from the same ancient root (*tu-*). So Spanish still uses, every day, the pronoun English quietly retired.

usted — “you,” **formal**. For strangers, elders, officials, customers, anyone you are showing respect or keeping distance with.

Both are the “doer” word — the one that says who is acting, like *yo* (“I”). Say them enough times that they come out without hunting: *tú*, one syllable with the accent; *usted*, stress on the second, with a very soft final *d*.

Not the whole story, and you should know that now.

Across Argentina, Uruguay, Paraguay, most of Central America and parts of Colombia, the everyday informal “you” is a *third* word — not *tú* at all. That is well over a hundred million people. You are learning *tú* because it is understood everywhere, and you will meet the third word shortly, only to recognise.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*tú*” — for a close friend
- “*usted*” — for someone you’d address respectfully
- “*tú*” then English “*thou*” — the retired twin

Before you move on

Which is formal, *tú* or *usted*? (*Usted*.) What English pronoun is the lost twin of *tú*, and what happened to it? (*Thou* — it faded out of English around 400 years ago.) How many words does Spanish have for “you,” and how many will you say yourself? (*Three, for one person; two*.) Next: what picking one of them tells your listener.

4.2 *tú or usted* — a choice you have to make every time

You have both words. Now the hard part: Spanish makes you **choose** one every time you speak to someone, and the choice is never neutral.

What to know first

- *tú* / *usted* — the two words themselves.

Why it's said this way

Tú and *usted* do not differ in **meaning** — both are “you,” singular, one person. They differ in **register**: the social distance you are claiming.

you say

tú

usted

you are signalling

closeness, equality, ease

respect, deference, distance

English used to carry this too, with *thou* against *you* — and when *thou* died, English lost the ability to say it at all. One-size-fits-all “you” means an English speaker never has to decide. A Spanish speaker decides every single time, and getting it wrong is not a grammar mistake but a **social** one: *tú* to a stranger can read as presumptuous, *usted* to a friend as cold.

The safe default when you cannot tell: **usted**. Over-formal is recoverable; over-familiar is awkward.

Grammar Lens: *usted* takes he/she forms

One structural surprise, because it shapes every lesson after this: ***usted* takes the *he/she* verb forms, not the informal “you” forms.**

That is why “what’s your name?” formally is *¿cómo se llama usted?* — using the *se llama* you would otherwise use for “he calls himself” — and not *te llamas*. Grammatically, *usted* behaves as though you were talking **about** the person rather than **to** them. That is a fossil of where the word came from, and the next lesson digs it up.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “tú” and name someone you would use it with
- “usted” and name someone you would use it with
- which verb pattern *usted* takes — the he/she one

Before you move on

Do *tú* and *usted* differ in meaning or in register? (**Register** — both mean “you”; they signal closeness versus respect.) Which do you pick when unsure? (**Usted.**) Which verb forms does *usted* take? (The

same forms used with **he** or **she**.)

4.3 vos — the third “you,” and you only have to recognise it

Two words so far. Which one do you use with a friend? (*Tú*.)
Which one keeps a respectful distance? (*Usted*.)

What to know first

vos — “you,” informal. It does the same job as *tú*.

Where it lives, in part: Argentina, Uruguay and Paraguay, and most of Central America. It is also alive in Chile, and in parts of Colombia and Bolivia — this list is not the whole map. Counting only the places named, that is **well over a hundred million people** for whom *vos*, not *tú*, is the ordinary word to a friend.

You are learning *tú* because it is understood everywhere, those places included. But a course that never mentioned *vos* would be teaching you a Spanish nobody speaks in Buenos Aires.

What you owe this word. Recognition, nothing more. Hear **vos**, think *tú*. Its endings differ a little, and you will meet that where you meet the endings themselves — not before.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Vos is Latin **vōs** — and Latin **vōs** was the **plural** “you.” The word Romans used for a group.

How does a plural become the word for one friend? By politeness. Addressing someone as though they were several made them bigger. The courtesy wore off, and across much of the Americas the word slid into *tú*’s place.

English began the same way and ended in the opposite place.

You met *thou* earlier in this chapter. What retired it was **you** — a *plural*, used to one person out of politeness, exactly as Spanish used *vos*. But English’s polite plural won and spread until it was the only word left; standard English now has no separate singular at all. Spanish’s *vos* went the other way — it *lost* the polite job and dropped into the intimate one.

Same start, opposite ends. And what took the polite job away from *vos* is the very next lesson.

Your turn

Recognition only — nothing to produce here.

- [YOU HEAR: “vos”] → think: *tú*. A friend, an equal, someone at ease with you.
- [YOU HEAR: “usted”] → think: distance, or respect.
- [YOU SAY: “tú”] — still your word, everywhere you go.

Before you move on

How many words does Spanish have for “you” when speaking to **one** person? (*Three.*) Which do you say? (*Tú* — and *usted* for distance.) Name a country where *vos* is the everyday word. (*Argentina, Uruguay, Nicaragua...*) What was Latin *vōs* originally? (*The plural “you.”*)

4.4 *vuestra merced* → *usted* — respect compressed into one word

You use *usted* for respectful “you,” and it takes the same verb form as “he” or “she.” That surprising grammar preserves the word’s history.

What to know first

- *tú* / *usted* — the informal and formal choices.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

usted wore down from **vuestra merced**, “your grace” or “your mercy.” *Vuestra* comes from Latin *vestra*, “your.” *Merced* comes from Latin *merces*, *mercedem*, “wages, reward, favor.” The *merc-* root links **mercy**, **mercenary**, **commerce**, **merchant**, and **merchandise**. A respectful title was repeated so often that two words

compressed into one pronoun. Its older abbreviation **Vd.** still preserves the *v* of *vuestra*.

Why it's said this way

A title like “your grace” refers to a respected person in the third person. That is why modern *usted* still takes the he/she verb form even while it means “you.” The social history remains visible in the grammar.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the two-word title that became *usted*
- “usted” followed by “mercy” and “merchant” — the *merc-* family
- which verb pattern *usted* takes

Before you move on

What did *vuestra merced* mean? (“Your grace” or “your mercy.”) Why does *usted* take the he/she verb form? (It began as a third-person title.) And the third “you” you met last lesson — which is it, and do you say it or just know it? (*Vos*; you recognise it, and keep saying *tú*.)

4.5 Choosing your “you” — putting it together

Three words, one choice, and it is social rather than grammatical. Nothing new in this lesson — only what you already have.

The exchange

To a friend: **tú**. To a stranger, an elder, an official: **usted**. Heard across the Southern Cone and Central America: **vos** — understand it, keep saying *tú*.

What you've built

You know which word to reach for, and why *usted* takes the shape it does.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole exchange, both parts, without stopping
- it again, faster, and let it sound like speech rather than recital

Twice through:

Before you move on

Run it once more from memory. If a word does not come, go back one lesson rather than pushing on — this chapter is short on purpose.

Chapter 5

Asking Someone's Name

Modes: 🗣️ voice (6) 👁️ eyes (1) ✍️ pen (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 1 of 8 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask someone's name in either register and say it was a pleasure.

Asking Someone's Name — the chapter run end to end.

5.1 cómo — “how,” your first question word

To ask someone's name or how they are, you need this word first.

Cómo — “how” — and hiding inside it is a little Latin word for “manner” that you already own a dozen English versions of.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

cómo — “how.” Root: Latin **quo modo** — not a word but a **two-word phrase**, “in what **manner**.”

The two halves, and their English cousins:

- *modo* (“manner, measure”) → English **mode**, **modal**, **model**, **moderate**, **modify**, commodity.
- *quo* (“in what”) is the Latin question-stem **qu-**, the seed of nearly every Spanish question word.

How the phrase became one word — the wearing-down. Spanish did not borrow *cómo* ready-made; it **eroded** out of *quo modo* over

centuries of everyday speech. The final *-do* fell off and the middle collapsed:

quomodo → *quomo* → **como**

The *qu-* (a *kw* sound) flattened to a plain *k*, written *c* before *o*. What is left is a whole Latin phrase worn smooth — the way a pebble loses its edges in a river. The same erosion gave Italian *come*, Portuguese *como*, French *comme*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “cómo” — *CÓ-mo*, stress on the first syllable
- “cómo” then English “mode”, “model” — the *modo* root
- the erosion — “quo modo, quomo, como”

Before you move on

What does *cómo* mean? (“How.”) Walk the erosion: *quo modo* → ? → *cómo*. (*Quomo* → *como*.) What did the two Latin halves mean? (*Quo*, “in what”; *modo*, “manner” — the root of English *mode* and *model*.) Next: the two marks Spanish puts on a question.

5.2 ¿cómo? — the two marks that say “this is a question”

You have the word *cómo*. Written down, it wears **two** marks that English has no equivalent for — and neither of them is decoration. Both do a job English leaves to word order and guesswork.

What to know first

- *cómo* — the word itself, and where it came from.

Script — the upside-down opener

Spanish questions open with an upside-down ¿ and close with a normal ?:
¿cómo?

Why? Spanish word order often does not change in a question — *cómo estás* looks the same whether you are asking or reporting. A reader coming to a long sentence would not know to raise their pitch until they hit the mark at the very end, by which time it is too late. The ¿ is a piece of engineering: it tells your voice, in advance, what shape the sentence has. Only the **question part** gets bracketed, not necessarily the whole line.

Grammar Lens: the accent that marks a question

Now watch the accent mark do real work:

written	means
cómo	“how?” — the question word
como	“like / as” — or “I eat”

Same letters, same sound. The written accent is the **only** thing marking the difference:

- ¿*Cómo* estás? — “**How** are you?”
- *Como* tú. — “Like you.” / *Yo como*. — “I eat.”

Every question word you will meet — *qué, dónde, cuándo, quién* — carries this accent for exactly this reason. It is not about stress (the stress is the same either way); it is a flag that says “**asking.**”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “¿cómo?” — with question intonation, opening high
- the pair — “cómo” (how?) then “como” (like / I eat)

Before you move on

Why does Spanish open a question with ¿? (Word order often does not change, so the reader needs the warning **before** the sentence, not after.) What changes when the accent disappears from *cómo*? (It stops being the question word — *como* means “like / as,” or “I eat.”)

5.3 The *qu-* question family — one ancient pattern, many clues

You traced *cómo* back to Latin *quomodo*. Focus now on its first piece, *qu-*, without trying to use a whole set of new question words yet.

What to know first

- *cómo* — “how,” from Latin *quomodo*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin used a recurring *qu-* stem in questions. Spanish preserves that family, although centuries of sound change gave the modern forms different shapes:

Spanish clue	← Latin	future meaning
<i>qué</i>	<i>quid</i>	what
<i>quién</i>	<i>quem</i>	who
<i>cuál</i>	<i>qualis</i>	which
<i>cuándo</i>	<i>quando</i>	when
<i>cuánto</i>	<i>quantus</i>	how much
<i>cómo</i>	<i>quomodo</i>	how

These are previews, not vocabulary to produce today. For now, use the family only as an etymological clue: a question form beginning *qu-* or *cu-* may continue the same Latin pattern. *Dónde*, “where,” is an exception from Latin *de unde*, “from where.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the Latin source of *cómo*
- the recurring Latin question stem
- whether the table is today’s production list or a preview

Before you move on

Which old stem connects *qué*, *quién*, *cuándo*, and *cómo*? (*qu-*)
Which word in the preview is the exception? (*Dónde*.)

5.4 se llama — the reflexive that fits *usted*

You can say *me llamo* (“I call myself”). To ask someone *else* their name — especially formally, with *usted* — you need the version that loops back on *them*: *se llama*.

What to know first

- *me llamo* — the reflexive “I call myself.”
- *tú* / *usted* — and the key fact that *usted* takes *he/she* verb forms.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

se llama = **se** (“himself / herself / yourself-formal”) + **llama** (“calls”). So *se llama* = “he/she calls himself,” or — because *usted* uses third-person forms — “**you** (formal) call yourself.”

se — the reflexive pronoun for the third person (and for *usted*). Root: Latin *sē* (“himself, herself, itself”). That same *se-* — carrying the sense of “self / apart / aside” — is bolted onto a shelf of English words:

- **secede** — *se* + *cedere* (“go apart”).
- **seclude**, **segregate** (“apart from the flock”), **separate**.
- **seduce** — *se* + *ducere* (“lead aside”).
- **secure** — *se* + *cura* (“free from care”), **secret** (“set apart”).

Every one is something turned in on itself or set apart — the same idea as a reflexive looping the action back on the doer.

Grammar Lens: the reflexive pronoun changes with the person

The verb *llamar* stays, but the little reflexive word in front shifts to match *who* is doing the calling:

- **me** llamo — *I* call myself
- **te** llamas — *you (informal, tú)* call yourself
- **se** llama — *he / she / you (formal, usted)* calls himself/yourself

Three persons, three pronouns: *me / te / se*. That *se* is exactly why the formal “what’s your name?” is *¿cómo se llama usted?* — *usted*, born from “your grace,” politely takes the *he/she* shape.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “se llama” — *seh YA-ma*
- the set — “me llamo, te llamas, se llama”
- “se” then “secede”, “seclude”, “separate” — the set-apart root

Before you move on

Which reflexive goes with *usted* — *te* or *se*? (*se* — because *usted* takes third-person forms.) What’s the “self/apart” root inside *secede* and *separate*? (Latin *se-*.)

5.5 ¿cómo se llama usted? — assembling the question, and answering it

Everything you built this chapter clicks into one sentence: how to ask a stranger their name, and how to answer back. This is your first real two-way exchange.

What to know first

- cómo · se llama · usted

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

¿Cómo se llama usted? = *cómo* (“how”) + *se llama* (“do you-formal call yourself”) + *usted* (“you,” formal).

Literally: “**How do you call yourself?**” Spanish asks *how*, not *what*, for a name — you’re asking by what name a person goes, the manner they’re called.

The informal version, for a friend, swaps the reflexive and drops the formal pronoun: **¿Cómo te llamas?** (*te llamas*, from *tú*). Same question, two registers — exactly the *tú/usted* choice from earlier, now live in a real sentence:

- To a stranger, an elder, a customer → *¿Cómo se llama usted?*
- To a friend, a child, a peer → *¿Cómo te llamas?*

How to answer

You already have the answer from the *me llamo* lesson: **Me llamo** ____.

— *¿Cómo se llama usted?* — **Me llamo David.**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- ask a stranger their name — *¿cómo se llama usted?*
- ask a friend the same — *¿cómo te llamas?*
- the whole mini-exchange — ask, then answer with *me llamo* ____

Before you move on

Formal vs. informal “what’s your name”? (*¿Cómo se llama usted?* / *¿Cómo te llamas?*) Does Spanish literally ask “what” or “how” is your name? (“How” — *cómo*.)

5.6 mucho — “much,” and a sound-change you’ve already seen

One more word before “pleased to meet you.” *mucho* — “much, a lot” — and it hides the same Latin-to-Spanish sound trick you spotted in *noche*.

Sounds you'll need

- **soft-c** — the **ch** is the *ch* of *church*: *MOO-cho*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

mucho — “much, a lot.” Root: Latin **multus** (“much, many”). The English cousins keep the original *-lt-*:

- **multiple**, **multitude**, **multiply**, **multi-purpose**, **multimedia**.

The sound-change, again: Latin *multum* → Spanish *mucho*. The Latin **-lt-** softened into Spanish **-ch-** — the very same move as *noctem* → *noche* (*-ct-* → *-ch-*, as in the *noche* lesson). Spanish has a habit of melting these consonant clusters into *ch*. So a Spanish *-ch-* word very often points back to a Latin *-ct-* or *-lt-* root — and the English cousin usually preserves it (*nocturnal*, *multiple*).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mucho” — *MOO-cho*
- “mucho” then “multiple”, “multitude” — the *mult-* family
- “noche” and “mucho” — two words, same *-ch-* from a melted Latin cluster

Before you move on

mucho comes from Latin *multus* — what English words keep the *-lt-*? (multiple, multitude, multiply.) What Latin cluster melted into the *-ch-*? (*-lt-*, like *-ct-* did in *noche*.)

5.7 *gusto* → *mucho gusto* — “much pleasure”

The line you say when you shake someone’s hand. First the noun *gusto*, then snap *mucho* onto it, and you’ve got it.

What to know first

- mucho — “much,” about to modify *gusto*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el gusto (masculine) — “taste; pleasure, liking.” Root: Latin **gustus** (“a tasting, a taste”). The English cousins:

- **gustatory** — to do with the sense of taste.
- **disgust** — *dis-* (“not, opposite”) + *gust*: literally “**distaste**.”
- **gusto** — borrowed whole into English, meaning zest, relish, enjoyment.

False friend to flag: a *gust* of wind is **not** related — that one’s from Old Norse *gustr*. Same spelling, different root. Resemblance isn’t proof.

mucho gusto = *mucho* (“much”) + *gusto* (“pleasure”) = literally “**much pleasure**” — short for “it’s a great pleasure [to meet you].” *gusto* is masculine (*el gusto*), and *mucho* is in its plain masculine form to match it: another quiet piece of the agreement you’ve been building.

Why it’s said this way

Spanish greets a new acquaintance by naming the *pleasure* of it — “much pleasure” — where English names the *person* (“pleased to meet **you**”). The phrase works by itself, so this first exchange needs no extra reply formula.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “gusto” then “gusto” (English), “disgust”, “gustatory”
- “mucho gusto” — on meeting someone

Before you move on

What does *mucho gusto* literally mean? (“Much pleasure.”) Is *el gusto* masculine or feminine? (Masculine.) And the English cousin of *gusto* built from *dis-*? (*Disgust* — “distaste.”)

5.8 Practice — introducing yourself

Ten lessons of atoms now assemble into a real conversation. No new words — just the exchange, run both formally and informally until the *tú* / *usted* choice is automatic.

The exchange

Formal (a stranger, an elder, a customer):

— Buenos días. Me llamo Susana. **¿Cómo se llama usted?**
 — Me llamo David. **Mucho gusto.**

Informal (a friend, a peer): only two words change, and they’re the ones that carry the whole social difference:

— ¡Hola! Me llamo Susana. **¿Cómo te llamas?** — Me llamo David. Mucho gusto.

What you’ve built

- **me llamo** — introduce yourself (“I call myself”).
- **tú** / **usted** — the informal vs. formal “you,” and *why* (the retired *thou*; *usted* from “your grace”).
- **¿cómo te llamas?** / **¿cómo se llama usted?** — ask a name, in either register, the pronoun (*te* / *se*) tracking the choice.
- **mucho gusto** — “much pleasure,” pleased to meet you.

And one from two chapters back, because it is worth keeping warm: *buenos días* but *buenas tardes* — the describing word copies its noun.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the full *formal* exchange, both parts
- the same exchange *informally* — catch yourself on *se llama* → *te llamas*
- for a police officer, then your best friend — which “you” for each, and why?

Twice through: Run the formal version start to finish without stopping.

Before you move on

Which two words change between the formal and informal introduction? (*se llama usted* → *te llamas*.) Next chapter, you will learn how to ask how someone is doing.

Chapter 6

Thank You, Yes, and No

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can thank someone, answer when I am thanked, and say yes or no.

Thanks, the answer to thanks, and the two words that let you accept or decline.

6.1 sí — yes

The smallest useful word — and the accent on it is doing real work.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sí = **yes**. One syllable, said *see*.

The written accent is not decoration — it is the **whole difference** between two words:

- **sí** (with the accent) = **yes**
- **si** (no accent) = **if**

They sound almost identical, so Spanish uses the mark to tell them apart on the page: *Sí, si quieres* = “Yes, if you want.” Miss the accent and you’ve written “if” where you meant “yes.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sí is Latin **sīc**, “thus, so” — answering a question with “just so,” exactly the move Latin also made with **ita** (“thus” = yes, from the Latin yes/no lesson). Its Romance cousins kept the same root:

Latin <i>sīc</i>	→
Spanish	sí
Italian	sì
Portuguese	sim

French is the odd one out — it went a completely different way for “yes” (*oui*), which its own lesson tells. But say *sí*, *sì*, *sim* in a row and you hear one Latin word answering across three countries.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “sí” — *see*, and picture the accent
- the pair — “sí” (yes) vs “si” (if)
- the cousins — “sí, sì, sim” — all from Latin *sīc*

Before you move on

How do you say yes in Spanish? (**sí**.) What is the *only* difference between **sí** “yes” and **si** “if”? (The **written accent**.) What Latin word is *sí* from, and what did it mean? (**sīc** — “thus, so”.)

6.2 no — no / not

The easiest word yet — and it quietly does two jobs Spanish never splits apart.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

no = **no**. Said *noh*, a clean single vowel.

It is Latin **nōn** with almost nothing worn off — just the final consonant gone. Compare the family, all from the same *nōn*:

Latin <i>nōn</i>	→
Spanish	no
Italian	no
French	non

Why it's said this way

Here's the thing English splits and Spanish doesn't. English has “**no**” (the answer) and “**not**” (inside a sentence) — two different words. Spanish uses **no** for **both**:

- as the **answer**. Someone asks you something — anything at all — and this one syllable declines it. You do not need to understand the question to answer it, which is exactly why this word comes early.
- and later, as the word that turns a sentence around — but that needs a sentence first, so it waits until you have one. For now: **no** is how you decline, refuse, and disagree, which is most of what a beginner needs it for.

<!-- the negator sense is taught in chapter 14, where the learner has a verb -->

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “no” — *noh*
- “No.” — flat, once, the way you would decline a second coffee
- “Sí.” then “No.” — the two shortest complete answers in Spanish

Before you move on

How do you say no in Spanish? (**no**.) What Latin word is it from? (**nōn**.) Spanish *no* does the work of which **two** English words? (“**no**” the answer, and later the word for “not.”) Where does *no* go to negate a sentence? (**Right before the verb.**)

6.3 gracias — “thank you,” and a whole family of English words

You can now introduce yourself. The next exchange is *how are you?* — but every answer ends the same polite way, so we learn the courtesy word first: **gracias**.

Sounds you’ll need

- **vowel-a** — the clean *ah* of *father*, twice.
- **r-tap** — a single flicked *r* (not the English one, and not yet the rolled *rr*): the tongue taps once, like the middle of American *butter*.
- **ci-th-s** — the *ci* is a soft *s* in Latin America (**GRAH-syahs**) and a soft *th* in most of Spain (**GRAH-thyahs**). Either is correct — pick one.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

gracias is the plural of **gracia** (“grace, favour”), from Latin **grātia** — *favour freely given*. Saying *gracias* literally offers someone “graces,” i.e. good will in return for theirs.

That one Latin root **grātia** fans out across English — once you see it, you get a fistful of words for free:

- **grace, gracious, graceful** — the direct borrowings.
- **grateful, gratitude** — being *full of* grātia.
- **gratis, gratuity** — something given as a *favour* (for free, or a tip).
- **congratulate** — literally “to wish grace *together with* someone.”
- Italian **grazie**, French *grâces*, Portuguese *graças* — the whole Romance family kept grātia, even where everyday thanks went elsewhere (French says *merci*, Portuguese *obrigado*).

So *gracias* is not a word to memorize cold: it is **grace**, made plural and handed to another person.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “gracias” — *GRAH-syahs*, one soft tap on the *r*
- “gracias” then English “grace, grateful, gratitude” — one family

Before you move on

What everyday English word is *gracias* the plural of, at the root? (*Grace*.) So when you thank someone in Spanish, you are literally handing them — what? (Graces / favours.) Next: the little reply that closes the exchange, **de nada**.

6.4 de nada — “you’re welcome,” or “it was nothing”

Someone says **gracias**. You need the reply that closes the loop: **de nada** — literally “*of nothing*.” You’re waving the favour off as no trouble at all — the same move English makes with “*it’s nothing*” / “*no problem*.”

Sounds you’ll need

- **d-soft** — the *d* in *nada* is soft, almost the *th* of *this* (**NAH-thah**), not a hard English *d*. Spanish *d* between vowels always softens.
- **vowel-a** — three clean *ah* sounds: *deh NAH-thah*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **de** = “of / from” (Latin **dē**) — the same *de* hiding in English **depart**, **deduct**, **descend**.
- **nada** = “nothing.” And this is the beautiful part.

nada comes from Latin (**rēs**) **nāta** — “(a thing) *born*.” From *nāscī*, “to be born,” the same root as English **native**, **nature**, **natal**, **re-nais-sance** (re-birth). Latin speakers said *nōn est rēs nāta*, “there is not a born thing” — *not a single thing that ever came into being* — and over

centuries the emphatic *nāta* (“born thing”) wore down until **the word for ‘born thing’ became the word for ‘nothing’ itself.**

So the reply *de nada* literally says “**of [a] born-thing**” → “of nothing at all.” French did the identical trick with **rien** (“nothing”) — which is Latin **rem**, “a thing.” Two languages, same move: the word for *thing* collapses into the word for *nothing*.

Grammar Lens: the courtesy pair

gracias → *de nada* is a fixed **adjacency pair**: one turn expects the other. Learn them as a unit, the way English glues *thank you* → *you’re welcome*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “gracias” ... “de nada” — the full exchange, both voices
- “de nada” then English “native, nature, natal” — nada’s true family

Before you move on

nada (“nothing”) started life as the Latin word for a *born* — what? (A *thing* — *rēs nāta*, a born thing.) What English words share that “born” root? (Native, nature, natal, renaissance.) Next: the verb the whole “how are you?” question turns on — **estar**.

6.5 Thank you, yes, and no — putting it together

Two words that travel everywhere together. Nothing new in this lesson — only what you already have.

The exchange

— **Gracias.** — **De nada.**

And the two words that let you answer anything at all:

— ¿...? — **Sí.** / — **No.**

What you've built

You can thank someone, answer when you are thanked, and — for the first time — accept or decline. Until you have *sí* and *no*, every question anyone asks you is unanswerable.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole exchange, both parts, without stopping
- it again, faster, and let it sound like speech rather than recital

Twice through:

Before you move on

Run it once more from memory. If a word does not come, go back one lesson rather than pushing on — this chapter is short on purpose.

Chapter 7

How Are You

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask a stranger how they are.
Greeting plus the question that opens almost every conversation.

7.1 *estar* — “to be,” the *standing* kind

To ask *how are you?* Spanish needs a verb for **being**. Today just the verb itself and where it came from; how to use it, and its two forms, come next.

Sounds you’ll need

- **st-no-e** — Spanish never starts a word with a bare *st-*; it props it up with an *e*: *es-TAR*. (That reflex is why Spanish speakers say *e-Spain*, *e-student* — the same *e* that Latin *stāre* grew to become *estar*.)
- **r-tap** — the final *r* is one soft tap: *es-TAR*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

estar comes straight from Latin **stāre**, “to stand.” Hold onto that picture: it is the whole reason this verb behaves the way it does. How you are **standing** at this moment — well, tired, here, there — is a snapshot, not a permanent fact.

That root **stā-/sta-** is one of the most productive in English. *Estar*

hands you a large family for free:

- **stay, stand, stance, station, stable, stationary** — to stand or stay put.
- **state, status, statue, estate** — a way of *standing* (your state is how you stand).
- **constant, circumstance, substance** — “standing with / around / under.”

So *¿cómo estás?* is, at the root, “**how are you standing?**”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “estar” — *es-TAR*, with the little propping *e*
- “estar” then English “stay, state, status, stable” — all *standing*

Before you move on

Which Latin verb is *estar* — “to be” or “to stand”? (To **stand** — *stāre*.) Why does Spanish put an *e* on the front? (It never begins a word with bare *st*-.) Name two English cousins. (*Stay, state, status, stable, estate*...) Next: the two forms you will actually ask with.

7.2 estás / está — the two forms, and what they are for

Estar is “to stand.” Now put it to work. Two forms, one job: saying how somebody is **right now**.

What to know first

- *estar* — the verb and its Latin “to stand” root.
- *tú* or *usted* — why *usted* takes he/she forms.

Grammar Lens: state and location use *estar*

Use **estar** for a **current state** or a **location** — the two things that can change without changing what something *is*:

- a state: *estoy bien* — “I’m well” (today; maybe not tomorrow).
- a location: *está aquí* — “it’s here” (for now).

“How are you?” asks about a current state, so it takes *estar*. Spanish has a second be-verb for identity, and it arrives in its own later lesson; keeping it out of today’s drill lets one contrast settle at a time.

Grammar Lens: the two forms you need

you’re addressing	form	reads as
tú (informal)	estás	“you are”
usted (formal)	está	“you are”

Notice that **está** is also “he is / she is.” That is not a coincidence and not something extra to learn — it is the *usted*-takes-he/she-forms rule you already met, showing up for the first time in a real verb.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “estás” ... “está” — the two forms you’ll ask with
- which one goes with *tú*, which with *usted*
- a state, then a location — “estás bien”, “está aquí”

Before you move on

What two kinds of thing does *estar* cover? (**Current state** and **location**.) Which form goes with *tú*, and which with *usted*? (*Estás*; *está*.) Why is *está* also “he/she is”? (Because *usted* takes the **he/she** verb forms.) Next lesson, you finally ask it: **¿cómo está usted?**

7.3 ¿cómo está usted? — “how are you?”

Everything you’ve built this chapter now snaps together into one question. You already met **cómo** (“how”) and the **tú / usted** choice back in Chapter 3; you just learned **estar**. Assemble them.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

¿Cómo está usted? = “How are you?” (formal) literally:
“In what manner are you standing?”

- **cómo** = “how / in what manner”
- **está** = “you are” (the *usted*/he-she form of **estar** — state, not identity)
- **usted** = the formal “you”

Note the **¿** — Spanish opens a question with an upside-down mark so you know the melody is coming before you start reading aloud. (We take that mark apart in a dedicated writing lesson.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “¿Cómo está usted?” — formal, for a stranger
- the pieces — “cómo + está + usted”

Before you move on

Which be-verb does “how are you?” use — *ser* or *estar*, and why? (*estar* — it’s about your current state.) What changes between formal and informal? (**The next step changes the ending and pronoun.**) Next: choosing the register.

7.4 How are you — putting the question together

You have a second “to be” and the question it carries. Nothing new here — only what you already have.

The exchange

— Buenos días. **¿Cómo está usted?**

The answer is the next chapter. Asking is this one.

What you've built

You can ask a stranger how they are, which is the question that opens almost every conversation you will ever have in Spanish.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “¿Cómo está usted?” — to someone you have just met
- the greeting and the question together, as one breath

Twice through:

Before you move on

Which “to be” carries how someone is, and why? (*Estar* — a state, not an identity.) Ask the question once more from memory.

Chapter 8

Answering, and Handing It Back

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can answer how I am, choose my register, and return the question.

The answer, the register choice inside it, and handing the question back.

8.1 ¿cómo está usted? / ¿cómo estás? — choose the register

You can already ask a stranger **¿Cómo está usted?** Now change only the relationship: ask the same question of a friend.

Grammar Lens: one question, two relationships

register	question
formal (stranger, elder, customer)	¿Cómo está usted?
informal (friend, peer, child)	¿Cómo estás?

The formal version uses the third-person ending **está** plus **usted**. The informal version uses second-person **estás** and normally omits **tú**. This is the same relationship contrast you drilled with **se llama** / **te llamas**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- to a doctor you just met — “¿Cómo está usted?”
- to your cousin — “¿Cómo estás?”
- swap back and forth — “está usted / estás”

Twice through: Ask both versions until the ending swap is automatic.

Before you move on

Which version fits a stranger? (¿Cómo **está** usted?) Which fits a friend? (¿Cómo **estás**?) What two things change? (The **verb ending** and the **pronoun**.)

8.2 regular / más o menos — the honest “so-so”

You asked *¿cómo estás?* Now you can answer three ways: great, middling, or a wave of the hand. You already have **bien** (“well,” Chapter 1). Today, the *middling* answers — because nobody is *bien* every day.

What to know first

Recall from Chapter 1: **bien** — “well.” Root? (Latin *bene*, “well” — same as *benefit*, *benevolent*.) So *estoy bien* = “I’m well.” Now the answer for when you’re *not* quite bien.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

regular — as an answer to “how are you?”, it means “so-so, average, not great.” (A famous false-friend trap: it does **not** mean English “regular / normal / usual” here.) From Latin **rēgula**, a *straight rod* a builder used to check a line — the **ruler**. So *regular* is “on the rule, on the average line” → middling.

That *rēgula* rod is everywhere in English: **rule**, **ruler**, **regulate**, **regular**, **regiment**, and even **rail** (a straight rod). All the same straight stick.

más o menos — “more or less,” the shrug-answer:

- **más** = “more,” from Latin **magis** (“more”) — cousin of *major*, *master*, *maximum*.

- **menos** = “less,” from Latin **minus** — the very word English borrowed for *minus*, *minor*, *minimum*, *minuscule*.

So *más o menos* is literally “**more or less**” — the exact phrase, root for root, that English uses for the same shrug.

Grammar Lens: a small answer set

You now have a scale to answer *¿cómo estás?*:

answer	sense
(muy) bien	(very) well
regular	so-so
más o menos	more or less / meh

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “regular” — *reh-goo-LAR*, soft tap on both *r*’s
- “más o menos” — a little shrug in the voice
- answer “¿cómo estás?” three ways — bien / regular / más o menos

Before you move on

As an answer, does *regular* mean “normal” or “so-so”? (So-so — the false-friend trap.) What straight-rod Latin word is it from, and what English “rod” words share it? (*rēgula* → rule, ruler, regulate, rail.) Next: put the whole exchange together.

8.3 y / ¿y tú? — pass the question back

You can ask how someone is and answer. One tiny connector turns that exchange around so the other person gets a turn too.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Y means **and** and sounds like Spanish **i**: *ee*. It continues Latin **et**, also “and.” English borrowed that Latin word intact inside **et cetera**,

literally “and the rest.”

Grammar Lens: the shortest return question

Put **y** before a person you already know:

- **¿Y tú?** — And you? (*informal*)
- **¿Y usted?** — And you? (*formal*)

Nothing else needs repeating. The little question hands the previous topic back to the other person.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Bien. ¿Y tú?” to a friend
- “Regular. ¿Y usted?” to a stranger
- “y” — one clear *ee* sound

Before you move on

What does **y** mean? (**And.**) How do you hand a question back to a friend? (**¿Y tú?**) To a stranger? (**¿Y usted?**) Which Latin word survives inside English **et cetera**? (**Et**, “and.”)

8.4 Asking how someone is — putting it together

Now the question, its answer, and the register choice inside it.
Nothing new in this lesson — only what you already have.

The exchange

— **¿Cómo está usted?** — **Bien**, gracias. **¿Y usted?** — **Regular**.

What you've built

You can ask how someone is, formally or not, answer honestly, and hand the question back.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole exchange, both parts, without stopping
- it again, faster, and let it sound like speech rather than recital

Twice through:

Before you move on

Run it once more from memory. If a word does not come, go back one lesson rather than pushing on — this chapter is short on purpose.

Chapter 9

The Written Accent

Modes:  voice (1)  pen (2)  Hands-free start: none of the 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can hear where a Spanish word is stressed and see why the accent is written.

The Written Accent — the chapter run end to end.

9.1 á é í ó ú — the acute accent, and the two jobs it does

You’ve been reading accented words since your very first noun — **día**, **cómo**, **está**, **más**. Time to make that little stroke make sense. Spanish uses one mark to write exceptional stress — the *acute* accent, ´, leaning right — and it does two jobs in the words you know. Learn the stress job now; the next lesson adds its grammar-label job.

Script — shape and stroke

A short stroke rising **left-to-right**, sitting on top of a vowel: **á é í ó ú**. (On the *í*, it replaces the dot.) One clean up-stroke — the opposite lean from the French *grave* accent â. Spanish never uses grave or circumflex; if it leans the wrong way, it isn’t Spanish.

Grammar Lens: the mark records exceptional stress

Spanish stress is regular, so most words need **no** mark. The default:

- word ends in a **vowel, -n, or -s** → stress the **second-to-last** syllable (*ho-la*, *lla-mo*, *gus-to*).
- word ends in **any other consonant** → stress the **last** syllable (*us-**ted***, *re-gu-**lar***, *es-**tar***).

The accent appears **only when a word breaks that rule** — it marks the exception. *está* ends in a vowel, so the rule wants *ES-ta*; the accent overrides it to *es-**TÁ***. *cómo* ends in a vowel (rule wants *co-**MO***) but is stressed *CÓ-mo*, so it gets the mark. The accent is a **spoken stress you can see** — it never changes the vowel’s sound, only which syllable you hit.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hola, llamo, gusto” — second-to-last stress
- “usted, regular, estar” — final stress
- “está, cómo” — the accent overrides the default

Before you move on

How many accent marks does Spanish have, and which way does it lean? (One — the acute, ´, rising left-to-right.) Its two jobs? (Mark irregular stress; the next step covers its look-alike job.) When does a word ending in a vowel, **-n**, or **-s** need an accent? (**When its stress breaks the second-to-last default.**)

9.2 el or él? — the accent as a meaning label

You know **el** as the article “the.” Add one acute accent and the same two letters do a different job.

Grammar Lens: one mark, two grammatical jobs

The **tilde diacrítica** separates words that otherwise look alike:

no accent	with accent
el = the	él = he
The two words are pronounced alike. Here the accent does not move stress; it labels meaning and grammar. Other pairs will arrive only when you know both words, so this lesson asks you to hold one contrast, not memorize a list.	

Your turn

- *Say it:* “el” — the
- *Say it:* “él” — he
- *Write it:* **el** / **él**, adding the meaning-label accent only to the pronoun

Before you move on

What is the accent’s second job? (**Separate look-alike words.**) Which means “the”? (**El**, no accent.) Which means “he”? (**Él**, with the accent.) Does this mark change their stress? (**No — it labels the job.**)

9.3 The written accent — putting it together

Two lessons on one small mark that changes both sound and meaning. Nothing new in this lesson — only what you already have.

The exchange

está is not *esta*. *él* is not *el*.

What you’ve built

You can hear where the stress falls and see why the mark is there.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole exchange, both parts, without stopping
- it again, faster, and let it sound like speech rather than recital

Twice through:

Before you move on

Run it once more from memory. If a word does not come, go back one lesson rather than pushing on — this chapter is short on purpose.

Chapter 10

Enye and the Upside-Down Marks

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ✍ pen (4) ⇄ Hands-free start: none of the 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can read and write ñ and the upside-down question and exclamation marks.

Enye and the Upside-Down Marks — the chapter run end to end.

10.1 ñ — the letter that remembers a doubled n

ñ is the one letter English does not have — and it has the best origin story in the alphabet. That wavy hat (~, a *tilde*) is not decoration. It is **a tiny second n, written on top to save space**. Once you know that, you know both how to write it *and* why it sounds as it does.

Sounds you'll need

ñ = the *ny* in “canyon” or “onion” — one squished sound, tongue flat against the roof of the mouth. English *canyon* is, in fact, Spanish **cañón** with the ñ spelled out as *ny*. Say “onion,” freeze on the middle: that is ñ.

Script — how to write it

Write a normal **n**, then a small wavy ~ floating above it. Two strokes, one letter.

Careful: ñ is its own letter, not “n with an accent.” *año* (“year”) and *ano* (a rather different word) are completely different words — the tilde is not an optional flourish, it is a distinct letter of the alphabet, with its own slot in the dictionary.

Why it’s said this way

That wave is a **medieval shorthand**. Scribes copying Latin were forever writing double letters, so they saved a stroke: write the letter **once**, and put a little mark above meaning “...and one more of these.” A bar over a vowel meant a dropped *n* or *m* (Latin *tantum* → *tātum*); a wave over an *n* meant **nn**.

Spanish is full of words where a Latin **-nn-** did exactly this:

- Latin **annus** (“year”) → *anno* → **año**. (That same *annus* gives English **annual**, **anniversary**, bi-**ennial**.)
- Latin **canna** (“reed”) → **caña**; Latin *domina* → *donna* → **doña**.

So the tilde on ñ is a **frozen abbreviation** — a thousand-year-old note saying “there used to be two *n*’s here.” You are writing a scribe’s shortcut.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “año” — *AH-nyo*, one squished *ny*; then English “annual”
- the doubled-n words — “año, caña, doña”

Before you move on

What is the tilde on ñ, really? (A tiny second *n* — a scribe’s shorthand for a doubled *nn*.) What Latin word gives *año*, and what English words share it? (*Annus* → annual, anniversary.) Is ñ a separate letter or an accented *n*? (A **separate letter**.) Next: the two everyday words you will be writing it in.

10.2 mañana, español — the ñ in the words you are about to need

You can write **ñ** and you can say it. Two of the next words in this book carry it, and both are worth a minute on their own — because neither of them got its *ñ* from a doubled *n*.

What to know first

- **ñ** — the letter, the sound, and the scribe’s shorthand.

Script — the two forms

- **mañana** — “tomorrow,” and also “morning.” *ma-NYA-na*: the *ñ* is in the **middle**, and it is the stressed syllable.
- **español** — “Spanish.” *es-pa-NYOL*: the *ñ* is at the **end**, right before the *-ol*.

Now the honest footnote. The scribe’s doubled *nn* is **one** road to *ñ*, the one you met with *año*. These two words took a **different** road: Latin’s **-ni-** before a vowel. *Mañana* traces back through *maneana* to **māne** (“morning” — the root of English **matinée**); *español* comes from **Hispaniolus**, built on **Hispania**. In both, a *ni* sequence squeezed together into the same single palatal sound.

So *ñ* is where **two** separate Latin sequences ended up — *-nn-* and *-ni-*. One letter, one sound, two histories.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “año, mañana, español” — the *ñ* in three positions
- the two roads — “año, from *-nn-*” then “mañana, from *-ni-*”

Before you move on

Where does the *ñ* sit in *mañana*, and where in *español*? (Middle; end.) Did those two get their *ñ* from a doubled *n*? (**No** — from Latin **-ni-** before a vowel, a second road to the same letter.) What was the first road? (**-nn-**, the scribe’s shorthand, as in *año*.)

10.3 ¿ ¡ — the marks that open a question

You’ve been writing them since *¿cómo está usted?* Spanish is the one major language that puts an **upside-down** question or exclamation mark at the **start** of the sentence, as well as the normal one at the end. It looks exotic; the reason is purely practical.

Script — the two opening marks

- ¿ ... ? wraps a question: *¿Cómo estás?*
- ¡ ... ! wraps an exclamation: *¡Hola! ¡Gracias!*

The opening mark is just the closing mark **flipped 180°** — turned upside down *and* left-right. To write ¿, draw a normal ? and rotate it half a turn: the hook ends up at the bottom, the dot on top.

Why it’s said this way

English lets you read most of a sentence before the final ? reveals it was a question — fine, because English usually flags a question early with word order (“Are you...”, “Do you...”). Spanish often **doesn’t reorder words**: *Tienes hambre*. (“You’re hungry.”) and *¿Tienes hambre?* (“Are you hungry?”) are the **same words** — only punctuation and the spoken rising tone tell them apart.

So the Spanish Royal Academy, in **1754**, made the opening ¿ official: it warns the reader “*a question is starting — read this with rising intonation from the very first word.*” It’s a **melody cue placed before the melody**, the exact same instinct as the written accent marking stress you can’t otherwise see. For a language read aloud, it’s genuinely useful.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- read “¿Cómo estás?” — start the rising *question* melody from the very first word, the way the ¿ tells you to
- “¡Hola!” — the ¡ warns you to begin with exclamation energy

Before you move on

Why does Spanish open a question with ¿? (Because word order often doesn't change, so the reader needs an early warning to use question intonation.) How do you write it? (A normal ? rotated 180°.) Does it always sit at the sentence's start? (**The next step places it around a question inside a larger sentence.**)

10.4 Where does ¿ begin? — bracket the spoken span

You can open a whole question with ¿. Now place that mark inside a larger sentence, exactly where the questioning voice begins.

Script — bracket the spoken span

The opening mark goes where the **question** begins, even if the sentence started earlier:

Roberto, ¿cómo estás?

The name **Roberto** is outside the question. The marks bracket the words that need question intonation. The same principle works for an exclamation:

Roberto, ¡buenos días!

This is why the opening mark is more than decoration. It tells the reader exactly where to begin and end a change in spoken melody.

Your turn

- *Write it:* “María, ¿cómo estás?”
- *Write it:* “María, ¡buenos días!”
- *Say it:* begin the new melody at ¿ or ¡, not at the first capital

Before you move on

In **Roberto, ¿cómo estás?**, is **Roberto** inside the question? (**No.**) Where does the inverted mark go? (**At the start of the question or exclamation span.**) What does that placement tell a reader? (**Where to change the spoken melody.**)

10.5 Practice — “how are you?”, start to finish

No new words. This chapter’s atoms — *gracias*, *de nada*, *estar*, *¿cómo está?*, *regular* — now assemble into a real exchange, run formally and informally until the register swap is automatic. It picks up right where the Chapter 3 introduction left off.

The exchange

Formal (a stranger, an elder, a customer):

— Buenos días. **¿Cómo está usted?** — **Bien, gracias.** ¿Y usted? — **Más o menos.** — [reply to a thanks, later in the chat] **De nada.**

Informal (a friend, a peer) — only the verb + pronoun change:

— ¡Hola! **¿Cómo estás?** — **Regular.** ¿Y tú? — Bien, gracias.

The glue pattern you just secured is **¿y usted?** / **¿y tú?** — “and you?” It bounces the question back without repeating the whole sentence.

What you’ve built this chapter

- **gracias** — thank you (← *grātia*, “grace”).
- **de nada** — you’re welcome (← “of a born-thing” → “of nothing”).
- **estar** — the state/location be-verb (← *stāre*, “to stand”).
- **¿cómo está usted?** / **¿cómo estás?** — how are you, formal / informal.
- **bien** / **regular** / **más o menos** — well / so-so / more-or-less.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the full *formal* exchange, both voices
- the same exchange *informally* — catch *está* → *estás*, *usted* → *tú*
- chain Chapter 3 + 4 — introduce yourself *and* ask how they are:
“Me llamo ... ¿Cómo está usted?”

Twice through: Run the formal exchange, greeting to answer, without stopping.

Before you move on

Which be-verb carries “how are you?” and why? (*estar* — current state.) Two words swap between formal and informal — which? (*está* → *estás*, and *usted* → *tú*.) What does *de nada* literally say? (“Of nothing.”) And if the person answering you says **vos** instead of *tú* — do you switch? (*No. You understand it and keep saying tú.*) Next chapter: **farewells** — hasta luego, hasta mañana, adiós.

Chapter 11

Goodbye

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can end a conversation, and I know the word every softer goodbye is built from.

Goodbye — the chapter run end to end.

11.1 adiós — “goodbye,” or “to God”

You can greet, introduce yourself, and ask how someone is. Time to leave gracefully. The final, plainest parting is **adiós** — and, like the English *goodbye*, it’s a tiny prayer worn smooth.

Sounds you’ll need

- diphthong-io — the *-íos* is one glide, *ee-OHS*: *ah-DYOHS*, stress on the end (that’s what the accent on *ó* marks — remember the acute-accent lesson).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

adiós is **a + Dios** — “**to God**.” It’s the front half of an old blessing, *a Dios te encomiendo*, “I commend you **to God**” — said to someone setting off, when a journey was dangerous and you left them in God’s keeping.

Every Romance sister kept the same farewell-prayer:

language	goodbye	literally
Spanish	<i>adiós</i>	“to God”
French	<i>adieu</i>	“to God” (<i>à Dieu</i>)
Italian	<i>addio</i>	“to God”
Portuguese	<i>adeus</i>	“to God”

And English is doing the **exact same thing** without telling you: **goodbye** is a crushed-down “*God be with ye.*” So *adiós* and *goodbye* are, at heart, the same sentence — a blessing for the road.

- **Dios** (“God”) ← Latin **Deus** — the *Deus* of English *deity*, *divine*, *adieu*, and (via Greek *Zeus*, same root) the whole sky-god family.

Grammar Lens: *adiós* is a *final* goodbye

adiós leans toward a **longer** parting — you won’t see them soon, or it’s the end of the day. For “see you later / tomorrow,” Spanish reaches for **hasta ...**, which the rest of this chapter is about — and *hasta* has a surprising origin.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*adiós*” — *ah-DYOHS*, stress the end
- *adiós* / *adieu* / *addio* / *adeus* — four “to God” farewells
- English “goodbye” = “God be with ye” — the same prayer

Before you move on

What two words hide inside *adiós*? (*a* + *Dios* — “to God.”) What English goodbye is built the same way? (*Goodbye* ← “God be with ye.”) Is *adiós* for a quick “see you soon”? (No — it’s the longer/final parting; *hasta ...* comes next.) Next: **hasta**, and a word Spain borrowed from Arabic.

11.2 hasta — “until,” and Spain’s Arabic centuries

Spanish says “see you later” as **hasta luego** — literally “**until** later.” So the key word is **hasta**, “until.” And *hasta* carries the single most important fact about Spanish’s history: **for nearly 800 years, much of Spain spoke Arabic.**

Sounds you’ll need

- **silent-h** — Spanish **h** is always silent: **hasta** = *AHS-tah* (no breath on the *h* at all). Stress the front.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hasta comes from Arabic **ḥattā**, “until, up to.” From **711 CE**, Muslim armies ruled much of the Iberian Peninsula — *al-Andalus* — and Arabic was the language of government, science, and poetry there for **centuries**, until 1492. Spanish absorbed roughly **four thousand** Arabic words in that time — more of its vocabulary than from any source except Latin itself.

Most of those loans are **nouns**, and you can spot a huge number by the frozen Arabic article **al-** (“the”) fused onto the front:

- **almohada** (pillow), **alcázar** (fortress), **alcalde** (mayor), **alfombra** (rug), **aduana** (customs), **álgebra**, **alcohol**.
- **azúcar** (sugar), **aceite** (oil), **naranja** (orange).

But **hasta** is rare and special: it is a **function word** — a preposition, part of the grammatical skeleton. Languages borrow nouns easily and grammar words almost never — so an Arabic *preposition* surviving in everyday Spanish shows how deep, how *intimate*, those centuries of contact were. (Its Latin rival *ad* “to”/*usque* “up to” simply lost.) You say a piece of al-Andalus every time you say goodbye.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hasta” — *AHS-tah*, silent h
- “hasta” then Arabic *ḥattā* — the same word, 1,300 years apart

Before you move on

What language is *hasta* from, and what does it mean? (Arabic *ḥattā* — “until.”) Why is it remarkable that Spanish borrowed it? (It’s a *function word* / preposition — languages almost never borrow those; it shows how deep the Arabic centuries went.) How do you spot many Arabic nouns in Spanish? (The frozen *al-* article: *almohada*, *azúcar*, *álgebra*.)

11.3 hasta aquí / hasta la noche — point to the limit

You know **hasta** means “until” or “up to.” Give that small word one spatial endpoint and one temporal endpoint, using only one new word.

Grammar Lens: endpoints in space and time

Aquí means **here**. Put it after **hasta**:

hasta aquí — up to here

For a time endpoint, reuse **la noche**, “the night,” from Chapter 2:

hasta la noche — until the night / until tonight

The same preposition points to a place or the end of a stretch of time. The next lessons will place new time words after it one at a time.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “aquí” — here
- “hasta aquí” — up to here
- “hasta la noche” — until tonight

Before you move on

What does **hasta** point to? (**An endpoint.**) Give one spatial and one temporal example. (**Hasta aquí; hasta la noche.**) What is the only new lexical item? (**Aquí**, “here.”)

11.4 Leaving — putting it together

One farewell that is final, and one word that opens all the others.
Nothing new in this lesson — only what you already have.

The exchange

Adiós — meant, and a little final. **Hasta** — “until,” and it is waiting for what comes next.

What you’ve built

You can close a conversation, and you have the word every softer goodbye is built from.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole exchange, both parts, without stopping
- it again, faster, and let it sound like speech rather than recital

Twice through:

Before you move on

Run it once more from memory. If a word does not come, go back one lesson rather than pushing on — this chapter is short on purpose.

Chapter 12

Until When

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can pick the farewell that matches when I will next see someone.

Until When — the chapter run end to end.

12.1 hasta luego — the everyday “see you later”

This is the goodbye you’ll actually use most — friendly, casual, open-ended. **hasta luego**: “until later.” You already own **hasta** (“until”); today you add **luego** (“later”), and it has a very Latin backstory.

Sounds you’ll need

- diphthong-ue — **luego** = *LWEH-goh*: the *ue* is a *w*-glide, *lweh*-.
- The whole phrase: *AHS-tah LWEH-goh*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hasta luego = “until later” → “see you later.”

- **hasta** = “until” (last lesson — Arabic *ḥattā*).
- **luego** = “later / then / soon,” from Latin **loco**, “at the place / at that point.” The idea slid from *place* → *point in time* → “then, next, soon.” So its cousins in English are all about **place**:

local, locus, location, locate, al-loc-ate. Spanish moved *loco* from *where* to *when*.

A nice contrast: **hasta luego** fuses an **Arabic** word and a **Latin** word in three syllables — the two great layers of Spanish, shaking hands as you leave.

Grammar Lens: the “hasta ...” family

hasta + a time word is Spanish’s whole toolkit of soft goodbyes. You’ll build the other two this chapter:

phrase	“until ...”	when
hasta luego	later	the default “see you”
hasta mañana	tomorrow	leaving for the day
hasta pronto	soon	you expect to meet again shortly

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hasta luego” — *AHS-tah LWEH-goh*
- “luego” then English “local, location” — the *loco* “place” family
- “¡Adiós! ... no — ¡hasta luego!” — feel the difference: final vs. soon

Before you move on

What does *hasta luego* literally mean? (“Until later.”) What did *luego*’s Latin root *loco* first mean, and what English words keep it? (Place — *local, location, locus*.) Which two language layers meet in *hasta luego*? (Arabic *hasta* + Latin *luego*.) Next: **hasta mañana**.

12.2 hasta mañana — “see you tomorrow” (and the ñ returns)

Leaving for the day? **hasta mañana** — “until tomorrow.” It brings back a letter you studied in the writing lessons: the **ñ**. Here it is, living in a word you’ll say every evening.

Sounds you'll need

- enye-ny — **mañana** = *mah-NYAH-nah*: the **ñ** is the squished *ny* of “canyon” (your ñ writing lesson — the tilde is a tiny second *n*, remember). Three soft *ah*’s: *ma-ÑA-na*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hasta mañana = “until tomorrow” → “see you tomorrow.”

- **hasta** = “until” (Arabic *ḥattā*).
- **mañana** = “tomorrow” — **and** “morning.” One word for both, from Latin (**hōra**) **maneana**, “the **early** hour” (from *māne*, “in the morning”). The logic: the next “early hour” you’ll see is *tomorrow morning* → *mañana* came to mean both **morning** and **tomorrow**.

The ñ, in the wild. Recall the writing lesson: *ñ* is a frozen *nn* — a scribe’s shorthand for a doubled *n*. *mañana* comes from Latin *maneana*, whose *n+ea* palatalized (softened) into that single *ñ* sound. So the tilde is a little historical fossil sitting in the middle of “tomorrow.”

Grammar Lens: same word, two meanings — context decides

mañana means “morning” **or** “tomorrow”; the sentence tells you which. Paired with *hasta*, it’s always **tomorrow**: *hasta mañana*, “until tomorrow.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mañana” — *mah-NYAH-nah*, squished *ñ*
- “hasta mañana” — until tomorrow
- “mañana” once as “morning,” then once as “tomorrow” — context decides

Before you move on

What two meanings does *mañana* carry? (Morning; tomorrow.) With *hasta*, which one? (Tomorrow.) What sound is the *ñ*, and what is its tilde, historically? (The *ny* of “canyon”; a frozen doubled-*n*.) Next: **hasta pronto**.

12.3 hasta pronto — “see you soon”

The last of the “hasta ...” trio: **hasta pronto**, “until soon” — for when you genuinely expect to meet again shortly. One new word, **pronto**, and it’s hiding in plain sight in English.

Sounds you’ll need

- **hasta pronto** = *AHS-tah PRON-toh* — a clean *pr*, a pure *o*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hasta pronto = “until soon” → “see you soon.”

- **hasta** = “until” (Arabic *ḥattā*).
- **pronto** = “soon / quickly / ready,” from Latin **promptus**, “brought forth, ready at hand” (from *prōmere*, “to bring out”). Something *prompt* is brought out **without delay** — so *pronto* slid to “soon.”

You already know its English twin: **prompt** (on time; to bring out a response), plus **prompter**, **promptly**, and the computer **prompt** (the cursor “ready” for input). Italian borrowed *pronto* too — it’s what Italians say when they pick up the phone (“*Pronto!*” = “Ready!”).

Grammar Lens: the “hasta ...” trio, complete

You now have Spanish’s three soft goodbyes, sharpest to vaguest in time:

phrase	until...	nuance
hasta pronto	soon	you'll meet again shortly
hasta luego	later	the neutral default "see you"
hasta mañana	tomorrow	you're parting for the day
...and adiós for the long or final goodbye.		

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hasta pronto” — *AHS-tah PRON-toh*
- “pronto” then English “prompt, promptly” — one family
- the trio — hasta pronto / hasta luego / hasta mañana

Before you move on

What does *hasta pronto* mean, and *pronto*'s English twin? (“Until soon”; *prompt*.) What Latin word is it from, and its literal sense? (*promptus*, “brought forth / ready.”) Order the three *hasta* goodbyes by time. (pronto → luego → mañana.) Next: put the whole farewell set together.

12.4 Practice — saying goodbye

No new words. This chapter's farewells — *adiós* and the three *hasta ...* goodbyes — now close a real conversation, and fold back into the whole arc you've built since *hola*.

Grammar Lens: choosing the right goodbye

The choice is about **when you'll meet again**:

you're...	say
parting for good / a long time	Adiós.
expecting to meet again shortly	Hasta pronto.
just “see you” (neutral default)	Hasta luego.
leaving for the day	Hasta mañana.

The exchange — start to finish

Everything from Chapters 1–5, in one conversation:

— ¡Hola! Buenos días. Me llamo Ana. ¿Cómo se llama usted?
 — Me llamo Luis. Mucho gusto. — ¿Cómo está usted? — Bien,
 gracias. ¿Y usted? — Bien. **Hasta mañana**, Luis. — **Hasta**
mañana, Ana. **¡Adiós!**

What you’ve built this chapter

- **adiós** — the plain/final goodbye (“to God”; twin of *goodbye*).
- **hasta** — “until,” Spain’s everyday Arabic word (← *ḥattā*).
- **hasta luego** / **mañana** / **pronto** — see you later / tomorrow / soon, each an Arabic + Latin handshake.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the full conversation above, both voices — greeting to goodbye
- pick the goodbye — for a friend you’ll see tomorrow? (*hasta mañana*); for someone moving away? (*adiós*)

Twice through: Run the whole exchange, *hola* to *adiós*, without stopping.

Before you move on

Which goodbye for someone you won’t see for a long time? (*Adiós.*)
 Which everyday word for “until” did Spanish take from Arabic? (*hasta.*)
 You can now open *and* close a conversation in Spanish. Next chapter: **por favor** and **gracias**’ partner courtesies, then into every-

day verbs.

Chapter 13

A Coffee, Please

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask for something politely.

A Coffee, Please — the chapter run end to end.

13.1 café — coffee, and a place to drink it

Before you can make a polite request, you need one small thing to request. **Café** gives you a useful noun and lets the written accent do a job you already understand.

Sounds you'll need

Say **ca-FÉ**. A vowel-final word would normally stress the second-to-last syllable, so the acute accent records the unexpected final stress.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish **café** came through Italian **caffè** and Turkish **kahve** from Arabic **qahwah**. English **coffee** reached the same travelling word by a different European route. The drink and the word both crossed languages.



The route from Arabic qahwah through Turkish kahve and Italian caffè to

Spanish café

Café can name the drink or the place, just as English **coffee** and **café** divide those jobs. It is masculine: **el café**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “café” — final stress
- “el café”
- the route — “qahwah → kahve → caffè → café”

Before you move on

Where does the stress fall? (**On the final é.**) Why is the accent written? (**It overrides the usual vowel-final stress.**) What route carried the word into Spanish? (**Arabic qahwah → Turkish kahve → Italian caffè → Spanish café.**)

13.2 por favor — “please,” i.e. “for a favour”

You can already thank (*gracias*) and reply (*de nada*). The third courtesy completes the set: **por favor**, “please” — literally “*for [a] favour.*” You’re asking someone to do you a kindness.

Sounds you’ll need

- **r-tap** — one soft tapped *r* in *por* and *favor*.
- **v-b** — Spanish *v* and *b* sound **identical** (a soft *b*): *favor* ≈ *fah-BOR*. (So *favor* and English *favour* look alike *and* the *v* even sounds like the *b* you’d hear in “harbour.”)

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **por** = “for / through / by,” from Latin **prō** (“for, on behalf of”) — the same *pro-* in English **pronoun**, **propose**, **protect**.
- **favor** = “a favour, goodwill,” from Latin **favēre**, “to be

favourable to, to support.” It’s the very word English borrowed: **favour, favorite, favorable, favouritism.**

So *por favor* literally says “**for a favour**” — [*do this*] as a kindness to me. English **favour, favorite, and favorable** keep the same Latin family visible without asking you to learn another language’s formula.

Grammar Lens: the courtesy set is complete

You now hold the three pillars of politeness:

- **por favor** — please (asking).
- **gracias** — thank you (receiving).
- **de nada** — you’re welcome (replying).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “por favor” — *por fah-BOR*, soft *v/b*
- “Café, por favor” — “Coffee, please”
- “favor” then English “favour, favorite” — one family

Before you move on

What does *por favor* literally mean? (“For a favour.”) What Latin verb is *favor* from, and its English cousins? (*favēre* — favour, favorite, favorable.) Which three-word courtesy loop do you now own? (*Por favor* → *gracias* → *de nada*.) Next: your first regular **verb** — *hablar*, “to speak.”

13.3 Ordering — putting it together

Your first transaction: a thing you want, and the word that makes it a request. Nothing new in this lesson — only what you already have.

The exchange

— Un café, **por favor**. — Gracias.

What you've built

You can ask for something and stay polite doing it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole exchange, both parts, without stopping
- it again, faster, and let it sound like speech rather than recital

Twice through:

Before you move on

Run it once more from memory. If a word does not come, go back one lesson rather than pushing on — this chapter is short on purpose.

Chapter 14

When You Don't Understand

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say that I did not understand, and ask for it more slowly.

The two sentences that rescue a conversation, and the thanks that closes it.

14.1 no entiendo — the most useful sentence a beginner owns

Everything so far assumed you understood what was said to you. This chapter is for when you did not.

What to know first

No entiendo. — “I don’t understand.”

Say it whole. You already have **no**; the rest comes with it for now, and the piece you are not yet meant to take apart will come apart later.

This is not an admission of failure. It is the sentence that keeps a conversation alive — the alternative is nodding at something you did not catch.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The word hiding inside *entiendo* comes from Latin **intendere** — literally *to stretch toward*. To understand something was to lean into it.

English took the same word and kept it in several places: **intend** (to stretch your mind toward a thing), **intense**, and — through the same

family — **attention**, which is what you are stretching when you listen hard.

So *no entiendo* is, underneath, “I am not managing to stretch that far yet.” Which is exactly true, and much kinder than “I failed.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “No entiendo.” — calmly, not apologetically
- it again, to someone speaking too fast

Before you move on

Say it once from memory. Which English word shares its root?

14.2 más despacio — the request that makes the last sentence solvable

Everything so far assumed you understood what was said to you.
This chapter is for when you did not.

What to know first

Más despacio, por favor. — “More slowly, please.”

No entiendo stops the conversation. This restarts it. Together they are the whole repair kit: say what went wrong, then say what would fix it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Despacio comes from **de spatio** — “of space.” Latin **spatium** is English **space**, and also **spatial**.

Doing something *de spatio* meant doing it with room around it, unhurried. The sense drifted from space into time, which is a journey English made too: we still say we need *space* when we mean we need *time*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Más despacio.” — calmly, not apologetically
- it again, to someone speaking too fast

Before you move on

Say it once from memory. Which English word shares its root?

14.3 When you don’t understand — putting it together

Two sentences. Between them they rescue almost any conversation.

The exchange

— *(something too fast to follow)* — **No entiendo. Más despacio, por favor.** — *(again, slower)* — **Gracias.**

What you’ve built

Until now, a sentence you missed was the end of the conversation. It is not any more. You can say what went wrong and what would fix it, and then thank someone for doing it — which is the difference between speaking a language badly and not speaking it at all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- both sentences, one after the other, without a pause between them
- them again, then “Gracias.” — the whole repair, start to finish

Twice through:

Before you move on

What do you say when you did not follow? And what do you ask for next? Which English words hide inside *entiendo* and *despacio*? (*Intend, intense, attention* — and *space*.)

Chapter 15

Your First Verb

Modes: ⇄ voice (2) 👁 eyes (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: first 1 of 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I do with an -ar verb in the singular.

Your First Verb — the chapter run end to end.

15.1 hablar — “to speak,” which used to mean “to tell tales”

Fixed phrases got you this far. **Hablar** (“to speak”) is the first verb you will take apart and put back together. Today: the word itself. Next lesson: the pattern it unlocks.

Sounds you’ll need

- **silent-h** — the **h** is **completely silent**: *hablar* = *ah-BLAR*. (Spanish *h* never makes a sound.)
- **v-b** — the *b* is a soft *b*; *hablo* = *AH-bloh*.

That silent *h* is not an accident of spelling. Latin’s initial **f**- weakened in a whole set of Spanish words and eventually fell silent altogether, but the scribes kept writing a letter where it used to be — and that letter is **h**. You are looking at the gravestone of an *f*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hablar comes from Latin **fābulārī**, “to chat, to tell tales” — from **fābula**, “a story.” So *to speak*, in Spanish, is at root *to tell stories*. Notice Latin had a plainer verb available (*loquī*, “to speak,” which English keeps in **eloquent** and **loquacious**) — and Spanish chose the chattier, more colourful one.

That **fābula** is thoroughly English: **fable**, **fabulous** (“story-like”), **con-fabulate**, and **ineffable** (“un-speak-able”).

The single path you need today is **fābulārī** → **hablar**; later words will let you test how broadly that *f*- → *h*- pattern reaches.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablar” — *ah-BLAR*, silent *h*
- “hablar” then English “fable, fabulous, ineffable” — the *fābula* root
- the sound law — “fābulārī” then “hablar”

Before you move on

What Latin word is *hablar* from, and what English word shares it? (*Fābulārī* ← *fābula* — **fable**.) What happened to its initial Latin *f*? (It weakened away, leaving the written but **silent** Spanish *h*-.) Next: the ending pattern that turns this one verb into a machine.

15.2 hablo, hablas, habla — one ending swap, three sentences

Hablar is one word. Swap its last two letters and it becomes “I speak,” or a question to a friend, or a polite question to a stranger. This is the biggest single piece of leverage in this book so far.

What to know first

- *hablar* — the verb and its *fābula* root.
- *tú* or *usted* — which forms *usted* takes.

Grammar Lens: the -ar present tense

Hablar belongs to the **-ar** family. To make the three singular forms you need now: **drop the -ar**, then add the ending for the person.

person	ending	<i>hablar</i> →	meaning
I	-o	hablo	I speak
tú (you, informal)	-as	hablas	you speak
usted (you, formal)	-a	habla	you speak

The *usted* row is the same *he/she* form you were warned about back in Chapter 3 — it turns up here for real. **This same template fits every regular -ar verb**, so learning it once buys you every *-ar* verb you will ever meet.

Grammar Lens: pro-drop

Look at **hablo** again. The **-o** already says “I.” Saying *yo hablo* is not wrong, but it is like saying “I, I speak” — Spanish normally leaves the subject pronoun out entirely.

That is called **pro-drop**, and it is only possible because the endings are distinct enough to carry the information by themselves. English endings are worn down to almost nothing (*spea*k, *spea*k, *spea*ks), so English **must** keep its pronouns. Spanish endings did not wear down, so Spanish can throw the pronoun away. One word, *hablo*, is a complete sentence.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the pattern — “hablo, hablas, habla” (I / tú / usted)
- “hablo” alone, and notice it is already a whole sentence

Before you move on

How do you build the three singular forms of an *-ar* verb? (**Drop -ar**, add **-o** / **-as** / **-a**.) Which one goes with *usted*, and why is it the *he/she* form? (**Habla** — *usted* takes third-person forms.) Why is no subject pronoun needed? (**Pro-drop** — the ending already carries the subject.) Next: **trabajar**, “to work,” straight into the same slot.

15.3 Your first verb — putting it together

One verb, three people, and the endings that carry them. Nothing new in this lesson — only what you already have.

The exchange

hablo — I speak. **hablas** — you speak. **habla** — he or she speaks.

What you've built

You can say who is doing the speaking without a separate word for *I* or *you*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole exchange, both parts, without stopping
- it again, faster, and let it sound like speech rather than recital

Twice through:

Before you move on

Run it once more from memory. If a word does not come, go back one lesson rather than pushing on — this chapter is short on purpose.

Chapter 16

More -ar Verbs

Modes: 🔄 voice (5) 🔄 Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can use several -ar verbs and say that I speak Spanish.

More -ar Verbs — the chapter run end to end.

16.1 trabajar — “to work,” and it once meant *torture*

A second **-ar** verb — snap it into the exact template you just learned. And *trabajar* has the darkest, best etymology in this chapter: it began as a word for **torture**, and it’s the secret origin of English **travel**.

Sounds you’ll need

- j-jota — the **j** is a raspy *h*-from-the-throat (the *jota*): *trabajar* = *tra-ba-HAR*.
- r-tap, b-soft — tapped *r*, soft *b*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

trabajar comes from Vulgar Latin **tripaliāre**, “to torture” — from **tripalium**, a Roman instrument of torture made of **three stakes** (*tri*- “three” + *pālus* “stake,” the root of English **pale** and **impale**). The chain of meaning is grimly logical: *torture* → *torment* / *suffering*

→ *hard toil* → just **work**. And English took the very same word down a parallel road:

- **travail** — painful, laborious effort (and the pains of childbirth).
- **travel** — yes: journeying was once such an *ordeal* that “travail” (toil) became **travel** (to make a journey). Every time you *travel*, you’re etymologically being *tortured*.

So even plain **trabajo**, “I work,” hides the old idea of toil as torment — a dark little joke inside an everyday verb.

Grammar Lens: same -ar template

Drop **-ar**, add the ending — identical to *hablar*:

person	form	meaning
I (ending carries the subject)	trabajo	I work
tú	trabajas	you work
usted	trabaja	you (formal) work

Notice you didn’t learn a new ending — that’s the point. **One template, every regular -ar verb.**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “trabajar” — *tra-ba-HAR*, raspy *j*
- “trabajo, trabajas, trabaja” — same endings as *hablo/hablas/habla*
- “trabajar” → travail → travel — torture became a journey

Before you move on

What did *trabajar* originally mean, and from what device? (“To torture,” ← *tripalium*, a three-stake tool.) What two English words come from the same root? (*Travail* and *travel*.) How do you say “I work”? (*Trabajo* — same -o ending.) Next: **estudiar**, “to study.”

16.2 estudiar — “to study,” and the eagerness inside it

Your third **-ar** verb. By now the pattern should feel automatic — that’s exactly what we want. *estudiar* also hides a nicer feeling than the classroom suggests: at root it means **eagerness**.

Sounds you’ll need

- **st-no-e** — Spanish props up *st-* with an *e*: **es-tudiar** (the same reflex behind *estar*, *España*, *escuela*). *es-too-DYAR*.
- **diphthong-io** — the *-iar* glides: *es-too-DYAR*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

estudiar comes from Latin **studēre**, “to be eager, to apply oneself zealously.” A *studium* was **zeal, enthusiasm, devotion** — only later “study.” So to *study* is, at heart, to *throw yourself eagerly* at something. That **studēre** is everywhere in English:

- **student** — literally “one who is *eager*.”
- **studio, studious, study** — the place, the trait, the act.
- Italian **studio** and the musical *studio* keep the “devoted practice” sense.

So *Estudio español* is “I devote myself eagerly to Spanish” — a nicer picture than mere schoolwork.

Grammar Lens: the template holds

Drop **-ar**, add the ending — for the third time:

person	form	meaning
I (ending carries the subject)	estudio	I study
tú	estudias	you study
usted	estudia	you (formal) study

Three verbs, one pattern: *hablo, trabajo, estudio*. The singular regular **-ar** present is now reusable rather than memorized verb by verb.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “estudiar” — *es-too-DYAR*
- “estudio, estudias, estudia” — the now-familiar endings
- “estudiar” then English “student, studio” — the *studēre* “eagerness”

Before you move on

What did *studēre* originally mean? (“To be eager / apply oneself.”) Its English cousins? (Student, studio, studious.) Say “I study” — and notice it uses the same *-o* as *hablo* and *trabajo*. (*Estudio*.) Next: put a verb and a noun together into your **first real sentence**.

16.3 español — the word for the language

You have practised writing this word’s **ñ**. Now find out what is inside it — because *español* is not a Spanish-made word at all.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

español = “Spanish” — both the language and a Spaniard — from **Hispania**, the **Roman** name for the Iberian peninsula. The path *Hispania* → *hispaniolus* → *español* wore the word down, and there is the **ñ** again, exactly the *-ni-* squeeze you met in the writing lesson (*Hispaniolus* → *españ-ol*). Say it *es-pa-NYOL*.

Two footnotes worth having:

- English **Spanish**, **Hispanic** and **Hispania** are all the same root, so the English and Spanish names for the language are cousins, not translations of each other.
- *Hispania* itself may go back through Latin to a **Phoenician** name for the coast, often read as “land of hyraxes” (or rabbits) — the Phoenicians having met an unfamiliar animal and reached for the nearest word they had.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “español” — *es-pa-NYOL*
- the path — “Hispania, hispaniolus, español”
- “español” then English “Hispanic” — same root

Before you move on

Where does *español* come from? (**Hispania**, the Roman name for Iberia.) What letter does its ending bring back, and from what Latin sequence? (**ñ**, from **-ni-** in *Hispaniolus*.) Next: put it behind a verb and build your first sentence.

16.4 Hablo español — your first real sentence

This is the moment this book has been building to. You take a **verb** you conjugated yourself and a **noun** you took apart yourself, and make a sentence **nobody handed you pre-assembled**.

What you’ve built — the sentence assembled

Snap two things you already own together:

Hablo (I speak, from *hablar*) + **español** (Spanish) = **Hablo español**.

That is a complete, grammatical Spanish sentence, and notice what is **not** in it: no separate subject word. The *-o* of *hablo* already says “I” — the pro-drop you just learned, doing real work in a real sentence. Now swap the pieces and watch it generate:

- **Estudio español.** — “I study Spanish.”
- **Trabajo.** — “I work.”
- **¿Hablas español?** — “Do you speak Spanish?” (the *¿ ?* pair opening and closing the question, as in the writing lesson).

Grammar Lens: languages go bare

One more thing missing from *hablo español*: **no “the,” no “a.”** After a verb like *hablar* or *estudiar*, a language name takes **no article** — *hablo español*, never *hablo el español*.

This matters because Spanish otherwise loves its articles far more than English does (*me gusta el café*, “I like coffee”). So this is a genuine exception you have to hold onto, and the rule of thumb is narrow: right after *hablar*, the language goes bare.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Hablo español” — *AH-bloh es-pa-NYOL*
- swap the verb — “Estudio español”, “Trabajo”
- ask it — “¿Hablas español?” (raise the pitch; ¿ opens it)

Why it’s said this way

You met **no** long ago as the answer. It has a second job, and now you have a sentence to try it on: put *no* directly in front of the verb and the whole thing flips.

Hablo español → No hablo español.

That is all there is to it. English needs a helper — *do not* — and Spanish needs nothing: one small word, in front, and the sentence means its opposite.

Before you move on

Say “I speak Spanish,” then “I study Spanish.” (*Hablo español; estudio español.*) Why is there no separate subject word? (The *-o* ending carries “I.”) Why no “the” before *español*? (**Languages take no article** after a verb like *hablar*.) You just built a sentence from parts — that is the whole game from here.

16.5 Practice — making sentences with -ar verbs

A milestone chapter: for the first time you’re not reciting fixed phrases, you’re **building sentences from a pattern**. Drill the

three verbs through the endings until *hablo* / *hablas* / *habla* is automatic.

Grammar Lens: conjugate on command

Run each verb through the three singular jobs you know: the ending alone for **I** → **tú** → **usted**:

- **hablar**: hablo · hablas · habla
- **trabajar**: trabajo · trabajas · trabaja
- **estudiar**: estudio · estudias · estudia

Same three endings (**-o** / **-as** / **-a**) every time — that's the whole regular **-ar** present, singular.

The exchange — say something real

— ¿**Hablas** español? — **Hablo** español. — ¿**Estudias** español? — **Estudio** español. — **Café, por favor.** — ¡Gracias!
— De nada.

What you've built this chapter

- **por favor** — please (← “for a favour”), completing *gracias* / *de nada* / *por favor*.
- **the singular regular -ar pattern** — drop *-ar*, add **-o** / **-as** / **-a**: the template behind *hablar*, *trabajar*, and *estudiar*.
- **hablar** (← *fābula*, fable; the f→h law), **trabajar** (← *tripalium*, torture → travail/travel), **estudiar** (← *studēre*, eagerness → student).
- **Hablo español** — your first self-assembled sentence (pro-drop, no article).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- conjugate all three verbs for I / tú / usted, without stopping

- answer “¿Hablas español?” and “¿Estudias español?” about yourself
- request “Café, por favor” and run the full gracias/de nada loop

Twice through: Ask and answer “¿Hablas español? — Hablo español.”

Before you move on

What are the three singular *-ar* endings? (*-o* / *-as* / *-a*.) Give the “I” form of all three verbs. (*Hablo, trabajo, estudio*.) Why does *Hablo español* need no separate subject word? (The *-o* carries “I.”) You can now generate sentences — this book stops handing you phrases and starts handing you *rules*. Next chapter adds the *-er/-ir* verb families.

Chapter 17

Eating, Drinking, Living — the -er and -ir Verbs

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 👁️ eyes (2) 🦶 Hands-free start: none of the 6 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can use the singular forms of regular Spanish -er and -ir verbs to ask and answer what someone eats or drinks and where they live.

Ask and answer a short exchange about eating, drinking, studying, and where someone lives, using the three singular regular verb patterns and only previously introduced words.

17.1 comer — “to eat,” and the second verb family

Last chapter you learned the **-ar** verbs. Spanish has two more families — **-er** and **-ir** — and here’s the good news: they’re **almost the same**. Meet **comer** (“to eat”), your first **-er** verb.

Sounds you’ll need

- **r-tap** — one soft tap: *ko-MER*.
- The *c* before *o* is a hard *k*: *comer* = *ko-MER*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

comer comes from Latin **comedere**, “to eat up” — **com-** (intensifier, “completely”) + **edere**, “to eat.” That **edere** is the twin of English **eat** (both from the same ancient root), and it feeds a small English family:

- **edible** — fit to be eaten.
- **comestible** — a fancy word for food (straight from *comedere*).
- English **eat** itself — the Germanic cousin of Latin *edere*.

Grammar Lens: the -er present tense

The pattern is the **-ar** one with the *a*'s swapped for *e*'s. Drop **-er**, add:

person	-ar was	-er is	<i>comer</i> →
yo	-o	-o	como (I eat)
tú	-as	-es	comes (you eat)
él/ella/usted	-a	-e	come (he/she eats)

So the **yo** form is identical (**-o**), and *tú/él* just trade *a* for *e*: *hablas/habla* → *comes/come*. Those are the only three forms this lesson asks you to hold.

Watch the false friend: **como** means “I eat” **and** “like/as” (*como tú*, “like you”) **and**, with an accent, **cómo** = “how?”. Same four letters, three jobs — the accent and context sort them out.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “comer” — *ko-MER*
- “como, comes, come” — note the *-o/-es/-e* endings
- “comer” then English “edible, comestible, eat” — the *edere* family

Before you move on

What Latin verb is *comer* from, and its English cousins? (*comedere* ← *edere* — edible, eat.) What are the three singular *-er* endings? (*-o* / *-es* / *-e*.) How do they differ from *-ar*? (The *tú* and *usted* vowels change from *a* to *e*.) Next: your first **-ir** verb, *vivir*.

17.2 vivir — “to live,” and the third family (that’s barely new)

The third and last verb family: **-ir**, and **vivir** (“to live”) is your first. Here’s the punchline — in the present tense, **-ir is almost identical to -er**. You’ve nearly finished learning the whole regular present.

Sounds you’ll need

- **v-b** — Spanish *v* = a soft *b*: *vivir* ≈ *bee-BEER*.
- **r-tap** — one tap on the final *r*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

vivir comes from Latin **vīvere**, “to live” — one of the most alive roots in English:

- **vivid** — “full of life.”
- **survive** (*super-vīvere*, “to live beyond”), **revive** (“live again”).
- **vivacious**, **convivial** (“living together” — sociable), **viva!**, **vivarium**. (And *vīta*, “life,” gives **vital**, **vitamin**.)

Grammar Lens: the -ir present tense

Compare the three families, singular — this is the whole system:

person	-ar (<i>hablar</i>)	-er (<i>comer</i>)	-ir (<i>vivir</i>)
yo	hablo	como	vivo
tú	hablas	comes	vives
él/ella	habla	come	vive

Look: **-er and -ir are identical in the singular** (*-o* / *-es* / *-e*). They only part company in plural forms, which come later. For now, learning *-ir* costs you almost nothing.

Three families, one idea. You can now build the three singular forms of a regular verb from any of the three families.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “vivir” — *bee-BEER*
- “vivo, vives, vive” — same endings as *como, comes, come*
- “vivir” then English “vivid, survive, revive” — the *vīvere* family

Before you move on

What Latin verb is *vivir* from, and two English cousins? (*vīvere* — vivid, survive.) In the singular, how do *-er* and *-ir* endings compare? (They’re **identical**: *-o* / *-es* / *-e*.) Say “I live.” (*Vivo*.) Next: the drink verb, *beber*.

17.3 beber — “to drink,” and the pattern is yours

One more **-er** verb to make the pattern automatic — **beber**, “to drink.” Pair it with *comer* and you can talk about eating and drinking, the heart of any café or restaurant.

Sounds you’ll need

- **v-b** — both *b*’s are the soft Spanish *b*: *be-BER*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

beber comes from Latin **bibere**, “to drink” — a thirsty little root that soaked into English:

- **beverage** — a drink (via Old French *bevrage*, from *bibere*).
- **imbibe** — to drink in (*in-* + *bibere*).
- **bibulous** — fond of drinking; **bib** — the cloth that catches drips; even **beer**’s cousins hover nearby.

Grammar Lens: no new grammar — that’s the point

beber is a regular **-er** verb, so it takes the endings you already own:

| yo | **bebo** | I drink |

| tú | **bebes** | you drink |

| él/ella/usted | **bebe** | he/she drinks / you (formal) drink |

Nothing new to learn — you’re just *reusing the machine*. With the word

café from the previous chapter, you can already say:

Bebo café. — “I drink coffee.”

One new verb, one known noun, one sentence you built yourself.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “beber” — *be-BER*
- “bebo, bebes, bebe” — the familiar *-o/-es/-e*
- “Bebo café” — “I drink coffee”

Before you move on

What Latin verb is *beber* from, and its English cousins? (*bibere* — beverage, imbibe.) Did *beber* need any new endings? (No — it’s a regular *-er* verb.) Say “I drink.” (*Bebo.*) Next: start **asking** — *qué*, “what?”

17.4 qué — “what”, a new question word

You already know the question word *cómo*; now ask about a thing. The new question word is **qué**, “what” — and it puts to work two things from your writing chapter: the **accent** and the *¿* ?.

Sounds you’ll need

- **k-hard** — **qu** is a plain hard **k** (the *u* is silent): *qué* = *keh*.
- **accent-mark** — the **accent on é** marks this as the *question* word (recall the diacrítica: *qué* = “what?”; *que* = “that”). Question words wear the accent.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

qué comes from Latin **quid**, “*what*” — the neuter of *quis*, “who.” It’s a small function word with a few learned English descendants:

- **quiddity** — the “what-ness,” the essence of a thing.
- **quid pro quo** — “*what* for *what*,” this for that.
- the *qu-* question family it heads in Spanish: *qué*, *quién* (who), *cuál* (which) — Latin’s *qu-* interrogatives, the same *wh-* instinct as English (Latin *qu-* and English *wh-* are ancient cousins).

Grammar Lens: asking with a verb you know

Put **qué** in front of a verb, wrap it in **¿** ?, and you have a real question:

¿Qué comes? — “What are you eating? / What do you eat?” **¿Qué bebes?** — “What are you drinking?”

Remember the opening **¿** (from the writing lesson) warns the reader a question is coming; the accent on *qué* marks it as the question word. Answer with the verb you already conjugate and a noun you already know: *Bebo café*. (“I drink coffee.”)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “**qué**” — *keh*, silent *u*
- “**¿Qué comes?**” / “**¿Qué bebes?**” — ask with verbs you know
- “**qué**” vs “**que**” — the accent marks the *question*

Before you move on

What Latin word is *qué* from? (*quid* — quiddity, quid pro quo.) Why does *qué* carry an accent? (It’s the *question* word; *que* without = “that.”) Ask “what are you eating?” (*¿Qué comes?*) Next: asking **where** — *dónde*.

17.5 dónde — “where?”

One more question word, and one more real question you can build: **dónde**, “where?” Pair it with *vivir* and you can ask the single most common getting-to-know-you question: *where do you live?*

Sounds you’ll need

- **d-soft** — the middle *d* is soft, near the *th* of *this*: *DON-deh*.
- **accent-mark** — like *qué*, the **accent on ó** marks the question word (*dónde* = “where?”; *donde* without = “where,” a relative — “the place *where*”).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

dónde comes from Latin **de unde**, literally “*from whence*.” *unde* meant “from where,” and Spanish glued *de* onto the front and wore the pair down to *dónde*. (English once had the matching set *whence* / *where* / *whither* — “from where / at where / to where”; Spanish keeps that flavour in *de dónde* “from where”, *dónde* “where”, *adónde* “to where”.)

Grammar Lens: your first getting-to-know-you questions

Two question words + verbs you own = real conversation:

¿Dónde vives? — “Where do you live?” → *Vivo en Madrid*.
¿Dónde trabajas? — “Where do you work?”
¿Qué estudias? — “What do you study?”

Notice the little **en** (“in,” ← Latin *in*) in the answer — the first preposition, slipping in exactly where you need it. You’re now trading real questions and answers, not fixed phrases.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “dónde” — *DON-deh*, soft *d*
- “¿Dónde vives?” — “Where do you live?”

- answer — “Vivo en ...” with your city

Before you move on

What Latin phrase is *dónde* from, and what did it mean? (*De unde* — “from whence.”) Why the accent? (It marks the *question* word.) Ask “where do you live?” and answer it. (*¿Dónde vives?* — *Vivo en ...*) Next: put the questions and verbs together in practice.

17.6 Practice — asking real questions

You now have all three verb families **and** two question words. This is where it becomes a conversation: you can **ask** and **answer**, not just recite. Drill until the questions come without thinking.

Grammar Lens: three singular patterns

Conjugate *yo* → *tú* → *él/ella* — feel how little differs:

- **-ar** *hablar*: hablo · hablas · habla
- **-er** *comer*: como · comes · come
- **-ir** *vivir*: vivo · vives · vive

Endings: *-ar* → *-o/-as/-a*; *-er* and *-ir* → *-o/-es/-e* in these three singular forms. The plural forms can wait.

The exchange — use only what you know

— *¿Dónde vives?* — **Vivo** en Sevilla. *¿Y tú?* — **Vivo** en México. — *¿Qué estudias?* — **Estudio** español. *¿Qué bebes?* — **Bebo** café.

What you’ve built this chapter

- **comer** / **beber** (-er), **vivir** (-ir) — the two remaining verb families; singular endings **-o** / **-es** / **-e**.
- **qué** (← *quid*) and **dónde** (← *de unde*) — your first question words, each wearing the **accent** and opening with *¿*.

- **Real questions:** *¿Qué comes?* *¿Dónde vives?* *¿Dónde trabajas?*
— and the first preposition, **en** (“in”), in the answers.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- conjugate all three families, yo/tú/él, back to back
- ask a friend where they live and what they drink; answer both
- ask what they study; answer “Estudio español”

Twice through: “¿Dónde vives? — Vivo en ... ¿Y tú?”

Before you move on

What are the singular endings for *-er/-ir* verbs? (*-o / -es / -e.*)
Give the “I” forms of *comer, vivir, beber*. (*Como, vivo, bebo.*) Ask
“what do you study?” and “where do you live?” (*¿Qué estudias?*
¿Dónde vives?) You can now hold a simple back-and-forth — this
book is fully in sentence territory. Next: **numbers** (uno, dos, tres)
and telling someone your age and phone.

Chapter 18

Numbers, and How Old You Are

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🖐️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can count from one through ten and use singular forms of *tener* to ask and answer age with a number I know.

*Count from one through ten, move among *tengo*, *ienes*, and *tiene*, then ask and answer age with the number frame taught in the chapter.*

18.1 uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco — counting to five

Numbers are among the most reusable words in any language. Spanish keeps them close enough to Latin that English cousins can help you remember them. This lesson asks for only **five**: **uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco**.

Sounds you'll need

- diphthong-ue — **cuatro** begins *KWA*-.
- r-tap — give *tres* and *cuatro* one light tap, not an English *r*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish	Latin source	English memory hook
uno (1)	<i>ūnus</i>	unit , unique
dos (2)	<i>duo</i>	duo , dual
tres (3)	<i>trēs</i>	trio , triple
cuatro (4)	<i>quattuor</i>	quart , quarter
cinco (5)	<i>quīnque</i>	quintet , quintuplet

The spellings changed, but the family resemblance remains. *Cinco* and *quintet* both descend from *quīnque*; Spanish changed the opening sound while English borrowed a more visibly Latin form.

Grammar Lens: uno becomes un or una

When **uno** stands alone, it means “one.” Before a noun it shortens:

- **un** before a masculine noun: **un café** — one coffee / a coffee.
- **una** before a feminine noun: **una noche** — one night / a night.

This shortening is called **apocope**: the end drops away. Spanish uses the same forms for “one” and “a/an”; context supplies the difference.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco” — once up, once down
- “uno/unit, dos/duo, tres/trio, cuatro/quart, cinco/quintet”
- “un café, una noche” — hear *uno* shorten

Before you move on

Give 1–5 in Spanish. (*Uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco.*) Which English word helps you remember *cinco*? (*Quintet*, through Latin *quīnque*.) What happens to *uno* before a noun? (It becomes **un** or **una**.) Next: **six through ten**.

18.2 seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez — and the calendar's old count

You can count to five. Add one small set and you reach ten: **seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez**. Four English month names will help hold the last four in memory.

Sounds you'll need

- diphthong-*ie* — **siete** begins *SYE*-.
- diphthong-*ue* — **nueve** begins *NWE*-.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish	Latin source	English memory hook
seis (6)	<i>sex</i>	sextet
siete (7)	<i>septem</i>	September , septet
ocho (8)	<i>octō</i>	October , octave
nueve (9)	<i>novem</i>	November
diez (10)	<i>decem</i>	December , decimal

Say the chain aloud: *siete–September, ocho–October, nueve–November, diez–December*. It is a memory path, not a second list to memorize.

Why it's said this way

The month names preserve an old Roman count in which **March was first**: September through December occupied positions seven through ten. When January and February stood before March, those names shifted to positions nine through twelve but kept their old numbers.

One tempting story is wrong: July and August were not new months inserted into the middle. The existing months **Quintilis** and **Sextilis** were later **renamed** for Julius Caesar and Augustus. The calendar moved; the numbered names stayed.

Numbers above ten belong to a later chapter. For now, stop cleanly at **diez**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- count from *uno* through *diez*
- “siete/September, ocho/October, nueve/November, diez/December”

Before you move on

Give 6–10. (*Seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez.*) Why does *December* carry the old word for ten? (The month names preserve a March-first count.) What happened to Quintilis and Sextilis? (They were renamed July and August.) Next: the verb **tener**, “to have.”

18.3 tener — “to have,” with two visible changes

Regular *comer* gave you *como, comes, come*. The common verb **tener**, “to have,” belongs to the same **-er** family, but its three singular forms change in two places. Learn only those three today.

Sounds you’ll need

- diphthong-**ie** — **ti**enes begins *TYE*-.
- **r-tap** — one light tap at the end of **tener**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

tener descends from Latin **tenēre**, “to hold or keep.” Having is, at root, holding. English borrowed the same root many times:

- **tenant, tenure, tenacious** — holding land, office, or position.
- **contain, retain, maintain, sustain** — holding together, back, in hand, or up.

When you see *-tain* in English, think of Spanish **tener**.

Grammar Lens: the three singular forms

person	regular <i>comer</i>	irregular <i>tener</i>
yo	como	tengo
tú	comes	 tienes
él / ella / usted	come	 tiene

Two small changes do all the work:

1. **yo** adds **g**: *tengo*, not *teno*. 2. The other two singular forms change **e** → **ie**: *tienes*, *tiene*.

Later chapters will expand both patterns. For now, hold only **tengo**, **tienes**, **tiene** — the same three-person frame you already use for regular verbs.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “tener — tengo, tienes, tiene”
- “tener / tenant / retain” — the shared idea is *hold*
- compare “como, comes, come” with “tengo, tienes, tiene”

Before you move on

What did Latin *tenēre* mean? (“To hold.”) Give the three singular forms. (*Tengo, tienes, tiene.*) What are the two changes? (*g* appears in *tengo*; *e* becomes *ie* in *tienes/tiene*.) Next: use them to ask and answer about **age**.

18.4 ¿Cuántos años tienes? — asking age

You now have *tengo, tienes, tiene* and the numbers one through ten. Put them together and you can ask or answer age. Spanish frames age as something you **have**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

¿Cuántos años tienes? “How old are you?” — literally, “How many years do you have?”

- **cuántos** means “how many.” Latin **quantus**, “how much,” also gives English **quantity**, **quantum**, **quantify**.
- **años** means “years.” Latin **annus** also gives **annual** and **anniversary**. Its doubled *nn* became Spanish **ñ**, exactly as your script lesson showed.
- **tienes** is the *tú* form of **tener**.

Keep the marks visible: opening **¿**, the accent in **cuántos**, and the letter **ñ** in **años** each carries information.

Grammar Lens: Spanish “has” years

English says “I **am** ten years old.” Spanish says:

— ¿Cuántos años **tienes**? — **Tengo diez años.**

The reusable frame is **Tengo + number + años**. Use a number you already know: *Tengo ocho años*, *Tengo nueve años*, *Tengo diez años*. Larger numbers wait until their own lesson; the grammar does not change.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “¿Cuántos años tienes?”
- “Tengo ocho años. Tengo nueve años. Tengo diez años.”

Before you move on

What does the question literally ask? (“How many years do you have?”) Which verb carries age? (*Tener*.) How do *cuántos* and *años* connect to English? (*Quantus* → quantity; *annus* → annual.) Next: combine counting, *tener*, and age in one short exchange.

18.5 Practice — counting, having, and age

This checkpoint asks for three small moves: count to ten, choose the right singular form of *tener*, and use the age frame. Every-

thing here has already appeared.

Grammar Lens: count and conjugate

- Count: **uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco, seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez.**
- Change person: **tengo · tienes · tiene.**
- Remember the roots: *quīnque* helps with *cinco*; *decem* helps with *diez*; *tenēre*, “hold,” helps with *tener*.
- Keep the calendar correction: July and August were **renamed**, not inserted.

The exchange — use only what you know

— Hola. ¿Cómo te llamas? — Me llamo Ana. ¿Cuántos años tienes? — Tengo diez años. ¿Y tú? — Tengo nueve años.

The exchange reuses the name question you already know, then adds exactly one new capability: age with **tener**.

What you’ve built this chapter

- **uno through diez**, with Latin and English hooks instead of an isolated list.
- **un / una** before a noun, where standalone *uno* shortens.
- **tengo, tienes, tiene**, the three singular forms of **tener**.
- **¿Cuántos años tienes? — Tengo ... años**, with *quantus/quantity* and *annus/annual* showing where the words came from.

Numbers above ten and the plural forms of *tener* remain deliberately deferred.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- count 1–10 up, then down

- “tengo, tienes, tiene”
- ask and answer age with a number from 1–10

Twice through: “¿Cuántos años tienes? — Tengo nueve años.”

Before you move on

Count to ten. Give the three singular forms of *tener*. Ask “How old are you?” and answer with a number you learned. You can now move from a name exchange into one concrete personal detail. Next: the two Spanish ways to say “to be,” introduced one contrast at a time.

Chapter 19

Ser and Estar — Two Ways to Be

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can identify someone, state origin, check wellbeing, and give a location by choosing a learned singular form of ser or estar.

Identify Ana, state an origin with soy de, check a current state, and locate Ana with está en using only previously introduced vocabulary and singular forms.

19.1 ser — another way to say “to be”

You already use **estar** for a current state or location. Spanish also has **ser**. This chapter adds one job at a time; today, learn the verb and the three singular forms that match the person frame you already know.

Sounds you’ll need

- vowel-e — **ser** begins with the clear vowel in *mesa*.
- r-tap — the final **r** is one light tap: *SER*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Modern **ser** grew from a historical merger. Latin **esse** meant “to be,” while **sedēre** meant “to sit.” The infinitive and the present forms do not all come down the same path, so the modern verb cannot be predicted from one neat stem.

The **esse** family is still visible in English **essence**, **essential**, **entity**, **present**, and **absent**. That makes *essence* a useful memory hook for one major use of *ser*: identifying what someone or something **is**.

Grammar Lens: only three forms today

person	form	a small identifying frame
yo	soy	Soy Ana. — “I am Ana.”
tú	eres	Eres Ana. — “You are Ana.”
él / ella / usted	es	Usted es Ana. — “You are Ana.”

Say the set as **soy · eres · es**. These forms are **irregular**: do not try to remove *-er* and attach the regular endings from *comer*. A later lesson will build the plural-person frame.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ser — soy, eres, es”
- “Soy Ana. Eres Ana. Usted es Ana.”
- “esse — essence — ser”

Before you move on

Which two Latin verbs fed *ser*? (*Esse* and *sedēre*.) Give the three forms learned today. (*Soy, eres, es*.) Why not predict them from the infinitive? (The verb is historically mixed and irregular.) Next: set *ser* beside *estar* using only identity and state frames you already have.

19.2 ser vs estar — identity or current state?

You now have two small sets: **soy, eres, es** and **estás, está**. Do not memorize a long rule list. Make one contrast: **ser identifies**; **estar places someone in a current state or location**.

Grammar Lens: the first contrast, from known material

question	what it asks	verb
¿Es usted Ana? — “Are you Ana?”	identity	ser
¿Está usted bien? — “Are you well?”	current state	estar

Only the verb and the job change. The first question identifies the person; the second checks how that person is now. Both **Ana**, **usted**, and **bien** are already part of your course, so the contrast adds no hidden vocabulary.

Grammar Lens: a memory hook, not a law

- **ser** recalls Latin *esse* and English **essence**: use it here to say who someone **is**.
- **estar** comes from Latin *stāre*, “to stand,” the family behind **state**: use it for the state or location in which someone stands.

“Permanent versus temporary” is only a rough beginner shortcut, not the rule. A location may last for centuries and still use *estar*; an identification may last one minute and still use *ser*. Ask instead: **am I identifying, or am I giving a state or location?**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “¿Es usted Ana?” — identity, *ser*
- “¿Está usted bien?” — state, *estar*
- “identify: *ser*; state or location: *estar*”

Twice through: “¿Es usted Ana? ¿Está usted bien?”

Before you move on

Which verb identifies? (*Ser*.) Which gives a current state or location? (*Estar*.) Why is “permanent versus temporary” incomplete? (The

choice follows the kind of claim, not its duration.) Next: use *ser* for one specific identity fact — origin.

19.3 soy de... — saying where you are from

You can identify yourself with **Soy Ana**. Add one short word and you can state another identity fact: **Soy de...**, “I am from...”.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

de means “from” or “of.” It comes from Latin **dē**, “down from, away from.” English keeps that direction in **depart** and **descend**. You already learned that *dónde* grew from Latin *de unde*, “from where.” Spanish can put the still-living word **de** before **dónde** to ask explicitly about origin.

Grammar Lens: ser + de for origin

¿De dónde eres? — “Where are you from?” **Soy de Madrid.** — “I am from Madrid.”

The place name **Madrid** already appeared with *vivir*. Here, the new piece is the frame around it. Use **ser**, because this sentence states origin; it does not say where someone is located now.

Keep the two known questions separate:

question	asks about
¿De dónde eres?	origin — where you are from
¿Dónde vives?	residence — where you live

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “¿De dónde eres?”
- “Soy de Madrid.”
- “de — depart — descend”: the shared direction is *from*

Before you move on

What does *de* mean? (“From” or “of.”) Ask where one friend is from. (*¿De dónde eres?*) Answer with Madrid. (*Soy de Madrid.*) Next: reuse *dónde* and *en* to say where someone is located now.

19.4 *está en...* — saying where someone is

In Chapter 7, *¿Dónde vives?* — *Vivo en Madrid* asked about where someone lives. Now use the same *dónde* and *en* with *estar* to ask about a current location.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

en already means “in,” “on,” or “at.” It descends from Latin **in** and is a cognate of English **in**. No new preposition is needed; only the surrounding verb changes.

Grammar Lens: *dónde* + *estar*, then *estar* + *en*

¿Dónde está usted? — “Where are you?” (formal) **Usted está en Madrid.** — “You are in Madrid.” **Ana está en Madrid.** — “Ana is in Madrid.”

The form **está** is already familiar from *¿Cómo está usted?* The phrase **está en...** simply gives that form a place. Location uses *estar* even when a place seems stable; the choice marks the kind of claim, not how long it lasts.

Compare origin and location without adding any new form:

sentence	meaning	verb
Ana es de Madrid.	origin	<i>ser</i>
Ana está en Madrid.	location	<i>estar</i>

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*¿Dónde está usted?*”

- “Ana está en Madrid.”
- “en / in” — two cognates

Before you move on

Which verb locates someone? (*Estar*.) What already-known word introduces the place? (*En*.) Ask formal “Where are you?” (*¿Dónde está usted?*) Next: combine identity, origin, state, and location without adding another word or verb form.

19.5 Practice — identity, origin, state, and location

This checkpoint adds nothing. Use **ser** for identity and origin; use **estar** for a current state or location.

Grammar Lens: retrieve the two small form sets

- **ser**: soy · eres · es
- **estar** in the questions used here: estás · está

Plural forms remain deliberately deferred.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **ser**: *esse* + *sedēre*.
- **estar**: *stāre*, “stand.”
- **de**: Latin *dē*, “from.”
- **en**: Latin *in*, English *in*.

Grammar Lens: sort by the kind of claim

prompt	answer	why
¿Es usted Ana?	<i>ser</i>	identity
¿De dónde eres?	<i>ser</i>	origin
¿Está usted bien?	<i>estar</i>	current state
¿Dónde está Ana?	<i>estar</i>	location

The exchange — only known pieces

— Hola. ¿Es usted Ana? — Sí. Soy Ana. — ¿De dónde es usted? — Soy de Madrid. — ¿Dónde está Ana? — Está en Madrid. — ¿Está usted bien? — Bien, gracias.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “soy, eres, es”
- the four questions, naming each job
- the exchange once

Twice through: “¿Es usted Ana? ¿Está usted bien?”

Before you move on

Give the three learned forms of *ser*. (*Soy, eres, es*.) Which verb identifies and states origin? (*Ser*.) Which gives a state or location? (*Estar*.) Ask where one friend is from, then locate Ana in Madrid. Next: **ir**, “to go,” introduced in the same small-step frame.

Chapter 20

Going, and the Future You Can Already Say

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask where someone is going, say what a singular person is going to do, and mark a known singular noun with *mi*, *tu*, or *su*.

*Complete ES-C10-practice, the canonical closing checkpoint, and demonstrate the chapter promise with singular *ir*, *ir a* plus a known infinitive, and *mi*, *tu*, or *su* before *café*.*

20.1 *ir* — “to go,” from more than one historical stem

You already match different verb forms with **tú** and **usted**, and you can ask ¿**Dónde...**?, “Where...?” Today, add one new verb and only its three singular-person forms.

Sounds you’ll need

- vowel-**i** — **ir** is one clear syllable, like *ear* without a glide.
- diphthong-**oy** — **voy** ends with the sound in English *boy*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ir means “to go.” Its infinitive descends from Latin **īre**, also “to go.” The present forms below followed a different Latin verb, **vādere**, “to go forward” or “advance.” English **invade** and **evade** preserve that *vad*-family.

One modern verb built from historically different stems is called **suppletive**. English does the same thing when *go* changes to *went*, an old form borrowed from *wend*.

Grammar Lens: only three forms today

person	present of ir
yo	voy
tú	vas
él / ella / usted	va

Say the small set as **voy · vas · va**. The plural forms are deliberately left for a later lesson.

The known question word now gives you a useful prompt:

¿Dónde va usted? — “Where are you going?”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ir — voy, vas, va”
- “¿Dónde va usted?”
- “īre gives ir; vādere gives the present set”

Before you move on

What does *ir* mean? (“To go.”) Give the three forms learned today. (*Voy, vas, va.*) Why do they look unlike *ir*? (The infinitive and present set come through different Latin stems.) Next: place **a** and a known infinitive after this small set to talk about what is coming.

20.2 voy a + infinitive — moving toward the near future

You know **voy**, **vas**, **va** and the infinitives **hablar**, **comer**, **vivir**. This lesson joins those owned pieces with one short new word.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish **a** means “to” or “toward.” It descends from Latin **ad**, “toward,” which English keeps in words such as **advance**.

Movement toward a place easily becomes movement toward a future event. English uses the same picture in “I am **going to** speak.” Spanish keeps **a** visible: **voy a hablar**.

Grammar Lens: ir + a + an unchanged infinitive

person	near-future frame	meaning
yo	voy a hablar	I am going to speak
tú	vas a comer	you are going to eat
usted	va a vivir	you are going to live

Only **ir** changes for the person. The second verb stays in its known dictionary form: **hablar**, **comer**, or **vivir**. No new plural person or infinitive is hidden in the pattern.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “voy a hablar”
- “vas a comer”
- “va a vivir”

Before you move on

What is the frame? (*Ir* in the present + **a** + an infinitive.) Does the second verb change for the person? (No.) What idea connects physical going with future time? (Motion toward a destination becomes motion toward an event.) Next: say whose already-known **café** it is.

20.3 mi, tu, su — whose café?

You already know **café**, and you distinguish informal **tú** from formal **usted**. Now put one small ownership word before that one known noun.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish	Latin source	meaning in today's frame
mi	<i>meus</i>	my
tu	<i>tuus</i>	your, to one informal tú
su	<i>suus</i>	your, to formal usted ; also his or her

English **my** helps recall **mi**. Older English **thy**, “your,” helps recall Latin *tuus* and Spanish **tu**. The ownership word **tu** has no written accent; the person word **tú** that you already know keeps its accent.

Grammar Lens: put the ownership word before the noun

phrase	meaning
mi café	my coffee
tu café	your coffee, informal
su café	your coffee, formal; or his or her coffee

The situation tells you which person **su** points to. Every noun phrase in this lesson is singular. Forms used before plural things are left for a later step, so there is no new number pattern to learn here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mi café”
- “tu café” to *tú*
- “su café” to *usted*

Before you move on

Give the three ownership words. (*Mi, tu, su.*) Where do they go? (Before the noun.) Which one addresses *usted*? (*Su.*) Which Latin sources sit behind them? (*Meus, tuus, suus.*) Next: retrieve the chapter without adding a new word, form, or noun.

20.4 Practice — going, approaching events, and ownership

This checkpoint adds nothing. Retrieve **voy, vas, va**; build the near future with **a** and a known infinitive; then put **mi, tu**, or **su** before the known noun **café**.

Grammar Lens: the complete small chapter frame

- **ir**, singular: **voy · vas · va**.
- near future: **voy a hablar · vas a comer · va a vivir**.
- ownership before one singular known noun: **mi café · tu café · su café**.

Plural person forms of *ir* and possessives before plural nouns remain deferred.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **ir** continues Latin *īre*, while **voy, vas, va** continue *vādere*.
- **a** continues Latin *ad*, “toward”; motion toward a goal became motion toward a coming event.
- **mi, tu, su** continue Latin *meus, tuus, suus*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “voy, vas, va”
- “voy a hablar, vas a comer, va a vivir”

- “mi café, tu café, su café”

Twice through: “Voy a hablar. Su café.”

Before you move on

Give the singular *ir* set. (*Voy, vas, va.*) Build “You are going to eat” for one friend. (*Vas a comer.*) Say “my coffee” and formal “your coffee.” (*Mi café; su café.*) Chapter 11 can now extend the grammar from this small, closed frontier.

Chapter 21

Verbs That Break in the Middle — the Stem Changers

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can express singular wanting and ability, compare the learned e-to-ie and o-to-ue changes, and say our with a known singular noun.

Complete ES-C11-practice, the canonical closing checkpoint, and demonstrate singular querer and poder, the learned vowel-change contrast, and nuestro or nuestra before a known singular noun.

21.1 querer — wanting with one familiar vowel change

You already say **tienes** and **tiene**, where the middle **e** opens into **ie**. Today, reuse that visible change in one useful verb and keep the same three-person frame you already own.

Sounds you'll need

- diphthong-ie — begin **quiero** with one smooth *kye*- syllable.
- r-tap — end the infinitive **querer** with one light tap.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

querer means “to want.” With a person as its object, it can also express love, but wanting is the meaning used in this lesson.

It descends from Latin **quaerere**, “to seek or ask.” English keeps the same searching idea in **query**, **quest**, **inquire**, and **require**. Wanting something begins as seeking it.

Grammar Lens: only the three singular forms

person	present of querer
yo	quiero
tú	quieres
él / ella / usted	quiere

Say the small set as **quiero** • **quieres** • **quiere**. The **e** → **ie** that you saw in **tienes**, **tiene** is visible again. The plural persons are deliberately left for a later step.

Place one known infinitive after the form of **querer**:

- **Quiero hablar.** — “I want to speak.”
- **Quieres comer.** — “You want to eat.”
- **Quiere vivir.** — “He, she, or formal you wants to live.”

The second verb stays in its known infinitive form.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “querer — quiero, quieres, quiere”
- “Quiero hablar”
- “quaerere — query — querer”

Before you move on

What does *querer* mean? (“To want.”) Give the three learned forms. (*Quiero, quieres, quiere.*) Which Latin verb and English cousin help explain it? (*Quaerere*, “seek”; *query* or *quest*.) Next: add the other

singular vowel change with **poder**.

21.2 poder — ability with the o → ue change

Quiero hablar says what you want to do. Now change the first verb to say what you are able to do. The second verb will remain a known infinitive.

Sounds you'll need

- diphthong-ue — **puedo** begins *pwe-* with one smooth glide.
- r-tap — end **poder** with one light tap.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

poder means “to be able”; in a sentence it often translates as “can.” It descends through Latin **potere** from **posse**, “to be able.” English **power**, **potent**, **potential**, and **possible** belong to the same family. Ability is the power to do something.

Grammar Lens: the three singular forms

person	present of poder
yo	puedo
tú	puedes
él / ella / usted	puede

Say **puedo** · **puedes** · **puede**. In these three learned forms, the stem **o** opens into **ue**. Plural persons wait.

Follow the form of **poder** with one unchanged infinitive:

- **Puedo hablar.** — “I can speak.”
- **Puedes comer.** — “You can eat.”
- **Puede vivir.** — “He, she, or formal you can live.”

Compare **Quiero hablar** with **Puedo hablar**: only the first verb changes the meaning from want to ability.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “poder — puedo, puedes, puede”
- “Puedo hablar”
- “poder — power — possible”

Before you move on

What does *poder* mean? (“To be able; can.”) Give the three learned forms. (*Puedo, puedes, puede.*) What English word is its close cousin? (*Power.*) Next: compare only the singular forms you have actually learned.

21.3 e → ie and o → ue — compare the singular forms

You now own three small singular sets: **tengo, tienes, tiene**; **quiero, quieres, quiere**; and **puedo, puedes, puede**. Compare only those learned forms before extending the pattern later.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

On the road from Latin to Spanish, many short **e** and **o** vowels opened when stressed: **e → ie** and **o → ue**. That history helps explain why a verb’s stem can look different across its forms.

It is a clue, not a machine that predicts every form. Learn each verb’s small set, then use the shared history to organize what you remember.

Grammar Lens: two changes, one learned frame

person	tener / querer, e → ie family	poder, o → ue
yo	tengo / quiero	puedo
tú	tienes / quieres	puedes
él / ella / usted	tiene / quiere	puede

The comparison says exactly this:

- **querer** shows **ie** in all three forms learned here.
- **poder** shows **ue** in all three forms learned here.
- **tener** reminds you that a common verb may combine more than one change: **tengo** has its known **g**, while **tiene**s and **tiene** show **ie**.

No plural form and no new verb is part of today's generalization.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “quiero, quieres, quiere”
- “puedo, puedes, puede”
- “stressed e and o often opened to ie and ue”

Before you move on

Which change appears in *querer*? (**e** → **ie**.) In *poder*? (**o** → **ue**.) Why is the history useful but not a complete prediction rule? (It organizes learned forms, but individual verbs can combine or resist changes.) Next: one possessive that agrees with a known noun's gender.

21.4 nuestro, nuestra — “our” with singular gender agreement

You put **mi**, **tu**, or **su** before the known noun **café**. Now add “our” and let it match one contrast you learned much earlier: masculine **día** beside feminine **noche**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

nuestro and **nuestra** mean “our.” They descend from Latin **noster**, also “our.” **Paternoster** means “Our Father,” and English **nostrum** originally meant “our thing.”

The change from *noster* to **nuestro** also displays the historical **o** → **ue**

opening you just used to organize **poder**.

Grammar Lens: match singular gender

known noun

el día, masculine

la noche, feminine

“our” phrase

nuestro día

nuestra noche

Like **mi**, **tu**, and **su**, the new word goes before the noun. Unlike those earlier forms, it shows the noun’s gender: **nuestro** before a masculine singular noun, **nuestra** before a feminine singular noun.

Only these two singular forms belong to this lesson. Plural agreement and the separate word for “your” to a group wait.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nuestro día”
- “nuestra noche”
- “noster — nuestro — Paternoster”

Before you move on

Which form goes before masculine *día*? (*Nuestro*.) Before feminine *noche*? (*Nuestra*.) What Latin source explains the pair? (*Noster*, “our.”) Next: retrieve the whole chapter without adding a form.

21.5 Practice — wanting, ability, and our known nouns

This checkpoint adds nothing. Retrieve two three-form verbs, compare their two vowel changes, and choose **nuestro** or **nuestra** before one known singular noun.

Grammar Lens: the complete small chapter frame

- wanting: **quiero** · **quieres** · **quiere** plus a known infinitive.
- ability: **puedo** · **puedes** · **puede** plus a known infinitive.
- the contrast: **e** → **ie** in the learned *querer* set; **o** → **ue** in the learned *poder* set.
- singular “our”: **nuestro día** · **nuestra noche**.

Plural persons and plural possessive agreement remain deferred.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **querer** continues Latin *quaerere*, “seek,” the family of **query**.
- **poder** continues the Latin ability family behind **power** and **possible**.
- stressed Latin **e** and **o** often opened into Spanish **ie** and **ue**.
- **nuestro**, **nuestra** continue Latin *noster*, “our.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “quiero hablar; puedo hablar”
- “quieres comer; puedes comer”
- “nuestro día; nuestra noche”

Before you move on

Give the two singular sets. (*Quiero, quieres, quiere; puedo, puedes, puede.*) Which vowel contrast organizes them? (**e** → **ie** beside **o** → **ue**.) Say “our day” and “our night.” (*Nuestro día; nuestra noche.*) Chapter 12 can now build from this closed singular frontier.

Chapter 22

Hacer, Decir, and the -go Verb Club

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 👁️ eyes (1) 🦋 Hands-free start: first 2 of 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can use the three learned singular forms of **hacer** and **decir** and compare **tengo**, **hago**, and **digo** without predicting unseen verbs.

Complete ES-C12-practice, the canonical closing checkpoint, and demonstrate the chapter promise with known words and only the learned singular person frame.

22.1 **hacer** — doing or making with three singular forms

You already use **tengo**, **tienes**, **tiene**, and you already know **café** and the question word **qué**. Reuse that small frontier for one verb that covers both English “do” and “make.”

Sounds you’ll need

The **h** in **hacer** is silent, just as it is in **hola**. In **hago**, the written **g** has the hard sound heard before **a**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hacer means “to do” or “to make.” It descends from Latin **facere**, with the same making root preserved in English **fact**, **factory**, and **manufacture**. Much of early Castilian changed word-initial Latin **f** into an **h** sound that later became silent, leaving the spelling as a historical trace.

Grammar Lens: only the three singular forms

person	present of <i>hacer</i>
yo	hago
tú	haces
él / ella / usted	hace

Say the bounded set as **hago · haces · hace**. Only the learned **yo** form contains **g**. Compare it with the familiar **tengo**, but do not extend the comparison beyond forms you already own.

Use the forms with one known object:

- **Hago café.** — “I make coffee.”
- **Haces café.** — “You make coffee.”
- **Hace café.** — “He, she, or formal you makes coffee.”

You can also ask **¿Qué haces?** — “What are you doing?” Plural persons and weather expressions wait for later lessons.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hacer — hago, haces, hace”
- “¿Qué haces? Hago café.”
- “facere — fact — factory — hacer”

Before you move on

What two English verbs does *hacer* cover? (“Do” and “make.”) Give the three learned forms. (*Hago, haces, hace.*) Which Latin source and English cousin help explain it? (*Facere; fact* or *factory.*) Next: add **decir** without widening the person frame.

22.2 decir — saying with the same small person frame

You can ask **cómo**, say **hola**, and retrieve **hago**, **haces**, **hace**.
Keep those three persons fixed while adding the verb “to say.”

Sounds you’ll need

In **dig**o, the **g** before **o** is hard. Keep the **i** in all three learned forms short and clear: **dig**o, **dices**, **dice**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

decir means “to say” or “to tell.” It descends from Latin **dīcere**, “to say.” English keeps the same root in **diction**, **dictionary**, **predict** (“say beforehand”), and **verdict** (“a true saying”).

Grammar Lens: one more three-form set

person	present of decir
yo	dig o
tú	dices
él / ella / usted	dice

Say **dig**o · **dices** · **dice**. The **yo** form has **g**, while the other two learned forms do not. Do not build a full table or a general vowel-change rule from this small set yet.

Now combine it only with known language:

- **Digo hola.** — “I say hello.”
- **Dices hola.** — “You say hello.”
- **Dice hola.** — “He, she, or formal you says hello.”
- **¿Cómo dices “hola”?** — “How do you say ‘hello’?”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “decir — digo, dices, dice”

- “Digo hola. ¿Cómo dices hola?”
- “dicere — diction — decir”

Before you move on

What does *decir* mean? (“To say” or “to tell.”) Give the three learned forms. (*Digo, dices, dice.*) Which Latin source and English cousin help explain it? (*Dicere; diction, dictionary, or predict.*) Next: compare only the three **yo** forms you have actually learned.

22.3 tengo · hago · digo — compare only what you know

Three learned verbs now place **g** in the **yo** form: **tengo, hago, digo**. Compare those three without guessing the form of any unseen verb.

Grammar Lens: one visible corner

infinitive	meaning	learned yo form	learned tú form
tener	to have	tengo	tienes
hacer	to do / make	hago	haces
decir	to say / tell	digo	dices

The shared observation is narrow: each learned **yo** form ends in **-go**, while each learned **tú** form does not. This is a memory organizer for three known forms, not permission to manufacture new ones.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The three modern forms did not arise by attaching one productive Latin **-go** ending. Older stem sounds changed in different ways, and analogy helped common verbs converge on a familiar shape. That mixed history explains why the group is useful to remember but unsafe as a prediction rule.

Later lessons can introduce other verbs on their own evidence. For now, the complete comparison is exactly **tengo · hago · digo**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “tengo — hago — digo”
- “tienes — haces — dices”
- “a memory organizer, not a prediction machine”

Before you move on

Which three learned **yo** forms end in **-go**? (*Tengo, hago, digo.*) May this comparison predict an unseen verb? (No.) Why not? (Different sound histories and analogy converged on the same shape.) Next: retrieve the whole chapter without adding any word or form.

22.4 Practice — doing, making, and saying in the singular

This checkpoint adds nothing. Retrieve two bounded three-form sets, use them with known words, and compare only **tengo**, **hago**, **digo**.

Grammar Lens: the complete small chapter frame

- doing or making: **hago** · **haces** · **hace**.
- saying or telling: **digo** · **dices** · **dice**.
- the learned **yo** comparison: **tengo** · **hago** · **digo**.
- known-word use: **Hago** café. **Digo** hola. ¿Cómo **dices** “hola”?

Plural persons, weather nouns, homework vocabulary, and unseen verbs remain outside this checkpoint.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **hacer** continues Latin *facere*, the making family of **fact** and **factory**.

- **decir** continues Latin *dicere*, the saying family of **diction** and **predict**.
- inherited sound changes and analogy made three known **yo** forms converge on **-go**; the resemblance does not predict forms you have not learned.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hago, haces, hace”
- “digo, dices, dice”
- “tengo, hago, digo”
- “Hago café. Digo hola.”

Before you move on

Give both three-form sets. (*Hago, haces, hace; digo, dices, dice.*) Which three learned **yo** forms share **-go**? (*Tengo, hago, digo.*) Why is that comparison a memory aid rather than a prediction rule? (Its mixed history does not license unseen forms.) Chapter 13 may now introduce its own verbs one at a time.

Chapter 23

Poner, Salir, Venir — Completing the -go Club

Modes: 🔄 voice (4) 🔄 Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can use the three learned singular forms of poner, salir, and venir and compare their yo forms with tengo, hago, and digo.

Complete ES-C13-practice, the canonical closing checkpoint, and demonstrate the chapter promise with known words and only the learned singular person frame.

23.1 poner — putting or placing with three singular forms

You already know **hago**, **haces**, **hace** and the careful comparison **tengo** · **hago** · **digo**. Add one verb on its own evidence: **poner**, “to put” or “to place.”

Sounds you’ll need

The **g** in **pongo** has the familiar hard sound. Tap the final **r** of **poner** lightly; do not turn it into the stronger written **rr** sound.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

poner descends from Latin **pōnere**, “to put or place.” English keeps the same placing family in **position**, **compose** (“place together”), and

deposit (“place down”). The two shapes **pon-** and **pos-** are historical relatives, so *poner* and *position* are cousins even though their endings differ.

Grammar Lens: only the three singular forms

person	present of <i>poner</i>
yo	pongo
tú	pones
él / ella / usted	pone

Say the bounded set as **pongo · pones · pone**. The learned **yo** form joins the known comparison because it ends in **-go**. That resemblance helps memory; it still does not predict an unseen verb.

For now, practise the forms and their meaning without importing a new object. Later lessons can add the nouns needed for expressions such as setting a table or putting on clothing. Plural persons and reflexive **ponerse** also wait.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “poner — pongo, pones, pone”
- “pōnere — position — poner”
- “a learned comparison, not a prediction rule”

Before you move on

What does *poner* mean? (“To put” or “to place.”) Give its three learned forms. (*Pongo, pones, pone.*) Which Latin source and English cousin help explain it? (*Pōnere; position, compose, or deposit.*) Next: learn **salir** inside the same three-person frame.

23.2 salir — leaving with three singular forms

You can retrieve **pongo, pones, pone**, and you already use **de** with a place name. Keep that frontier while adding **salir**, “to leave” or “to go out.”

Sounds you'll need

The **g** in **salgo** is hard. Keep the **l** clear in every form: **salgo**, **sales**, **sale**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

salir descends from Latin **salīre**, “to leap” or “to jump.” The older image of leaping outward developed into the everyday meaning “to go out.” English **salient** first carried the sense “leaping” or “springing,” and a **sally** is a sudden movement outward. Those cousins preserve the same motion without requiring a long list of uncertain relatives.

Grammar Lens: one more singular set

person	present of salir
yo	salgo
tú	sales
él / ella / usted	sale

Say **salgo** · **sales** · **sale**. Only the learned **yo** form contains **g**. Compare it with **pongo** because both forms are now known, not because one form could have predicted the other.

Reuse the known word **de** and the familiar place name Madrid:

- **Salgo de Madrid.** — “I leave Madrid.”
- **Sales de Madrid.** — “You leave Madrid.”
- **Sale de Madrid.** — “He, she, or formal you leaves Madrid.”

Plural persons, dating expressions, house vocabulary, and the noun for “exit” wait until their own lessons.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “salir — salgo, sales, sale”
- “Salgo de Madrid.”
- “salīre — salient — salir”

Before you move on

What does *salir* mean? (“To leave” or “to go out.”) Give the three learned forms. (*Salgo, sales, sale.*) What did Latin *salire* mean? (“To leap” or “to jump.”) Name one English cousin. (*Salient* or *sally.*) Next: add **venir** and compare it only with already-learned **tener**.

23.3 venir — coming with three singular forms

You can say **salgo de Madrid**, and you already know **tengo, tienes, tiene**. Now learn **venir**, “to come,” inside exactly the same three singular persons.

Sounds you’ll need

The **g** in **vengo** is hard. In **vienes** and **viene**, let **ie** move as one smooth vowel sequence.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

venir descends from Latin **venīre**, “to come.” English **convene** means “come together”; an **event** is something that “comes out”; and **adventure** passed through the idea of what may “come to” a person. The recurring **ven-** or **vent-** shape marks this old coming family.

Grammar Lens: one known comparison, still singular

person	present of venir	known tener comparison
yo	vengo	tengo
tú	vienes	tienes
él / ella / usted	viene	tiene

Say **vengo · tienes · viene**. The learned singular forms line up closely with **tengo · tienes · tiene**: the **yo** form ends in **-go**, while the other two show **ie**. This comparison describes two complete learned sets; it does not introduce a plural “boot” table or license guesses about other verbs.

Now contrast leaving and coming with known **de** and Madrid:

- **Salgo de Madrid.** — “I leave Madrid.”
- **Vengo de Madrid.** — “I come from Madrid.”
- **Vienes de Madrid.** — “You come from Madrid.”

Plural persons and free-standing arrival vocabulary wait for later lessons.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “venir — vengo, vienes, viene”
- “Vengo de Madrid.”
- “vengo / tengo — vienes / tienes”

Before you move on

What does *venir* mean? (“To come.”) Give its three learned forms. (*Vengo, vienes, viene.*) Which learned verb provides the close comparison? (*Tener: tengo, tienes, tiene.*) Which Latin source and English cousin help explain it? (*Venīre; convene, event, or adventure.*) Next: compare all six learned **yo** forms only after retrieving this chapter’s three verbs.

23.4 Practice — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular

This checkpoint adds nothing. Retrieve the three bounded singular sets first. Only then widen the memory comparison from three learned **yo** forms to six.

Grammar Lens: the complete Chapter 13 frame

- putting or placing: **pongo** • **pones** • **pone.**
- leaving or going out: **salgo** • **sales** • **sale.**
- coming: **vengo** • **vienes** • **viene.**

- known-word contrast: **Salgo de Madrid. Vengo de Madrid.**
- known singular comparison: **vengo / tengo · vienes / tienes · viene / tiene.**

Now that all three new verbs have been taught, the learned **yo** comparison can grow to exactly **tengo · hago · digo · pongo · salgo · vengo**. It remains a retrieval aid, not a rule for predicting any unseen verb.

Plural persons, full boot diagrams, reflexive clothing expressions, house and table nouns, clock times, dinner vocabulary, and other unseen contexts remain outside this checkpoint.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **poner** continues Latin *pōnere*, the placing family of **position**.
- **salir** continues Latin *salīre*, the leaping family of **salient**.
- **venir** continues Latin *venīre*, the coming family of **convene**.
- different inherited histories and analogy let the six known **yo** forms converge on **-go**; the shared shape does not make a productive prediction rule.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pongo, pones, pone”
- “salgo, sales, sale”
- “vengo, vienes, viene”
- “tengo, hago, digo, pongo, salgo, vengo”

Before you move on

Give all three new singular sets. (*Pongo, pones, pone; salgo, sales, sale; vengo, vienes, viene.*) Which six learned **yo** forms now share **-go**? (*Tengo, hago, digo, pongo, salgo, vengo.*) Why is the list a memory aid rather than a prediction rule? (Different histories con-

verged on one shape.) Chapter 14 may now introduce a new time frame without borrowing any plural form from this chapter.

Chapter 24

The Preterite — Your First Past Tense

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can use the singular completed past of ser or ir and the known regular -ar verb hablar.

Complete ES-C14-practice and distinguish fui/fuiste/fue from hablé/hablaste/habló using known words, context, and written stress.

24.1 fui — one past set shared by ser and ir

You already use **ser** for identity and **ir** for going. Spanish now gives both verbs one completed-past set. This lesson keeps the same three singular persons you know: **fui**, **fuiste**, **fue**.

Grammar Lens: three singular forms, two verbs

person	completed past of ser or ir
yo	fui
tú	fuiste
él / ella / usted	fue

Say **fui** · **fuiste** · **fue**. Each form can belong to either verb. The surrounding words decide which meaning is possible:

- **Fui a Madrid.** — “I went to Madrid.” The known **a** plus a destination points to **ir**.

- **Fue Roberto.** — “It was Roberto.” Identification points to **ser**.

Fui and **fue** are one-syllable words, so standard Spanish spelling gives them no written accent. Plural forms wait until a later lesson.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The shared set continues the Latin perfect family of “be,” including Latin **fuī**, “I have been.” Sound change and analogy reshaped the inherited forms. Spanish **ir** then came to share this past family with **ser**: a case of **suppletion**, where one verb draws forms from more than one historical root. English **go** / **went** uses the same broad strategy, although not the same words.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “fui, fuiste, fue”
- “Fui a Madrid.”
- “Fue Roberto — identification, so ser.”

Before you move on

Give the three shared forms. (*Fui, fuiste, fue.*) Which two verbs share them? (*Ser* and *ir.*) What decides the meaning? (Context.) What older family supplied the forms? (The Latin perfect family of “be.”) Next, reuse the known verb **hablar** to build a regular singular past.

24.2 **hablé** — a regular singular past from a known verb

You know **hablar** and its present singular **hablo**, **hablas**, **habla**. To say that the speaking was completed, keep **habl-** and learn three new endings: **hablé**, **hablaste**, **habló**.

Grammar Lens: present beside completed past

person	present	completed past
yo	hablo	hablé
tú	hablas	hablaste
él / ella / usted	habla	habló

Say **hablé** · **hablaste** · **habló**. This is a complete singular pattern, not a preview of plural forms. Notice the exact changes:

- **hablo** → **hablé** changes the final vowel and moves stress to the end.
- **hablas** → **hablaste** adds the past ending **-aste**.
- **habla** → **habló** changes the final vowel and moves stress to the end.

Grammar Lens: two accents, one natural stress pattern

The written accents in **hablé** and **habló** show final stress. Without those marks, words ending in a vowel normally stress the next-to-last syllable. **Hablaste** already follows that ordinary pattern — **blas** is next to last — so it needs no written accent. The mark records the stress; it is not the only change that makes a form past.

Now reuse known words:

- **Hablé español.** — “I spoke Spanish.”
- **¿Hablaste español?** — “Did you speak Spanish?”
- **Habló español.** — “He, she, or you-formal spoke Spanish.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The regular **-ar** past continues material from the Latin first-conjugation perfect, visible in forms such as **amāvī**, **amāvistī**, **amāvit**. Centuries of sound change and analogy produced the Spanish family **-é**, **-aste**, **-ó**. The history explains a family resemblance; it is not one tidy letter-by-letter erosion for every modern ending.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablé, hablaste, hablé”
- “Hablo español. Hablé español.”
- “hablé and hablé carry written accents; hablaste does not”

Before you move on

Give the three learned past forms. (*Hablé, hablaste, hablé.*) Which two carry written accents, and why? (*Hablé* and *hablé*; the marks show final stress.) What older family lies behind the endings? (The Latin first-conjugation perfect.) Next: choose between the two past patterns using only known words.

24.3 Practice — two singular ways to talk about a completed past

This checkpoint adds nothing. Retrieve the shared singular set and the regular **hablar** set, then use context and spelling to keep them apart.

Grammar Lens: the complete Chapter 14 frame

- shared past of **ser** and **ir**: **fui** • **fuiste** • **fue**.
- regular past of **hablar**: **hablé** • **hablaste** • **hablé**.
- context: **Fui a Madrid** expresses **ir**; **Fue Roberto** expresses **ser**.
- time contrast: **Hablo español** is present; **Hablé español** is completed past.
- spelling: **hablé** and **hablé** show final stress with a written accent; **hablaste** needs none.

Plural persons, additional past-tense verb classes, new time words, and new place or person vocabulary wait for later lessons.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The **fui** family continues Latin perfect “be” material and became shared by **ser** and **ir**. The regular **-ar** endings continue Latin first-conjugation perfect material, reshaped by sound change and analogy.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “fui, fuiste, fue”
- “hablé, hablaste, hablé”
- “Fui a Madrid. Fue Roberto.”
- “Hablo español. Hablé español.”

Before you move on

Give both singular sets. (*Fui, fuiste, fue; hablé, hablaste, hablé.*) How does context separate **ser** from **ir**? (A destination points to going; identification points to being.) Which regular forms carry written accents? (*Hablé* and *hablé.*) Chapter 15 can add another past family without borrowing plural forms or unseen vocabulary from this checkpoint.

Chapter 25

Completing the Preterite — Three Families, One Question

Modes: 🗣️ voice (6) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 6 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can form the singular completed past of regular -er/-ir verbs and the known strong verbs tener, hacer, and estar.

Complete ES-C15-practice and retrieve the bounded singular sets for comer, vivir, tener, hacer, and estar with their spelling and historical contrasts.

25.1 comí — one regular -er singular past

You know present **como**, **comes**, **come** and the singular **-ar** past. To make a completed past from **comer**, keep **com-** and learn three forms: **comí**, **comiste**, **comió**.

Grammar Lens: present beside completed past

person	present	completed past
yo	como	comí
tú	comes	comiste
él / ella / usted	come	comió

Say **comí** · **comiste** · **comió**. Keep the limit visible: these are the same three familiar singular persons. Plural forms wait.

Grammar Lens: final stress in two forms

Comí and **comió** carry written accents because their stress falls on the final vowel. **Comiste** follows ordinary next-to-last stress, so it needs no mark. The three forms by themselves make complete utterances:

- **Comí.** — “I ate.”
- **¿Comiste?** — “Did you eat?”
- **Comió.** — “He, she, or you-formal ate.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish **comer** continues Latin **comedere**. Its regular past endings also continue Latin perfect material, including forms with **-ī**, **-istī**, **-it**. Sound change and analogy reshaped that material across Romance into Spanish **-í**, **-iste**, **-ió**. The resemblance is real, but it is not one tidy chain in which every modern ending merely drops a letter.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “comí, comiste, comió”
- “Como. Comí.”
- “comí and comió carry final-stress accents”

Before you move on

Give the three learned **comer** forms. (*Comí, comiste, comió.*) Which carry written accents? (*Comí* and *comió.*) What shaped the modern endings? (Latin perfect material, sound change, and analogy.) Next: reuse the same endings with a known **-ir** verb.

25.2 viví — reuse one past pattern with an -ir verb

You know present **vivo, vives, vive**, and you just learned past **comí, comiste, comió**. Keep **viv-** and reuse those three past endings: **viví, viviste, vivió**.

Grammar Lens: one -ir singular past

person	present	completed past
yo	vivo	viví
tú	vives	viviste
él / ella / usted	vive	vivió

Say **viví** · **viviste** · **vivió**. Reuse known **en** for a small contrast:

- **Vivo en Madrid.** — “I live in Madrid.”
- **Viví en Madrid.** — “I lived in Madrid.”
- **¿Viviste en Madrid?** — “Did you live in Madrid?”
- **Vivió en Madrid.** — “He, she, or you-formal lived in Madrid.”

The written accents in **viví** and **vivió** show final stress. **Viviste** already has ordinary next-to-last stress and needs no mark.

Grammar Lens: -er and -ir meet in this past

person	comer	vivir
yo	comí	viví
tú	comiste	viviste
él / ella / usted	comió	vivió

The shared endings are **-í** in the first row, **-iste** in the second, and **-ió** in the third. The presents differ, but these two singular past rows converge on one ending set. That is a fact about the forms you have learned, not permission to guess plural forms; those wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish **vivir** continues Latin **vīvere**. Its modern past endings belong to the same Romance history as the **comer** endings: Latin perfect material was reshaped by sound change and analogy. The shared **-iste** is a useful family resemblance, not proof of one simple letter-by-letter erosion.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “viví, viviste, vivió”
- “Vivo en Madrid. Viví en Madrid.”
- “comí and viví share -í; comió and vivió share -ió”

Before you move on

Give the three learned **vivir** forms. (*Viví, viviste, vivió.*) Which past endings do **comer** and **vivir** share? (*-í, -iste, -ió.*) Which two carry written accents? (*Viví* and *vivió.*) Next, keep the singular limit but let the stem change.

25.3 tuve — let the strong stem carry the stress

You know present **tengo, tienes, tiene**. Its completed past changes the stem to **tuv-** and uses **tuve, tuviste, tuvo**. Unlike **comí** and **comió**, none of these three forms carries a written accent.

Grammar Lens: one strong singular pattern

person	present	completed past
yo	tengo	tuve
tú	tienes	tuviste
él / ella / usted	tiene	tuvo

The strong stem **tuv-** takes **-e, -iste, -o**. Say **tuve · tuviste · tuvo**. Stress remains in the stem, so normal spelling needs no accent mark. Reuse known **café**:

- **Tuve café.** — “I had coffee.”
- **¿Tuviste café?** — “Did you have coffee?”
- **Tuvo café.** — “He, she, or you-formal had coffee.”

“Strong” describes the stem-stressed historical pattern. It does not mean that the meaning is forceful. Plural endings wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Tener continues Latin **tenēre**. Its past also belongs to an older strong history associated with Latin **tenuī**. Spanish sound change and analogy reshaped that material into the **tuv-** family. **Tenuī** → **tuve** is therefore a historical relationship, not a promise that every letter passed across intact.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “tuve, tuviste, tuvo”
- “Tuve café.”
- “comí has final stress; tuve has stem stress”

Before you move on

Give the three learned **tener** forms. (*Tuve, tuviste, tuvo.*) Which endings attach to **tuv-**? (*-e, -iste, -o.*) Why are there no written accents? (The strong stem carries the stress.) What shaped **tuve** historically? (Older strong-perfect material, sound change, and analogy.) Next: reuse the strong endings with **hacer**.

25.4 hice — the strong pattern with one third-person swerve

You know present **hago, haces, hace** and strong past **tuve, tuviste, tuvo**. **Hacer** reuses the strong endings: **hice, hiciste, hizo**. Watch the third form: the stem is **hiz-** there, not **hic-**.

Grammar Lens: hacer in the completed past

person	completed past	stem plus ending
yo	hice	hic- + -e
tú	hiciste	hic- + -iste
él / ella / usted	hizo	hiz- + -o
Say hice · hiciste · hizo . These are strong, stem-stressed forms		

with no written accents. **Hizo** is an irregular stem alternation inside this family; it is not a general rule that **c** must become **z** before **o**. Reuse known **café**:

- **Hice café.** — “I made coffee.”
- **¿Hiciste café?** — “Did you make coffee?”
- **Hizo café.** — “He, she, or you-formal made coffee.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Hacer continues Latin **facere**, and **hice** continues the history of its strong perfect **fēcī**. Long sound changes help explain Spanish **h-** and the changed vowel and consonant; this is not a direct spelling recipe. The pattern links **hice** historically to strong **tuve**, while each verb keeps its own stem.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hice, hiciste, hizo”
- “Hice café.”
- “hizo is a learned hiz- alternation, not a general c-before-o rule”

Before you move on

Give the three learned **hacer** forms. (*Hice, hiciste, hizo.*) What changes in the third form? (**Hic-** becomes **hiz-**.) Is that a general **c-before-o** spelling rule? (No; learn it inside this irregular family.) What older form lies behind **hice**? (Latin **fēcī**, through substantial historical change.) Next: add strong **estar** without adding plural forms.

25.5 **estuve** — a third known verb joins the strong pattern

You know present **estoy, estás, está** and the strong past pairs **tuve, tuviste, tuvo** and **hice, hiciste, hizo**. Now use the

same strong endings with **estuv-**: **estuve**, **estuviste**, **estuvo**.

Grammar Lens: *estar* in the completed past

person	completed past
yo	estuve
tú	estuviste
él / ella / usted	estuvo

Say **estuve** · **estuviste** · **estuvo**. The strong stem **estuv-** takes **-e**, **-iste**, **-o**. These forms carry no written accents. Reuse known **bien**:

- **Estuve bien.** — “I was well.”
- **¿Estuviste bien?** — “Were you well?”
- **Estuvo bien.** — “He, she, or you-formal was well.”

Grammar Lens: three strong singular rows

- yo: **tuve** · **hice** · **estuve**.
- tú: **tuviste** · **hiciste** · **estuviste**.
- él / ella / usted: **tuvo** · **hizo** · **estuvo**.

All three rows use the learned strong endings. Only **hacer** changes its stem shape from **hic-** to **hiz-** before third-person **-o**. Plural forms and other irregular verbs still wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Estar grew from a Romance verb related to Latin **stāre**, “stand.” But modern **estuve** is not a direct, tidy wearing-down of Latin **stetī**. Historical analogy helped reshape its past beside other strong forms, including the **-uv-** pattern visible in **tuve**. This explains the family resemblance without pretending that each modern letter came straight from one Latin form.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “estuve, estuviste, estuvo”

- “Estuve bien.”
- “tuve and estuve share -uv- through historical analogy”

Before you move on

Give the three learned **estar** forms. (*Estuve, estuviste, estuvo.*) Which known strong verb shares their **-uv-** shape? (*Tener: tuve.*) Why should **estuve** not be shown as a direct wearing-down of **stetī**? (Analogy reshaped the Spanish family.) Next: retrieve all six bounded patterns.

25.6 Practice — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary

This checkpoint adds nothing. Retrieve only the three singular persons of each learned row. Every word in the short sentences is already known.

Grammar Lens: the complete Chapter 15 frame

Regular rows:

- yo: **hablé** · **comí** · **viví**.
- tú: **hablaste** · **comiste** · **viviste**.
- él / ella / usted: **habló** · **comió** · **vivió**.

Strong rows:

- yo: **tuve** · **hice** · **estuve**.
- tú: **tuviste** · **hiciste** · **estuviste**.
- él / ella / usted: **tuvo** · **hizo** · **estuvo**.

The **-er** and **-ir** rows share **-í**, **-iste**, **-ió**. The three strong rows share **-e**, **-iste**, **-o**, but their stems must be learned: **tuv-**, **hic-/hiz-**, **estuv-**. Plural persons, more strong verbs, and new time or setting vocabulary remain outside this checkpoint.

Grammar Lens: let spelling show the stress

- Regular **comí, comió, viví, vivió** carry written accents for final stress.
- Strong **tuve, tuvo, hice, hizo, estuve, estuvo** carry no written accents; stress remains in the strong stem.
- **Comiste** and **viviste** need no accent because their ordinary stress is already next to last.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The regular **-er/-ir** endings continue Latin perfect material reshaped across Romance. **Tuve** and **hice** continue older strong-perfect histories, also reshaped rather than copied letter for letter. **Estuve** shows especially clear analogical remodeling beside the **-uv-** family of **tuve**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablé, comí, viví”
- “tuve, hice, estuve”
- “Hice café. Viví en Madrid. Estuve bien.”
- “comí and comió have accents; tuve and tuvo do not”

Before you move on

Give the regular **comer** and **vivir** sets. (*Comí, comiste, comió; viví, viviste, vivió.*) Give the three strong sets. (*Tuve, tuviste, tuvo; hice, hiciste, hizo; estuve, estuviste, estuvo.*) Which rows share endings? (**-er/-ir** share one regular set; the strong rows share another.) Chapter 16 can add a new past contrast without borrowing any plural form here.

Chapter 26

The Imperfect — the Past That Kept Going

Modes: 🗣️ voice (8) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 8 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can use the Spanish imperfect for past habits, background, and actions in progress.

Complete ES-C16-practice and retrieve the bounded singular imperfect rows for hablar, comer, vivir, ser, ir, and newly learned ver while contrasting open and completed past viewpoints.

26.1 hablaba — let a past action stay open

Hablé español presents speaking as a completed past event. A different past, the **imperfect**, can leave the action open: **Hablaba español** — “I was speaking Spanish” or “I used to speak Spanish.” The sentence does not say where the action ended.

Grammar Lens: three familiar persons

person	open or habitual past
yo	hablaba
tú	hablabas
él / ella / usted	hablaba

Say **hablaba** · **hablabas** · **hablaba**. The first and third forms are identical; the surrounding conversation or an explicit person tells you

who is speaking. Plural persons wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish **-aba** continues the Latin imperfect family in **-ābam**. Historical sound change reshaped the complete Latin forms, but the **b** remains a useful audible bridge between **-ābam** and Spanish **-aba**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablaba, hablabas, hablaba”
- “Hablé español. Hablaba español.”
- “-ābam and -aba share b”

Before you move on

Give the three learned forms. (*Hablaba, hablabas, hablaba.*) What can the imperfect do? (Leave a past action ongoing or habitual.) Which Latin family stands behind **-aba**? (**-ābam**.) Next: build the same gentle frame with **comer**.

26.2 comía — hear both vowels

Comí presents eating as completed. **Comía** leaves it open or habitual: “I was eating” or “I used to eat.” One accent separates the two forms in writing and in sound.

Grammar Lens: the singular -er row

person	open or habitual past
yo	comía
tú	comías
él / ella / usted	comía
Say comía · comías · comía . As with hablaba , the first and third forms match. Plural persons wait.	

Grammar Lens: co-mí-a

The accent in **-ía** keeps **i** and **a** in separate syllables: **co-mí-a**, three beats. It appears in every form learned here. Compare final stress in **comí** with the middle stress and extra syllable in **comía**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The **-er** imperfect continues a Romance reshaping of Latin **-ēbam** material. Among the changes, an intervocalic **b** was lost; later Spanish spelling marks the stressed **í** that keeps **i-a** apart. This is a layered history, not a single instruction to delete one letter.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “comía, comías, comía”
- “Comí. Comía.”
- “co-mí-a”

Before you move on

Give the three learned forms. (*Comía, comías, comía.*) What does the accent do? (Keeps **i** and **a** apart.) Which Latin family lies behind the ending? (**-ēbam**, reshaped through Romance.) Next: test whether **vivir** can reuse this row.

26.3 vivía — reuse the complete -er row

Chapter 15 let **comer** and **vivir** share one completed-past row. They converge again here. Replace **com-** in **comía, comías, comía** with **viv-**.

Grammar Lens: one row reused

person	comer	vivir
yo	comía	vivía
tú	comías	vivías
él / ella / usted	comía	vivía

Say **vivía** · **vivías** · **vivía**. **-er** and **-ir** share **-ía**, **-ías**, **-ía**. The accent still keeps **i-a** apart. Plural persons wait.

Grammar Lens: one known contrast

- **Viví en Madrid.** — presents living there as a completed stretch.
- **Vivía en Madrid.** — puts us inside that past stretch or treats it as background.

Both are past. The speaker chooses how to frame the event.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Vivir continues Latin **vīvere**. Its infinitive belongs to the Spanish **-ir** class, but the imperfect has converged with **-er**. That shared row is a reliable fact about these learned forms, not a claim that the two conjugations are identical everywhere.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “vivía, vivías, vivía”
- “comía and vivía share -ía”
- “Viví en Madrid. Vivía en Madrid.”

Before you move on

Give the three **vivir** forms. (*Vivía, vivías, vivía.*) Which class shares them? (**-er**.) What contrast can **viví** / **vivía** make? (Completed stretch versus an open or background past.) Next: learn **ver** before asking it to enter this tense.

26.4 ver — learn the verb before its past

Ver means “to see.” Its written **v** uses the Spanish sound you already know: it is not contrasted with a separate English-style **v** sound. Say **ver**.

Grammar Lens: three present forms

person	present
yo	veo
tú	ves
él / ella / usted	ve

The **tú** and third-person forms resemble the familiar **-er** row. The **yo** form keeps an extra vowel: **veo**. Reuse known **café**: **Veo café** — “I see coffee.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish **ver** continues Latin **vidēre**, “to see,” through Old Spanish **veer**. Loss of the consonant between vowels helps explain the shorter shape; the two adjacent vowels later contracted in the infinitive. English **video** belongs to the same Latin family, a memory bridge rather than a new Spanish word for this lesson.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ver — to see”
- “veo, ves, ve”
- “ver comes through veer from vidēre”

Before you move on

What does **ver** mean? (“To see.”) Give its three learned present forms. (*Veo, ves, ve.*) Which Latin verb stands behind it? (**Vidēre.**) Next: add **ser** to the open past.

26.5 era — an old root in an open past

You know present **soy, eres, es** and completed-past **fui, fuiste, fue**. The open or background past of **ser** uses a different short stem: **era**.

Grammar Lens: the singular ser row

person	open or background past
yo	era
tú	eras
él / ella / usted	era

Say **era · eras · era**. The first and third forms match, just as they did in the regular imperfect rows. **¿Era usted?** asks “Was it you?” without adding a new noun. Plural persons wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Era continues Latin **eram**, an old form in the **esse** family. That is the family already connected to Spanish **ser** and English **essence**. The preterite **fue** comes from another historical set, so **era / fue** is a real contrast inside one modern verb.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “era, eras, era”
- “¿Era usted?”
- “era comes from Latin eram”

Before you move on

Give the three learned **ser** forms. (*Era, eras, era*.) Which past form supplies background, **era** or **fue**? (**Era**.) Which Latin form stands behind it? (**Eram**.) Next: follow **ir** back toward its own older verb.

26.6 iba — ir returns to its inherited past

Present **voy** and completed-past **fui** came from different historical sets. For an open or habitual past, **ir** gives you **iba** — “I was going” or “I used to go.”

Grammar Lens: the singular ir row

person	open or habitual past
yo	iba
tú	ibas
él / ella / usted	iba

Say **iba ·ibas · iba**. Reuse the destination frame: **Iba a Madrid** — “I was going to Madrid” or “I used to go to Madrid.” Plural persons wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Iba continues Latin **ībam**, from **īre**, the inherited verb behind the Spanish infinitive **ir**. Present **voy** contains material associated with **vādere**, while preterite **fui** comes from the Latin “be” perfect family. These sources help explain the three learned sets; they do not mean that every form in every tense can be assigned to one source by a three-box rule.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “iba,ibas,iba”
- “Fui a Madrid. Iba a Madrid.”
- “iba continues ībam from īre”

Before you move on

Give the three learned forms. (*Iba,ibas,iba*.) Say “I was going to Madrid.” (*Iba a Madrid*.) Which Latin form stands behind **iba**? (**ībam**, from **īre**.) Next: put newly learned **ver** into the same past.

26.7 veía — keep the extra e you already met

You learned **ver** before its past: **veo**, **ves**, **ve**. Its imperfect keeps **ve-** and adds the familiar **-ía** row. That gives **veía** — “I was seeing” or “I used to see.”

Grammar Lens: the singular ver row

person	open or habitual past
yo	veía
tú	veías
él / ella / usted	veía

Say **veía** · **veías** · **veía**. Keep **í-a** in separate syllables. Plural persons wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Old Spanish **veer** displays the **ve-** shape clearly. The imperfect **veía** preserves that vowel before the familiar **-ía** material. It is useful to call this an exceptional learned row, but not to pretend that **ver** was already known before this chapter or that the history is merely “regular plus one letter.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “veía, veías, veía”
- “Veo café. Veía café.”
- “veer helps explain ve-”

Before you move on

Give the three learned forms. (*Veía, veías, veía.*) Which vowel stays before **-ía**? (**e**.) Which earlier form displays it? (**Veer**.) Next: retrieve every Chapter 16 row and make a few bounded contrasts.

26.8 Practice — keep the past open or close it

This checkpoint adds no vocabulary and no plural persons. Retrieve the seven learned singular rows, then choose whether a known sentence presents the past as completed or leaves it open as background, progress, or habit.

Grammar Lens: the complete Chapter 16 frame

Regular rows:

- yo: **hablaba** · **comía** · **vivía**.
- tú: **hablabas** · **comías** · **vivías**.
- él / ella / usted: **hablaba** · **comía** · **vivía**.

The three special rows:

- yo: **era** · **iba** · **veía**.
- tú: **eras** · **ibas** · **veías**.
- él / ella / usted: **era** · **iba** · **veía**.

The first and third forms match in every learned row. **Comer** and **vivir** share **-ía**, **-ías**, **-ía**. **Ver** keeps **ve-** before that material. Plural persons remain outside this checkpoint.

Grammar Lens: one scene, two frames

- **Hablé español.** — completed event. **Hablaba español.** — open, background, or habitual speaking.
- **Viví en Madrid.** — completed stretch. **Vivía en Madrid.** — we stand inside that past stretch.
- **Fui a Madrid.** — completed trip. **Iba a Madrid.** — motion was in progress or habitual.

The tense does not mechanically report how long something lasted. It frames the past from a different viewpoint.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

-aba continues the Latin **-ābam** family. **-ía** continues material from the **-ēbam** family after several Romance changes. **Era** continues **eram**; **iba** continues **ībam** from **īre**; and **veía** keeps the **ve-** shape also visible in Old Spanish **veer**. These are historical bridges, not recipes for generating unlearned forms.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablaba, comía, vivía”
- “era, iba, veía”
- “Hablé / hablaba · viví / vivía · fui / iba”

Before you move on

Give the six **yo** forms. (*Hablaba, comía, vivía, era, iba, veía.*) Which two regular classes share a row? (**-er** and **-ir**.) What is the core contrast? (The preterite presents a completed event; the imperfect leaves past action open, habitual, in progress, or in the background.) Chapter 17 can now build on **-ía** without borrowing a plural form here.

Chapter 27

The Future and the Conditional — One Weld, Twice

Modes: 🗣️ voice (7) 👁️ eyes (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: first 7 of 8 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can form the Spanish future and conditional from the infinitive and use each for its core meaning.

Complete ES-C17-practice and retrieve the bounded singular future and conditional rows for hablar, comer, and vivir plus the learned har-, tendr-, and podr- stems.

27.1 hablaré — keep the infinitive, add the future

Voy a **hablar español** uses the near-future frame you already know. Spanish also has a one-word future: **Hablaré español** — “I will speak Spanish.” It can present a future prediction or intention without adding a new subject or object.

Grammar Lens: three familiar persons

Keep the whole infinitive **hablar**, then add one ending:

person	simple future
yo	hablaré
tú	hablarás
él / ella / usted	hablará

Say **hablaré · hablarás · hablará**. Each form has final stress, marked by an accent. Plural persons wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Late Latin and early Romance used more than one way to speak about the future. One influential construction placed an infinitive beside present forms of Latin **habēre**, “to have.” Through repeated use and sound change, descendants of those pieces became the endings in forms such as **hablaré**.

That history explains why the infinitive remains visible. It does **not** mean that a modern learner should attach the full modern verb **haber**, and it does not require the claim that every older future vanished at one moment.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablaré, hablarás, hablará”
- “Voy a hablar español. Hablaré español.”
- “infinitive plus historical habēre material”

Before you move on

Give the three learned forms. (*Hablaré, hablarás, hablará.*) What stays visible? (The whole infinitive.) What older verb contributed to the endings? (Latin **habēre**.) Next: test the same endings on **comer**.

27.2 comeré — the same endings keep -er

You built **hablaré** without removing **-ar**. Keep **comer** just as intact: **comeré** — “I will eat.”

Grammar Lens: the singular -er row

person	simple future
yo	comeré
tú	comerás
él / ella / usted	comerá
Say comeré · comerás · comerá . Compare hablaré / comeré :	

the infinitives differ, but the future endings do not. Plural persons wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The historical infinitive-plus-**habēre** construction helps explain the shared endings: the verb-family vowel remains inside **hablar** or **comer**, rather than selecting a different ending set.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “comeré, comerás, comerá”
- “Hablaré. Comeré.”
- “Beberé café.”

Before you move on

Give the three learned forms. (*Comeré, comerás, comerá.*) Did the **-er** disappear? (No.) Which endings match **hablar**? (**-é, -ás, -á.**) Next: let **vivir** test the pattern once more.

27.3 viviré — one future row for three verb families

Hablaré kept **-ar**. **Comeré** kept **-er**. Predict the yo future of **vivir** before reading on. It is **viviré**.

Grammar Lens: the singular -ir row

person	simple future
yo	viviré
tú	vivirás
él / ella / usted	vivirá

Say **viviré · vivirás · vivirá**. Now the bounded pattern is complete: **hablaré, comeré, viviré**. The same three endings attach to all three whole infinitives. Plural persons wait.

Grammar Lens: meaning with known words

Viviré en Madrid says “I will live in Madrid.” Every lexical piece was available before this lesson; only the future form is new.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “viviré, vivirás, vivirá”
- “hablaré, comeré, viviré”
- “Viviré en Madrid.”

Before you move on

Give the three **vivir** forms. (*Viviré, vivirás, vivirá.*) Which verb families share the learned endings? (All three: **-ar**, **-er**, **-ir**.) Next: reuse the whole-infinitive frame for “would.”

27.4 hablaría — the whole infinitive meets -ía

Hablaré español places speaking in the future. **Hablaría español** means “I would speak Spanish” in an imagined or conditional situation. Today the situation can remain unstated; learn the form and its core “would” meaning first.

Grammar Lens: three familiar persons

Keep **hablar** whole, then add the learned singular conditional endings:

person	conditional
yo	hablaría
tú	hablarías
él / ella / usted	hablaría

Say **hablaría · hablarías · hablaría**. The first and third forms match. The accent keeps **í-a** in separate syllables, just as it did in **comía**. Plural persons wait.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The conditional developed from an infinitive beside past or imperfect forms of the same “have” verb that helped form the Romance future. That is why the whole infinitive remains visible again and why the endings resemble the **-ía** row. The history passes through older Romance forms; modern **hablaría** is not made by attaching the complete modern word **había**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablaría, hablarías, hablaría”
- “Hablaré español. Hablaría español.”
- “ha-bla-rí-a”

Before you move on

Give the three learned forms. (*Hablaría, hablarías, hablaría.*) What is the core meaning? (“Would speak.”) Which older construction stands behind the row? (An infinitive plus past forms of **haber**.) Next: give **comer** the same ending set.

27.5 comería — keep -er before “would”

Comeré means “I will eat.” Keep **comer** whole and exchange the future ending for **-ía**: **comería** — “I would eat.”

Grammar Lens: the singular -er row

person	conditional
yo	comería
tú	comerías
él / ella / usted	comería

Say **comería** • **comerías** • **comería**. Compare **hablaría** / **comería**: one bounded ending set serves both complete infinitives. Plural persons wait.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “comería, comerías, comería”
- “comeré, comería”
- “hablaría, comería”

Before you move on

Give the three learned forms. (*Comería, comerías, comería.*) Which piece stays whole? (**Comer.**) Which endings match **hablaría**? (**-ía, -ías, -ía.**) Next: complete the regular pattern with **vivir**.

27.6 viviría — the regular conditional closes its small frame

You can move from **comeré** to **comería**. Apply the same move to **viviré**: **viviría** — “I would live.”

Grammar Lens: the singular -ir row

person	conditional
yo	viviría
tú	vivirías
él / ella / usted	viviría
Say viviría · vivirías · viviría . The complete regular frame is now hablaría, comería, viviría . Plural persons wait.	

Grammar Lens: meaning with known words

Viviría en Madrid says “I would live in Madrid.” The lesson adds no new place or preposition.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “viviría, vivirías, viviría”

- “hablaría, comería, viviría”
- “Viviría en Madrid.”

Before you move on

Give the three **vivir** forms. (*Viviría, vivirías, viviría.*) Which regular verb families share the ending row? (All three.) Next: three already-known verbs change the stem but keep both sets of endings.

27.7 haré · tendré · podré — three stems, two ending sets

Regular verbs keep the whole infinitive. Three common verbs you already know use a shorter or reshaped stem. Learn only these three today. In each row, the **same** stem serves the future and the conditional.

Grammar Lens: hacer becomes har-

person	future	conditional
yo	haré	haría
tú	harás	harías
él / ella / usted	hará	haría

Use the known noun in **Haré café** — “I will make coffee” — and **Haría café** — “I would make coffee.”

Grammar Lens: tener becomes tendr-

person	future	conditional
yo	tendré	tendría
tú	tendrás	tendrías
él / ella / usted	tendrá	tendría

The **d** in **tendr-** arose during the history of the compact future and conditional. Treat **tendr-** as the learned stem, not as permission to insert **d** into a new verb.

Grammar Lens: poder becomes podr-

person	future	conditional
yo	podré	podría
tú	podrás	podrías
él / ella / usted	podrá	podría

Podré hablar español says “I will be able to speak Spanish.” **Podría hablar español** says “I could / would be able to speak Spanish.”

These stems reflect inherited reductions and sound changes. The useful modern fact is bounded: **har-** · **tendr-** · **podr-**, each followed by the same endings you already learned.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “haré, haría”
- “tendré, tendría”
- “podré, podría”

Before you move on

Give the three learned stems. (**Har-**, **tendr-**, **podr-**.) Does each verb need separate future and conditional stems? (No; one stem serves both.) Do the endings change? (No.) Next: retrieve the complete twelve-atom chapter.

27.8 Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought

This checkpoint adds no vocabulary and no plural persons. Retrieve the six regular singular rows, then the three learned irregular stems. Use the future for “will” and the conditional for the bounded core meaning “would.”

Grammar Lens: the regular frame

person	hablar	comer	vivir
yo future	hablaré	comeré	viviré
tú future	hablarás	comerás	vivirás
él / ella / usted future	hablará	comerá	vivirá
yo conditional	hablaría	comería	viviría
tú conditional	hablarías	comerías	vivirías
él / ella / usted conditional	hablaría	comería	viviría

All three regular infinitives remain whole. Future endings are **-é, -ás, -á**; conditional endings are **-ía, -ías, -ía**. Plural persons wait.

Grammar Lens: three learned stems

verb	learned stem	future yo	conditional yo
hacer	har-	haré	haría
tener	tendr-	tendré	tendría
poder	podr-	podré	podría

The stems change; the ending sets do not. Other irregular stems remain outside this chapter.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Romance future and conditional forms grew from constructions pairing an infinitive with forms of Latin **habēre**. Present material contributed to the future; past or imperfect material contributed to the conditional. Many paths and competing forms existed during the change, so this is a bridge for memory, not a one-step story or a recipe using modern **haber**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hablaré, comeré, viviré”
- “hablaría, comería, viviría”
- “haré/haría · tendré/tendría · podré/podría”

Before you move on

Give the three regular future yo forms. (*Hablaré, comeré, viviré.*)
Give the three regular conditional yo forms. (*Hablaría, comería, viviría.*) Which three learned stems replace a whole infinitive? (**Har-, tendr-, podr-.**) What is the careful historical bridge? (Infinitive plus forms of Latin **habēre**, reshaped through Romance.) Chapter 18 can now begin without borrowing plural persons, new auxiliaries, or clock-time vocabulary.

Chapter 28

The Subjunctive — the Mood of the Not-Yet-Real

Modes: 🗣️ voice (9) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 9 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can distinguish an asserted event from a wanted one and use the learned singular present-subjunctive forms after *quiero que* or *ojalá*.

Complete ES-C18-practice and choose asserted versus wanted meaning before retrieving the singular forms of hablar, comer, vivir, querer, poder, and hacer in the two learned trigger frames.

28.1 Hablas español · Quiero que hables español — fact or wanted event?

Hablas español can assert “You speak Spanish.” Now compare **Quiero que hables español** — “I want you to speak Spanish.” **Hables** does not report what is true. It presents the speaking as wanted and not yet asserted. That meaning contrast is the first small doorway into the **subjunctive**.

Grammar Lens: count the doers

meaning	Spanish	doers
I want to speak Spanish.	Quiero hablar español.	one: I want; I speak
I want you to speak Spanish.	Quiero que hables español.	two: I want; you speak
With one doer, keep the known infinitive hablar . With a different doer for the wanted event, use que and the new form hables . This is a bounded pattern for querer , not a rule for every clause in Spanish.		

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Hablas español.”
- “Quiero hablar español.”
- “Quiero que hables español.”

Before you move on

Which form asserts the event? (**Hablas.**) Which presents it as wanted? (**Hables**, after **quiero que**.) What happens when the wanter and the speaker are the same? (Use the infinitive: **Quiero hablar.**) Next, build the three singular **-ar** forms one piece at a time.

28.2 **hable · hables · hable — the singular -ar row**

You already used **hables** for one friend. Today add only the other two singular slots:

person	present subjunctive
yo	hable
tú	hables
él / ella / usted	hable

Plural forms wait. Say the small row: **hable · hables · hable**.

Grammar Lens: the yo stem, then a vowel swap

Start from present **hablo**. Remove **-o** to reveal **habl-**. Regular **-ar** verbs then use **e** in these subjunctive endings: **-e, -es, -e**. The family vowel has swapped from the familiar **a** to **e**. This recipe will matter later because a verb's special present **yo** stem can travel with it.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish **subjuntivo** descends from Latin **subiūnctīvus**, “subjoined,” from **sub-** “under” plus **iungere** “join.” English **join**, **junction**, and **conjunction** belong to the same word family; **yoke** is a more distant cousin. The name helps you picture the wanted clause joined under **quiero que**. It is history, not a complete usage rule.

Your turn

Build each answer only from the learned singular row.

Before you move on

Give the three forms. (**Hable, hables, hable.**) Which present form supplies the stem? (**Hablo.**) What did the family vowel do? (**a → e.**) What does the name remember? (A clause **subjoined**, or joined under another.)

28.3 coma · comas · coma — let -er cross to a

Start from **como**, remove **-o**, and keep **com-**. A regular **-er** verb crosses to the **a** family:

person	present subjunctive
yo	coma
tú	comas
él / ella / usted	coma

Say only the singular row: **coma · comas · coma.**

Grammar Lens: meaning before machinery

Comes can assert “you eat.” **Quiero que comas** presents your eating as what I want. The **e** → **a** contrast helps you hear the two meanings. It does not mean that every **a** form is subjunctive; use the learned frame as a whole.

Your turn

Keep **comer** inside the learned singular frame.

Before you move on

Give the three forms. (**Coma, comas, coma.**) Which form asserts “you eat”? (**Comes.**) Which belongs after **quiero que**? (**Comas.**) Next, test whether regular **-ir** behaves differently.

28.4 viva · vivas · viva — -ir joins -er

Start from **vivo**, remove **-o**, then add the same **a** endings you just used with **comer**:

person	present subjunctive
yo	viva
tú	vivas
él / ella / usted	viva

Regular **-er** and **-ir** match in this singular row:

- **comer: coma · comas · coma.**
- **vivir: viva · vivas · viva.**

Plural differences wait.

Grammar Lens: meaning in a known frame

Vives en Madrid asserts where one friend lives. **Quiero que vivas en Madrid** makes that living a wanted event. Nothing new is being smuggled into the sentence: **en** and **Madrid** have appeared in the earlier location frame.

Your turn

Keep **vivir** inside the learned singular frame.

Before you move on

Give the three forms. (**Viva, vivas, viva.**) Which regular family matches **-ir** here? (**-er.**) Which form fits one friend after **quiero que?** (**Vivas.**)

28.5 quiera · quieras · quiera — keep the change you know

Present **quiero** already carries the stressed **e** → **ie** change. Remove **-o** to get **quier-**, then add the **-er/-ir** subjunctive endings:

person	present subjunctive
yo	quiera
tú	quieras
él / ella / usted	quiera

Say only this bounded singular row: **quiera · quieras · quiera.**

Grammar Lens: one known verb, one inherited stem

You are not learning a new list of stem-changing verbs. You are carrying one known change into one known row. **Quiero que quieras hablar español** means “I want you to want to speak Spanish.” The sentence is deliberately narrow: no new person noun, object, or plural form.

Your turn

Carry only the known **quier-** stem into this row.

Before you move on

Give the three forms. (**Quiera, quieras, quiera.**) Which old change stays visible? (**e** → **ie.**) Where did the stem come from? (Known **quiero**, minus **-o.**)

28.6 pueda · puedas · pueda — one more known stem change

Present **puedo** already carries **o** → **ue**. Remove **-o** to get **pued-**, then add the same **a** row:

person	present subjunctive
yo	pueda
tú	puedas
él / ella / usted	pueda

Say **pueda · puedas · pueda**. No other **poder** forms enter today.

Grammar Lens: use it immediately

Quiero que puedas hablar español means “I want you to be able to speak Spanish.” Every word was already known except the single form **puedas**. This is the gentle pattern: learn one row, then spend it in the next sentence.

Your turn

Carry only the known **pued-** stem into this row.

Before you move on

Give the three forms. (**Pueda, puedas, pueda.**) Which old change stays visible? (**o** → **ue.**) Which form addresses one friend after **quiero que**? (**Puedas.**)

28.7 haga · hagas · haga — hago lends its stem

The known present **yo** form is **hago**. Remove **-o** and keep **hag-**:

person	present subjunctive
yo	haga
tú	hagas
él / ella / usted	haga

Say **haga · hagas · haga**. Only **hacer** enters this lesson; other special stems wait for later chapters.

Grammar Lens: spend the new form

Haces café can assert “you make coffee.” **Quiero que hagas café** says “I want you to make coffee.” The **g** is not a fresh exception: it was already in **hago**, the present form that supplied the stem.

Your turn

Carry only the known **hag-** stem into this row.

Before you move on

Give the three forms. (**Haga, hagas, haga.**) Where does **hag-** come from? (Known **hago**, minus **-o**.) Say the wanted event. (**Quiero que hagas café.**)

28.8 ojalá + subjunctive — a wish borrowed through Arabic

Ojalá hables español means “I hope you speak Spanish” or “May you speak Spanish.” **Ojalá** expresses the wish by itself. It needs neither a main verb nor **que** before the subjunctive. Keep the first frame tiny:

Ojalá + subjunctive

That is a usable modern pattern. It does not make the Arabic source phrase new Spanish vocabulary.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The Real Academia Española records **ojalá** from Hispanic Arabic **wa šā lláh**, “and God has willed.” Long contact in al-Andalus carried the expression into Spanish, where its sound and grammatical life changed. You met another Arabic-derived function word in **hasta**. The historical phrase explains a route; only modern **ojalá** is available for your Spanish sentences.

Your turn

Use only modern **ojalá** as the Spanish trigger.

Before you move on

What follows **ojalá** in the learned frame? (The **subjunctive**.) Does it need **que**? (**No.**) Which historical language variety carried the word into Spanish? (**Hispanic Arabic.**) Is the older Arabic phrase usable as new Spanish vocabulary here? (**No.**)

28.9 Practice — assert the event or want it

This checkpoint adds no vocabulary, plural person, object pronoun, or new clause frame. First decide whether the event is asserted or wanted. Then retrieve only the singular rows you learned.

Grammar Lens: the bounded map

verb	yo / él / ella / usted	tú
hablar	hable	hables
comer	coma	comas
vivir	viva	vivas
querer	quiera	quieras
poder	pueda	puedas
hacer	haga	hagas

The repeated outer form is not a missing row: first- and third-person singular match. Every plural form waits.

Grammar Lens: two safe triggers

- Same doer: **Quiero hablar español.**
- Different doer: **Quiero que hables español.**
- Wish by itself: **Ojalá hables español.**

Do not extend these two frames to every emotion, doubt, command, or conjunction yet. More triggers belong in later micro-lessons.

Your turn

Decide the meaning first; then retrieve only the learned form.

Before you move on

What is the first meaning choice? (**Asserted event or wanted event.**) Give the three regular tú forms. (**Hables, comas, vivas.**) Give the three bounded special tú forms. (**Quieras, puedas, hagas.**) Name the two safe triggers. (**Quiero que** for a different doer; **ojalá** for a wish.) What still waits? (Plural persons, additional irregular verbs, and additional subjunctive triggers.)

Chapter 29

Lo Siento

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can apologise in Spanish and choose between *lo siento* and *perdón*.

Say lo siento for regret and perdón for fault or for catching someone's attention, hearing sentir — I feel it — inside the first and dōnāre — to give completely — inside the second.

29.1 lo siento — “I’m sorry,” i.e. “I feel it”

You already know **por favor**, “please.” The next courtesy phrase is **lo siento**. Spanish does not say “I *am* sorry” as an adjective; it says something closer to “**I feel this.**”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **lo** = “it” — a **neuter** pronoun. It does not point at any noun; it points at the **situation itself**. Spanish keeps this one leftover neuter slot precisely for “the whole business, unnamed.”
- **siento** = “I feel,” from **sentir**, “to feel,” from Latin **sentīre**. That root gave English a whole family: **sentiment**, **sense**, **consent** (“feel together”), **resent** (“feel back at”), and **sentence** (originally an *opinion*, something felt).

So **lo siento** is literally “*I feel it.*” You are naming a feeling — regret, sympathy — rather than declaring a state about yourself. That is why it stretches so easily: *lo siento mucho*, “I feel it a lot,” works both for

stepping on someone's foot and for hearing that their father died.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “siento” — I feel — then “lo siento,” I feel it / I’m sorry
- “lo siento mucho” — I’m so sorry
- “siento” then English “sentiment, sense, consent”

Before you move on

What does **lo siento** literally mean? (“**I feel it**” — *siento*, “I feel,” from Latin *sentire*.) What is the *lo* pointing at? (The **situation**, not a noun — it is the neuter “it.”) Next: Spanish’s *other* word for sorry, and when it is the right one.

29.2 perdón — the sorry that asks for something back

Lo siento names a feeling. Spanish keeps a **second** word for a different job — one that is not about your feelings at all, but about something you want from the other person.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

perdón (“pardon”), from the verb **perdonar** — Latin **per-** (“thoroughly”) + **dōnāre** (“to give”). Literally: “**to give completely**.” That *dōnāre* is English’s **donate**, **donor**, and **condone**; the *per-* is the same intensifier in **perfect** (“thoroughly made”) and **perturb**. So forgiveness, in Latin’s picture of it, is a **gift given all the way** — you hand over the debt rather than keeping a share of it.

Why it’s said this way

The two are not interchangeable, and the difference follows straight from the etymologies:

	lo siento	perdón
literally	“I feel it”	“give [it] completely”
points at	your feeling	their forgiveness
use for	regret, sympathy	fault, or getting past someone

So **perdón** is what you say to squeeze through a crowd or catch a waiter’s eye (English “excuse me”), and to ask forgiveness for something **you did** — often stronger than *lo siento*. **Lo siento** leans toward “I’m sorry that happened,” including things that are nobody’s fault at all. Be honest about the edges: native speakers use whichever fits, the boundary is soft, and mixing them is not a real mistake — just a shade off.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “perdón” — pardon / excuse me
- the pair — “lo siento” for regret, “perdón” for fault
- “perdón” then English “donate, condone” — the *dōnāre* root

Before you move on

What do the two halves of **perdonar** mean? (**Per-**, “thoroughly,” plus **dōnāre**, “to give” — to give completely.) Which word do you use to get past someone in a corridor? (**Perdón.**) Which leans toward sympathy rather than fault? (**Lo siento** — “I feel it.”)

Chapter 30

Days of the Week

Modes: 👁 eyes (2) ⇌ Hands-free start: none of the 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name all seven days of the week in Spanish and say why the last two broke away from the planet names.

Run lunes to domingo straight through, then pair each weekend day against its English twin — sábado against Saturn’s day, domingo against the Sun’s.

30.1 lunes to viernes — the planets of the week, worn down

The Romans mapped the seven-day week onto the seven visible “wandering stars” — the planet-gods. Spanish kept that map, but handled the word “day” differently from its Romance cousins: where French still spells out “-di” (day) on every weekday, Spanish mostly just **dropped it**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Each weekday began life as “[planet-god]’s diēs (day).” In Vulgar Latin, *diēs* was simply **dropped as a separate word** in most of these — what survived is just the planet’s own Latin genitive form. That’s why **martes**, **jueves**, **viernes** already end in -s: not because *diēs* wore down into one, but because **Martis**, **Iovis**, **Veneris** — the planets’ own genitive forms — end in -s in Latin already. **Lunes** has no such -s to inherit (*lūnae* doesn’t end in one), so it likely picked up the ending by **analogy** with its four siblings:

Spanish	← Latin	planet-god	English echo
lunes	<i>lūnae diēs</i>	the Moon (<i>luna</i>)	<i>Monday</i> = Moon-day
martes	<i>Martis diēs</i>	Mars	<i>Tuesday</i> (Tiw, the Germanic war-god = Mars)
miércoles	<i>Mercuriī diēs</i>	Mercury	<i>Wednesday</i> (Woden = Mercury)
jueves	<i>Jovis diēs</i>	Jupiter (<i>Jove</i>)	<i>Thursday</i> (Thor = Jupiter)
viernes	<i>Veneris diēs</i>	Venus	<i>Friday</i> (Frigg/Freya = Venus)

Compare **French**, which keeps *diēs* as its own visible syllable on every day — **lundi**, **mardi**, **jeudi** — while Spanish dropped it from four of its five weekdays. **miércoles** is the odd one out: some historians of the language think its extra “-coles” is a genuine surviving trace of *diēs* itself (fused in and reshaped) — though the exact sound changes are debated, unlike the plainer, better-understood story for its four siblings.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “lunes, martes, miércoles, jueves, viernes” — the work week
- each as “[planet]’s day, worn down” — “lunes = Moon, jueves = Jupiter”
- the bridge — “martes / Tuesday, both the war-god’s day (Mars / Tiw)”

Before you move on

Recall the weekday family:

- What did every Spanish weekday begin life as?

(“**[Planet-god]’s diēs (day)**” — the same Latin phrase French keeps more visibly with *-di*.)

- Why do **martes, jueves, viernes** end in *-s*, and where does **lunes** get its *-s* from? (**From the planet’s own Latin genitive** — Martis/Iovis/ Veneris already end in *-s*; *lunes* likely picked it up **by analogy**, since *lūnae* has no *-s* of its own.)
- What’s debated about **miércoles**? (**Whether its “-coles” is a genuine surviving trace of diēs** — unlike the plainer, better-understood story for its four siblings.)
- Why do *martes* and *Tuesday* line up? (They name the same day for the war-god: *Mars* in Latin, *Tiw* in Germanic.)

30.2 sábado and domingo — the week’s religious edge

Five days named for planets — then two that broke the pattern entirely. The weekend is where **religion overwrote astronomy**, and Spanish keeps both rewrites in plain view.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish	← Latin	meaning	note
sábado	<i>sabbatum</i>	“ Sabbath ”	the planet-god (Saturn) is gone — replaced by the Hebrew <i>shabbāt</i> , “to rest”
domingo	<i>diēs Dominica</i>	“the Lord’s day”	<i>Dominica</i> ← <i>Dominus</i> , “lord/master” — Spanish kept this one much less worn-down than French’s <i>dimanche</i>

Two different rewrites:

- **sábado** would have been “Saturn’s day” (as English **Saturday** still is — the one weekday English kept a Roman god for). Instead, Latin Christians borrowed the Jewish **Sabbath** (*Sabbatum* ← Hebrew *shabbāt*), and it became *sábado*. So English **Saturday** and Spanish **sábado** are the **same day, two different names** — the planet vs. the Sabbath.
- **domingo** drops Sun-worship entirely: where English keeps **Sunday**, Spanish made it *diēs Dominica*, “the Lord’s day” (*Dominus* → English **dominion, dominate, dame**). Spanish kept **domingo** recognizably close to *Dominica* — compare French’s more worn-down **dimanche**, where the *di-* (day) fossil jumped to the front of the word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the full week — “lunes, martes, miércoles, jueves, viernes, sábado, domingo”

- “sábado = Sabbath, domingo = the Lord’s day” — religion, not planets
- the pair-ups — “sábado / Saturday (Sabbath vs. Saturn)”, “domingo / Sunday (Lord vs. Sun)”

Before you move on

Give all seven Spanish days. (*Lunes ... domingo*.) Where does **sábado** come from, and its English contrast? (The **Sabbath**, *Sabbatum*; English kept *Saturday* = Saturn’s day.) What does **domingo** mean literally? (“The **Lord’s** day,” *diēs Dominica*.)

Chapter 31

Black, White, Red, and Blue

Modes: ⇄ voice (4) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name black, white, red and blue in Spanish and say which of them Spanish borrowed rather than inherited.

Say negro, blanco, rojo and azul, then sort them by origin: negro inherited from Latin, blanco traditionally linked to the Germanic Visigoths, rojo a cousin of English red by a different Latin branch, and azul carried in from Arabic lāzaward.

31.1 negro, blanco — two colours, and one of their histories

Two colours you can put to work immediately. One of them has the most ordinary history imaginable. The other does not — which is why it gets its own lesson next.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

negro (“black”) ← Latin **niger**. Nothing surprising: the same Latin root gives English **denigrate** (“to blacken someone’s name”) and the rest of the Romance family’s words for black — French *noir*, Italian *nero*, Portuguese *negro*. Latin’s word for black stayed put, in every daughter language.

Hold that in mind as the baseline. It is what a colour word normally does.

The two words in use

blanco (“white”) is the pair to it: *el gato negro, el gato blanco*. Both behave like any Spanish adjective — they follow the noun and agree with it (*la casa blanca*).

But hear what you would have expected and did not get. Latin’s word for white was **albus**, and by the *negro* pattern Spanish “white” should be something like *albo*. It is not. Where **blanco** actually came from — and what became of *albus* — is the next lesson.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “negro, blanco”
- with a noun — “el gato negro, la casa blanca”
- “negro” then English “denigrate” — the *niger* root

Before you move on

Say black and white. (*Negro, blanco*.) Where does *negro* come from, and what English word shares it? (Latin **niger** — *denigrate*.) What would you have expected Spanish’s “white” to be, given Latin *albus*? (Something like *albo* — and it isn’t. That is next lesson’s puzzle.)

31.2 blanco — the colour Spanish did not inherit

Negro came straight down from Latin, like almost every other everyday word you have met. **Blanco** did not come down at all. It walked in.

What to know first

- negro, blanco — the two colour words.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

blanco comes from **Germanic *blank** — “shining, gleaming.” It is a **loan**, traditionally attributed to contact with the **Visigoths**, the Germanic people who ruled Spain for centuries after Rome collapsed.

Be careful how firmly you hold that last part: no surviving Gothic text actually preserves this word, so the Visigothic route is a **plausible traditional account**, not a documented one. What *is* well attested is the parallel case next door — **French** took the very same Germanic word (*blanc*) from a **different** Germanic people, the **Franks**. Two Romance sisters, the same borrowed word for white, two separate borrowings. Why would a borrowed word beat Latin’s own? Because **blank* was not a pale word: it meant **bright, gleaming**. Colour terms lose out to vivid ones all the time — English’s own *bright* is doing the same job in “bright white.”

Why it’s said this way

Latin’s white did not vanish. It stopped being the **everyday** word and survived in corners:

word	meaning	the white inside
alba	dawn	the sky going <i>white</i>
<i>albo</i> (rare, poetic)	white, pale	a fossil, mostly literary now
<i>album</i> (Eng. <i>album</i>)	album	a <i>blank white</i> tablet
<i>albino</i>	albino	white-skinned

That is the normal fate of a displaced word: not death, but retreat into technical and poetic corners. *El alba* is still every Spanish speaker’s word for dawn.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the pairing — “negro from Latin, blanco from Germanic”
- “el alba” — dawn — and hear the old Latin white inside it
- “blanco” then French “blanc” — the same loan, twice over

Before you move on

Where does **blanco** come from, and what did it mean? (**Germanic *blank**, “shining” — traditionally linked to the Visigoths, though not directly attested.) Which other language borrowed the same word,

from whom? (**French** *blanc*, from the **Franks**.) Where did Latin's *albus* end up? (In **alba** “dawn,” *album*, *albino* — no longer the everyday colour word.)

31.3 rojo — the same family as *red*, by a different branch

So far the sorting has been simple: *negro* inherited, *blanco* borrowed. **Rojo** needs a third box — inherited, yes, but not from the word you would guess.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

rojo (“red”) ← Latin **russus**, an everyday, expressive Latin word for red. That is a **different specific Latin word** from the one behind French *rouge* (← **rubeus**). Latin had several reds and the daughter languages did not all pick the same one.

Both *russus* and *rubeus*, though, descend from the very same ancient root: PIE ***h₁rewd^h*** — which is also the root of English **red**, **rust**, **ruddy**, and of Latin *ruber* itself (English **rubric**, once written in red ink).

So *rojo*, *rouge* and *red* are **cousins**, not copies: three descendants of one very old family, arriving by three different branches. Nobody borrowed this one from anybody.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “rojo”
- the cousins — “rojo · rouge · red”, three branches, one root
- the three so far — “negro inherited, blanco borrowed, rojo cousin”

Before you move on

Is **rojo** from the same Latin word as French *rouge*? (**No** — *rojo* ← *russus*, *rouge* ← *rubeus*.) Are they related at all? (**Yes** — cousins, via

the shared PIE root *h₁rewd^h*-, which also gives English **red**.) Next: the one colour in this chapter that came from outside Europe entirely.

31.4 azul — a stone from Afghanistan, in your everyday vocabulary

Three colours in, three different histories: inherited, borrowed from a neighbour, inherited by a different branch. The fourth comes from outside the Indo-European family altogether.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

azul (“blue”) ← Arabic لازورد (*lāzaward*), “**lapis lazuli**” — the deep blue stone, mined for centuries in what is now Afghanistan and ground into the most expensive pigment in the medieval world. Spanish picked the word up during the centuries of Arabic-speaking rule in Iberia (**al-Andalus**). English has the same source at one more remove, in **azure**, and the stone keeps its own name: **lazuli**.

So Spanish’s word for blue is, underneath, the name of a **rock** — which is common for blue. Blue is the last basic colour term most languages acquire, and when they do, they usually name it after the thing that was reliably that colour.

Why it’s said this way

Here is the contrast worth keeping. **French** has *azur* too — but only as a **secondary, poetic** word (the sky’s blue, the *Côte d’Azur*); its everyday blue is the Germanic loan *bleu*. In **Spanish** it is the reverse: **azul is the plain, unremarkable, everyday word**, with no Germanic rival competing for the job at all.

Same borrowed word, two languages, opposite outcomes — a reminder that where a word came from tells you nothing about how ordinary it now feels.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all four — “negro, blanco, rojo, azul”

- sort them — “negro inherited, blanco Germanic, rojo cousin of red, azul Arabic”
- “azul” then English “azure” — the same lapis lazuli

Before you move on

Name the four colours and sort them by origin. (*Negro* — Latin *niger*; *blanco* — Germanic **blank*; *rojo* — Latin *russus*, cousin of red; *azul* — Arabic *lāzaward*.) What did *lāzaward* actually name? (**Lapis lazuli**, the stone.) How does *azul*’s role differ from French *azur*’s? (**Azul is Spanish’s everyday blue**; French’s *azur* is only poetic, with *bleu* doing the daily work.)

Chapter 32

Parents and Siblings

Modes:  voice (3)  Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name my parents and my siblings in Spanish and explain why *hermano* is not built on Latin’s word for brother.

Give el padre, la madre, el hermano and la hermana, trace hermano back through germānus to germen, the seed, rather than to frāter, and separate its silent h from the once-spoken h of hijo and hacer.

32.1 el padre, la madre — among the oldest words there are

“Father” and “mother” are some of the **oldest reconstructible words in human language** — older than Latin, older than Rome. Spanish kept them close to the Latin original, and they are secretly the *same words* as English **father** and **mother**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **el padre** (“father”) ← Latin **pater** ← PIE *ph₂tēr*.
- **la madre** (“mother”) ← Latin **māter** ← PIE *méh₂tēr*.

Why it’s said this way

Padre and English *father* both descend independently from the **same** PIE word — they’re siblings, not parent and child. Latin (and Spanish

after it) kept the original *p* and *t* largely intact; the Germanic branch that gave English took a separate road through **Grimm’s Law**, which shifted the **inherited** **p** → **f** and **t** → **th**:

PIE ancestor	Latin → Spanish	Germanic → English
<i>ph₂tēr</i>	<i>pater</i> → padre	father
<i>méh₂tēr</i>	<i>māter</i> → madre	mother

So *padre* and *father* aren’t lookalikes borrowed late, and neither one comes *from* the other — they’re the **same inherited PIE word**, one branch keeping the *p*, the other shifting it to *f*. The Latin root also gives Spanish and English their “of a parent” adjectives: **paternal**, **paternidad**, **patrón** and **maternal**, **maternidad**. (A further Latin-only offshoot, *māter* → *māteria*, “the stuff a tree-mother produces,” gives Spanish *materia* and, separately, *matriz* — “womb” — via Latin *mātrix*.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el padre, la madre”
- the sound-law — “padre keeps p; father shifts to f — same word”
- “padre → paternal; madre → maternal”

Before you move on

Give “father” and “mother” with their articles. (**el padre, la madre**.) Does *padre* turn into English *father* directly? (**No** — both descend independently from the same PIE word; the Germanic branch shifted **p** → **f** and **t** → **th** via **Grimm’s Law**, while Latin/Spanish kept the original sounds.) Name an English cousin of each. (*padre* → paternal; *madre* → maternal.)

32.2 el hermano, la hermana — brother and sister, from a different word entirely

You might expect Spanish “brother” to come from Latin **frāter**, the way French’s *frère* does. It does not. Spanish’s siblings took a completely different word — one about **seeds**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Classical Latin could say **frāter germānus**, literally “a brother **of the same stock/blood**” — distinguishing a *full* brother from a half-brother, or from a “brother” in some looser sense.

Then something ordinary and strange happened: in everyday Latin the **adjective** took over the whole job and the **noun quietly dropped out**. (English does this all the time — a *mobile phone* becomes a *mobile*, a *cellular telephone* becomes a *cell*.) What survived is the modifier:

- **el hermano** (“brother”) ← Latin **germānus**.
- **la hermana** (“sister”) ← Latin **germāna**.

So Spanish’s everyday word for brother is, grammatically, a leftover adjective.

Why it’s said this way

Germānus traces back to **germen**, “sprout, bud, seed” — the same root that gives English **germ**, **germinate**, and **germane** (originally “closely related,” from the same seed, before it loosened into just “relevant”).

So calling someone your *hermano* is, at the etymological root, calling them “**sprung from the same seed**.” (And no, this has nothing to do with *Germany* — that name is a separate, unrelated puzzle.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el hermano, la hermana” — brother, sister
- the root chain — “germen, seed” → “germānus, of the same seed” → “hermano”

- “hermano” then English “germinate, germane”

Before you move on

Does Spanish *hermano* come from Latin *frāter*? (**No** — from **germānus**, “of the same stock/seed,” an adjective that swallowed the noun *frāter* it used to modify.) What does its root *germen* mean, and what English words share it? (**Seed, sprout** — *germ, germinate, germane*.) Next: the silent *h* on the front, which is not the *h* you think it is.

32.3 the *h* in hermano — a letter that was never spoken

Germānus starts with a **g**. *Hermano* starts with an **h**. Something has to explain that — and the obvious explanation is the wrong one.

What to know first

- el hermano, la hermana — the words and the *germen* root.

Why it’s said this way

You may already know that Spanish often turns a Latin initial **f** into a silent **h** — *filius* → **hijo** (“son”), *facere* → **hacer** (“to do”). **Hermano is not that**, and the difference is worth getting right.

Germānus is stressed on its **third** syllable (*ger-MĀ-nus*), which leaves the opening *ger-* **unstressed**. Latin’s **g** before a front vowel had already softened toward a *y*-like sound in everyday speech — and in that unstressed position it simply **fell away entirely**, giving Old Spanish *ermano*, with **no *h* at all**. That is the form actually recorded centuries ago.

The **h** you see today was added **later, in spelling only**, to mark the word’s old link to Latin *g-*. Compare:

word	what happened to the sound	was the <i>h</i> ever spoken?
hijo, hacer	Latin <i>f-</i> → a real breathy <i>h</i>	yes , for centuries
hermano	Latin <i>g-</i> simply dropped	no , never
Same silent letter today; two completely different backstories, only one of which involves a sound at all.		

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*germānus*” then “*ermano*” then “*hermano*” — the three stages
- the honest distinction — *hijo/hacer*’s *h* was once truly spoken; *hermano*’s *h* never was

Before you move on

Is *hermano*’s *h* the same kind of change as *hijo*’s or *hacer*’s? (**No.**) What actually happened to *germānus*’s opening? (Its **g** dropped away in an **unstressed** syllable, giving Old Spanish *ermano*.) So where did the *h* come from? (**Spelling** — added later to mark the Latin link, never pronounced.)

Chapter 33

Head and Hand

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the head and the hand in Spanish and get la mano’s gender right despite its -o ending.

Say la cabeza and la mano, use me duele la mano, and explain the feminine article on a word that ends in -o by way of Latin’s fourth declension.

33.1 la cabeza — “the head”

Spanish’s word for “head” is the boring, expected one — and that’s exactly what makes it interesting, once you see what French did instead.

You’ll want to know: la cabeza

la cabeza — the head. Feminine, so **la**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Latin’s word for “head” was **caput**. Spanish’s *cabeza* comes straight from it (by way of Vulgar Latin *capitia*), and *caput* shows up all over English too:

English	literally
captain	the “head” of a ship/unit
capital	the “head” city, or “head” sum of money
decapitate	to remove the head
capitulate	to arrange under “headings” — hence, to yield

Why it’s said this way

French had the exact same Latin word available — and **dropped it**. French *tête* (“head”) comes instead from **testa**, Latin for an **earth-ware pot**: Roman soldiers joked about the skull the way English speakers say “noggin” (a small mug), and in Gaul that joke eventually **replaced** the real word entirely. Spanish never made that swap — *cabeza* is *caput*, plain and simple, still standing after two thousand years.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “la cabeza” — the head
- “me duele la cabeza” — “my head hurts”
- the English family — “captain, capital, decapitate”
- the contrast — Spanish kept *caput*; French swapped it for a pot joke

Before you move on

Say “the head.” (*La cabeza* — feminine.) What Latin word is it from? (**Caput**.) Give an English word from the same root. (**Captain, capital, decapitate...**) What did French do instead? (**Replaced caput with *testa*, “pot”** — soldiers’ slang for the skull that took over completely.)

33.2 la mano — “the hand”

You’ve been trusting “-o words are masculine, -a words are feminine” since Chapter 1. Here’s the word that breaks it — and everyone learning Spanish has to memorize this one by name.

Grammar Lens: la mano and its gender

la mano — the hand. **Feminine**, despite ending in **-o**.

Almost every Spanish noun ending in *-o* is masculine (*el libro, el gato...*). *Mano* is the single most common exception, and it’s actually **doubly** irregular. Latin **manus** (“hand”) belonged to the **4th declension** — a group of *-us* nouns that were mostly **masculine** (*fructus* “fruit,” *exercitus* “army,” *senātus* “senate”). *Manus* was one of a small handful of exceptions that were **feminine** instead (alongside *domus* “house” and *anus* “old woman”). So *mano* broke the rule **twice over**: an exception within Latin’s own mostly-masculine 4th declension, and then an exception again against Spanish’s usual *-o* = masculine pattern.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Mano comes from Latin **manus**, “hand” — and that root is buried inside an enormous number of English words:

English	literally
manual	done by hand
manufacture	made by hand (<i>manus</i> + <i>facere</i> , “to make”)
manuscript	written by hand (<i>manus</i> + <i>scribere</i>)
maintain	hold in the hand (<i>manū tenere</i>)
manage	to handle

Manufacture is worth pausing on: it literally means “made by hand” — and today it names precisely the opposite.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “la mano” — feminine, despite the -o

- “me duele la mano” — “my hand hurts”
- the family — “manual, manufacture, maintain — all a hand”
- the irony — “manufacture = made by hand”

Before you move on

Say “the hand,” and name its gender. (*La mano* — **feminine**, despite ending in *-o*.) Why is *mano* feminine when most *-o* words aren’t? (**It’s doubly irregular** — Latin’s 4th declension, where *manus* belongs, was mostly **masculine**; *manus* was one of a few feminine exceptions there, and then an exception again against Spanish’s usual *-o*=masculine rule.) Give an English word built on *manus*. (**Manual, manufacture, manuscript, maintain, manage.**)

Chapter 34

The Seasons

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the four seasons in Spanish and explain how verano moved from spring to summer.

Run primavera, verano, otoño, invierno, unpack primavera as prīma vēra, and show verano growing out of that same vēr before its meaning slid across to summer.

34.1 la primavera, el verano, el otoño, el invierno — three plain, one surprising

Three of Spanish’s four seasons are exactly what you’d expect from Latin. The fourth hides a genuine surprise: its **meaning itself** drifted from one season to another.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **la primavera** (“spring”) ← Latin *prīma vēra*, literally “**first spring**” (*vēr*, “spring,” + *prīma*, “first”). Italian still says the identical phrase, *primavera*, unchanged. (Old French once said *primevère* too, before switching to *printemps*.)
- **el otoño** (“autumn”) ← Latin *autumnus* — the same root behind French *automne* and English *autumn* itself.
- **el invierno** (“winter”) ← Latin *hībernūm* (*tempus*), “the **wintry** [season]” — the same root as French *hiver* and English *hibernate*, “to spend the winter.”

Why it's said this way

You might expect *verano* (“summer”) to come from Latin *aestas*, “heat” — the way French *été* does. It doesn’t. The standard account (per Spanish etymological dictionaries) traces **verano** to Latin *vērānum* (*tempus*), “**of spring**” — built on the very same *vēr*, “spring,” behind *primavera*.

So how did a word meaning “spring-ish” end up naming **summer**? The honest answer is a **shift in meaning over time**, not a sound change — though the exact story is murkier than a tidy one-line explanation. The traditional, simplified account says that as *primavera* (“first spring”) rose to become the standard word for spring, *verano*’s meaning drifted forward into the season right after, summer; the fuller picture likely also involves Vulgar Latin agricultural usage (a “vernal” grazing or working period that stretched from late spring into early summer), so the drift may not be purely a case of one word simply vacating a job for the other. Either way, two Spanish words both rooted in *vēr*, “spring,” ended up naming two different seasons.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “primavera, verano, otoño, invierno” — the four seasons
- “primavera = prima vera, first spring”
- the surprise — “verano **ALSO** comes from *vēr*, ‘spring’ — but its meaning moved to summer”
- “invierno ~ hibernate”

Before you move on

What does **primavera** literally mean? (“**First spring**” — *prīma vēra*.) Does **verano** come from Latin *aestas*, like French *été*? (**No** — from *vērānum*, “of spring,” the same *vēr* root as *primavera*; its meaning **shifted** toward summer over time — traditionally linked to *primavera* taking over the job of naming spring, though the fuller history is murkier than that alone.) What English word is **invierno** the cousin of? (**Hibernate**.)

Chapter 35

Water, Wine, and Bread

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name water, wine and bread in Spanish and say why a *compañero* is someone who shares bread with me.

Say el agua, el vino and el pan, then open compañero into com- plus pānis and follow the root out to panadería and panadero.

35.1 el agua — water, and an article that is not what it looks like

One of the least changed words in Spanish, carrying one of its most misunderstood rules. The “masculine” article on this feminine noun is not a mistake and not an exception to gender.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

agua (“water”) ← Latin **aqua** — almost unchanged in two thousand years. Compare French, where the *very same word* was worn all the way down to a bare “**eau**,” just the sound “oh.” Same starting point, same span of time, wildly different amounts of erosion: how fast a language wears its words down is not fixed.

English kept the whole Latin word too, but as a **learned borrowing** rather than an inherited everyday one: **aquatic, aquarium, aqueduct, aqualung**.

Grammar Lens: el agua's article and gender

Notice: **el agua**, not *la agua* — yet *agua* is genuinely **feminine**. You can prove it: *el agua fría*, “the cold water,” keeps the feminine adjective ending, and the plural is *las aguas*, never *los aguas*.

The rule is **phonological**, not grammatical. Spanish swaps *la* for *el* directly before a **singular** feminine noun beginning with a **stressed a-sound**, to avoid running two identical vowels together (*la agua*). It is the same instinct that makes English pick “an apple” over “a apple.”

	singular	plural
the water	el agua	las aguas
the eagle	el águila	las águilas
the axe	el hacha	las hachas

Only the article changes. The noun's gender never moves.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el agua” — water, feminine, but takes *el*
- the proof — “el agua fría” and “las aguas”
- the contrast — “agua” barely changed; French's “eau” wore all the way down

Before you move on

Is **agua** masculine or feminine? (**Feminine** — *el* replaces *la* only because *agua* begins with a **stressed a**.) How would you prove it? (*El agua fría*; *las aguas*.) How does Spanish's erosion of *agua* compare with French's? (**Much less** — Spanish kept nearly the whole word; French wore it to “eau.”)

35.2 el vino — one word, three separate arrivals in English

The second drink is grammatically boring — plain masculine, plain *el vino*, no stressed-*a* trick. Its history makes up for that.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

vino (“wine”) ← Latin **vīnum** — which held its shape well, as French’s *vin* did too.

English shares the very same root by **more than one road**, and the roads are worth separating, because they show three different ways a word can travel:

English word	how it got there
wine	<i>vīnum</i> borrowed directly into old Germanic, very early
vine, vinegar	borrowed centuries later, secondhand via French (<i>vin</i> + <i>aigre</i> , “sour wine”)
vineyard	not borrowed at all — English built it at home from the already-borrowed <i>wine</i> plus native <i>yard</i>

So *wine* and *vine* are the same Latin word twice, arriving a thousand years apart by different routes, and *vineyard* is a homemade compound made out of the first arrival. One Latin noun; three English histories.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el agua, el vino” — the two drinks
- “vino” then English “wine, vine, vinegar” — one root, three roads

Before you move on

What Latin word gives *vino*? (**Vīnum**.) Name three English cousins and say how each arrived. (**Wine** — direct, early, into Germanic; **vine/vinegar** — later, via French; **vineyard** — built at home from *wine* plus *yard*.) And why is it *el agua* but *las aguas*? (The *el* is a sound rule for a stressed *a*, singular only.)

35.3 el pan — bread, and the friend who shares it

Spanish’s word for bread hides the same lovely word-story you’d find in English’s “companion” — except Spanish kept **both halves**, the bread and the friendship.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el pan (“bread”) ← Latin **pānis**. Masculine: *el pan*.

Why it’s said this way

The Latin root **pān-** (“bread”) gives Spanish its own word for a close friend:

- **compañero / compañera** (“companion, friend, partner”) ← *com-* (“with”) + *pānis* — literally “**one you share bread with**.” Spanish built this word from the very same recipe as English **companion** and **company** (which come from the identical Latin pieces) — but where English only kept the *friendship* sense, Spanish still visibly uses the **same root** for the actual **bread** (*pan*) too.
- **panadería** (“bakery”) and **panadero** (“baker”) — both transparently built on *pan*.

So *pan* and *compañero* are the same word-family doing double duty in Spanish: name the food, and name the friend you’d share it with.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el pan” — bread
- “compañero” — literally, one you share bread with
- “panadería, panadero” — bakery, baker

Before you move on

Give “bread” with its article. (**El pan.**) What does *compañero* literally mean, and what’s it built from? (“**One you share bread with**” — *com-* + *pānis*.) Does English keep this same double meaning? (**No** — English’s *companion* only kept the friendship sense; Spanish still uses the same root for the actual bread, *pan*, too.)

Chapter 36

The Months

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the twelve months in Spanish and explain why diciembre carries the Latin word for ten.

Recite enero through diciembre, tie marzo back to martes through Mars, and place septiembre and diciembre against the Roman year that started in March.

36.1 los meses — the calendar’s gods and Caesars

Spanish’s twelve months are a **procession of Roman gods and emperors**, barely changed from Latin. Two things you already know pay off immediately: *marzo* is the war-god you met in *martes*, and *septiembre–diciembre* are the Latin numbers 7–10 from the counting chapters.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish	← Latin	who / what
enero	<i>Iānuārius</i>	Janus , the two-faced god of doors & beginnings
febrero	<i>Februārius</i>	<i>Februa</i> , the Roman purification festival
marzo	<i>Martius</i>	Mars , the war-god — <i>the same Mars as martes</i> (Tuesday)! perhaps <i>aperire</i> , “to open” (buds opening)
abril	<i>Aprīlis</i>	Maia , goddess of growth
mayo	<i>Māius</i>	Juno , queen of the gods
junio	<i>Iūnius</i>	originally <i>Quīntilis</i> , “the 5th [month]” — renamed for Julius Caesar after his death
julio	<i>Iūlius</i>	originally <i>Sextilis</i> , “the 6th [month]” — renamed for the emperor Augustus
agosto	<i>Augustus</i>	“ 7th ” (<i>septem</i>)
septiembre	<i>september</i>	“ 8th ” (<i>octō</i>)
octubre	<i>octōber</i>	“ 9th ” (<i>novem</i>)
noviembre	<i>november</i>	“ 10th ” (<i>decem</i>)
diciembre	<i>december</i>	

Two payoffs land at once:

- **marzo = Mars = martes.** The month and the weekday honor the *same* war-god — *Martius* (his month) and *Martis diēs* (his day). Spot one, you know the other.
- **The 7–10 months.** *Septiembre* through *diciembre* still carry *septem*, *octō*, *novem*, *decem* — because the old Roman year

originally began in **March**, with September genuinely the 7th month. Centuries before Caesar, two new months (Januarius, Februarius) were added at the front to cover the winter, which pushed every later month's number out of step with its name — September became the 9th month while still being *named* “7th.” **Julius** and **Augustus** had nothing to do with that shift: they simply got two already-existing months — *Quintilis* and *Sextilis*, literally “5th” and “6th” — **renamed** in their honor after the fact. The names stuck; the months themselves were never new.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the twelve — “enero, febrero, marzo, abril, mayo, junio, julio, agosto, septiembre, octubre, noviembre, diciembre”
- the tie-back — “marzo / martes — both Mars, the war-god”
- “septiembre = 7, diciembre = 10” — the old March-start year

Before you move on

Which god links *marzo* and *martes*? (**Mars**, the war-god — his month and his day.) Why is *diciembre* Latin for “ten”? (**The Roman year began in March**, and adding January/February at the front later pushed every month's number out of step with its name.) Did Julius Caesar and Augustus **add** new months to the calendar? (**No** — *julio* and *agosto* were already-existing months, *Quintilis* and *Sextilis* (“5th”/“6th”), simply **renamed** in their honor.)

Chapter 37

Noon and Midnight

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say that it is noon or midnight in Spanish and break both words into their two living halves.

Say es mediodía and es medianoche, split each into medio/media plus día/noche, and set them against French’s worn-down midi and minuit.

37.1 mediodía, medianoche — noon and midnight, spelled out in full

Two hours that don’t get a number — they get a name. And Spanish keeps that name far more transparent than its French cousin does.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish	← Latin	literally
mediodía	<i>medius diēs</i>	“ mid-day ” (<i>medio</i> “middle” + <i>día</i> “day”)
medianoche	<i>media nox</i>	“ mid-night ” (<i>media</i> “middle” + <i>noche</i> “night”)

Both halves are **fully alive, ordinary Spanish words on their own**: **medio/media** (“middle” — cousin of English *medium*, *mid*, *middle*) and **día/noche** (“day/night,” words you already know). Compare

French, which took the same Latin phrase down a bumpier road: *mi-nuit*'s second half, **-nuit**, is still the plain, everyday French word for “night” — just as recognizable as Spanish's *noche*. But *midi*'s second half, **-di**, wore down into an opaque fragment: the ordinary French word for “day” is *jour*, not *di* — that piece survives only as a fossil, tucked inside weekday names like *lundi* and *mardi*. So the erosion split unevenly: French kept “night” transparent and lost “day,” while Spanish kept both.

They don't need *horas* the way a normal Spanish time (*son las tres*) never does either — they simply stand in for the hour on their own:

Es mediodía. — “It is noon.” **Es medianoche.** — “It is midnight.”

(Fun aside: English **noon** comes from Latin *nōna hōra*, “the **ninth** hour” — originally mid-afternoon, it drifted earlier over the centuries to mean midday. Spanish kept the tidier, transparent “mid-day” instead.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mediodía” (noon), “medianoche” (midnight)
- break them — “medio + día”, “media + noche” — both halves still ordinary words
- “Es mediodía. Es medianoche.” — they stand in for the hour
- the contrast — French kept “night” (*nuit*) but wore “day” down to a fossil (*-di*)

Before you move on

What do *mediodía* and *medianoche* literally mean, and from what Latin? (“Mid-day” ← *medius diēs*; “mid-night” ← *media nox*.) Are both halves still recognizable, ordinary Spanish words? (**Yes** — *medio/ media* “middle,” *día/noche* “day/night.”) Did French erode its phrase evenly? (**No** — French's *-nuit* stayed just as transparent as Spanish's *noche*, but its *-di* wore down to an opaque fossil, since the everyday French word for “day” is actually *jour*.) How do you

say “it is noon”? (*Es mediodía.*)

Chapter 38

Telling Time

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can tell the time in Spanish and choose correctly between *es la una* and *son las dos*.

Say es la una, son las dos, son las diez, and explain why one o'clock takes a singular verb while every other hour takes a plural one.

38.1 la hora — Spanish's barely-changed Latin hour

You've now seen this Latin word take three different paths: French wore it down to *heure*, German borrowed it centuries later as *Uhr*. Spanish's path is the simplest of all — it barely changed.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hora ← Latin **hōra** ← Greek **hōrā**, “a season, a time of day” (the Greek goddesses of the seasons were the *Hōrai*). Spanish kept the word almost exactly as Latin had it — just a silent **h** in spelling, a fossil of a Latin *h* that was already weak and barely pronounced by the time Spanish inherited the word (the same non-story as French *heure* or English *hour*'s silent *h*). Be careful not to confuse this with *hijo* and *hacer*'s silent *h* — those come from a completely different, later Spanish sound change (Latin **f-** → Old Spanish aspirated *h-* → eventual silence), not from an already-weak Latin *h* the way *hora*'s is. Two different roads to the

same “silent letter” result. Compare its cousins: French wore *hōra* down further to *heure*; German didn’t inherit the word at all, but borrowed it later as *Uhr*; English took the same Latin *hōra* and made *hour*.

language	word	what happened
Spanish	hora	inherited almost unchanged, just a silent <i>h</i>
French	heure	inherited, but worn down further
German	Uhr	not inherited — borrowed later, separately
English	hour	inherited via French, silent <i>h</i>

Grammar Lens: Son las and telling time

Spanish uses **ser** (“to be”) plus the **feminine plural article** (agreeing with the unspoken *horas*) to tell time — and famously switches number for “one”:

Es la una. — “It is one o’clock.” (singular — *la una*, “the one”) **Son las dos.** — “It is two o’clock.” (plural — *las dos*, “the two”) **Son las diez.** — “It is ten o’clock.”

Literally “**it is the one**” / “**they are the two/ten**” — the hour count itself is implied by the article and number, without needing to say *hora(s)* at all in everyday speech (unlike French’s *il est deux heures*, which spells out “hours” every time).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hora” — silent *h*, a fossil of an already-weak Latin *h*
- “Es la una. Son las dos. Son las diez.”
- “hora / heure / hour” — one Latin root, three different fates

Before you move on

What Latin (and Greek) word is *hora* from? (*hōra* ← Greek *hōrā*.) How did Spanish's path differ from French's and German's? (**Spanish** inherited it almost unchanged; **French** wore it down further to *heure*; **German** didn't inherit it at all and borrowed *Uhr* separately, much later.) How do you say “it is one o'clock” vs. “it is two o'clock”? (*Es la una* — singular; *Son las dos* — plural.)

Chapter 39

The Weather

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can talk about the weather in Spanish and know why llueve refuses to join hace.

Ask about el tiempo, answer hace calor, hace frío, hace sol, then switch to llueve — a verb of its own, whose ll- is the same sound change that gave llamar.

39.1 el tiempo — one word doing two jobs

Ask a Spanish speaker *¿qué tiempo hace?* and you are literally asking “**what time does it make?**” — because *tiempo* does not split “time” from “weather” the way English does.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

el tiempo = both “**time**” and “**weather**” — from Latin **tempus**, which already carried this same double sense. Nothing was merged in Spanish; the two meanings simply arrived together and stayed.

English inherited the word too, through borrowing, but kept **only the time half**: **temporal**, **contemporary**, **tempo**, **temporary**. So the double meaning is not a Spanish oddity — it is the older state of affairs, and English is the one that narrowed.

How does a Spanish speaker know which is meant? **Context alone**, and it is never ambiguous in practice: *no tengo tiempo* is “I have no time,” *¿qué tiempo hace?* is “what’s the weather like?”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el tiempo” — time, or weather, depending on context
- “¿qué tiempo hace?” — what’s the weather like?
- “tiempo” then English “tempo, temporal” — the *tempus* family

Before you move on

What two things does **el tiempo** mean? (**Time** and **weather**.) Which Latin word gives it, and did it already mean both? (**Tempus** — yes, both.) Which language narrowed the meaning, Spanish or English? (**English** — it kept only “time.”) Next: how to actually answer *¿qué tiempo hace?*

39.2 hace calor, hace frío, hace sol — the weather Spanish *makes*

You can ask *¿qué tiempo hace?* Now answer it. Three of Spanish’s commonest weather answers all take the same verb you already know — *hacer*, “to make.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **calor** ← Latin **calor**, “heat, warmth” → English **calorie**, **caloric**, **cauldron**.
- **frío** ← Latin **frigidus**, “cold” (the middle syllable syncopated away) → English **frigid**, **refrigerate**.
- **sol** ← Latin **sol**, “sun,” unchanged → English **solar**, **solstice**, **parasol**.

Here is the part worth noticing: all three are **nouns**, not adjectives. *Calor* is “heat,” not “hot.” That is exactly why Spanish reaches for **hacer**: you cannot *be* a noun, but the world can **make** one.

hace calor — “it’s hot,” literally “**it makes heat**” **hace frío** — “it’s cold,” literally “**it makes cold**” **hace sol** — “it’s sunny,” literally “**it makes sun**”

French does the same thing with the same logic (*il fait chaud*); English is the outlier, forcing weather into “it **is** hot” with an adjective.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hace calor. hace frío. hace sol.”
- the literal reading — “it makes heat, it makes cold, it makes sun”
- “calor” then English “calorie”; “frío” then “refrigerate”

Before you move on

Say “it’s hot,” “it’s cold,” “it’s sunny.” (*Hace calor, hace frío, hace sol.*) Why does Spanish use *hacer* rather than a “to be” verb? (Because *calor*, *frío* and *sol* are **nouns** — the weather **makes** heat, it does not *be* hot.) Give an English cousin of *frío*. (**Frigid, refrigerate.**)

39.3 llueve — the one weather word that will not join *hacer*

Hace calor, hace frío, hace sol — three answers, one pattern. Now try rain, and the pattern breaks. Rain does not get made in Spanish; rain has a verb of its own.

Grammar Lens: rain brings its own verb

llueve = “it’s raining.” Not *hace lluvia*, not “it makes rain” — just **llueve**, a single word that is a complete sentence.

It comes from **llover**, “to rain,” and *llover* is **impersonal**: it has no subject at all, not even a “it” you could point to. Compare the two shapes side by side:

pattern	example	what carries the weather
hacer + noun	<i>hace calor</i>	the noun (<i>calor</i> , heat)
dedicated verb	<i>llueve</i>	the verb itself

English does exactly the same split, which makes it easy to feel: you say “it **is** hot” with an adjective, but “it **rains**” with a verb built for the job. Spanish just draws the line in the same place.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

llover ← Latin **pluere**, “to rain.” Recognise that **pl-** → **ll-** shift? It is the **same regular sound change** that gave you **llamar** (← *clamāre*), **llave** (← *clāvem*, “key”) and **llama** (← *flamma*, “flame”). Latin’s *cl-*, *fl-* and *pl-* clusters all became Spanish *ll-*.

So *llueve* is not an exception you have to memorise twice: it is a predictable descendant of *pluere* (the same root English keeps in **pluvial** and the **pluviometer**, a rain gauge), and it is the one weather word with enough of its own life to refuse the *hacer* frame.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “¿qué tiempo hace?” then “hace calor. hace frío. hace sol.”
- “llueve” — one word, a whole sentence, no *hacer*
- the family — “llamar, llave, llama, llover” — four Latin clusters, one Spanish *ll-*

Before you move on

Which weather word does **not** use *hacer*, and why? (**Llueve** — rain has its own impersonal verb, *llover*.) What Latin word is *llover* from? (**Pluere**.) What sound change turned its *pl-* into *ll-*, and what other words show it? (Latin *cl-/fl-/pl-* → Spanish *ll-* — *llamar*, *llave*, *llama*.) And what does *el tiempo* mean? (**Time** and **weather**, from *tempus*.)

Chapter 40

Numbers Eleven to Twenty

Modes: ⇄ voice (4) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can count from eleven to twenty in Spanish and say where the fused Latin teens stop and the ten-and-X ones begin.

Run once to quince as fused Latin compounds, then dieciséis to diecinueve as a ten-and-X template, say why Latin's own subtractive 18 and 19 did not survive, and close on veinte.

40.1 once — quince: five words with a seam you can no longer see

Spanish counts past ten in **two completely different ways**, and the join between them is a real boundary in the language, not a place someone drew a line. Today: the first five, which you simply have to learn as words.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish	← Latin
once	<i>undecim</i> (“one-ten”)
doce	<i>duodecim</i> (“two-ten”)
trece	<i>tredecim</i> (“three-ten”)
catorce	<i>quattuordecim</i> (“four-ten”)
quince	<i>quindecim</i> (“five-ten”)

Every one of these *was* a compound — a number plus **-decim** (“ten,”

the same root as *diez*). But these five are the numbers people say most often, and heavy use wears words smooth. Centuries of everyday speech fused each pair into a single, **opaque** word: no Spanish speaker hears “one-ten” in *once* any more than an English speaker hears “two-ten” in *twelve*.

Listen for the ghost, though. The **-ce** ending on *doce*, *trece*, *catorce*, *quince* is all that survives of Latin’s *-decim*. It is the same “ten” you already say in **diez**, ground down to two letters.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “once, doce, trece, catorce, quince”
- just the endings — “-ce, -ce, -ce, -ce” — the worn-down *ten*

Before you move on

Count eleven to fifteen. (*Once, doce, trece, catorce, quince*.) What are these five, structurally? (**Fused Latin compounds** — number plus *-decim*, “ten.”) Which piece of each word is the old “ten”? (The **-ce** ending — *diez* worn down.) Next: the numbers where the seam is still wide open.

40.2 dieciséis — diecinueve: where the seam re-opens

You just learned five numbers whose insides had been ground smooth. Now say **fifteen** and then **sixteen** — *quince*, *dieciséis* — and hear the language change gear. From here you are not memorising words; you are following a rule.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Spanish	literally
dieciséis	<i>diez y seis</i> , “ten and six”
diecisiete	<i>diez y siete</i> , “ten and seven”
dieciocho	<i>diez y ocho</i> , “ten and eight”
diecinueve	<i>diez y nueve</i> , “ten and nine”

No fusion. You can hear **diez** plainly at the front of every one, and the number you already know sitting right behind it.

Grammar Lens: a formula, not a list

This is the structural difference that makes 15/16 a real boundary in Spanish rather than a convenient place to pause:

	11-15	16-19
how you get the word	remember it	build it
the “ten” inside	worn to <i>-ce</i>	still spelled <i>dieci-</i>
can you hear the parts?	no	yes

So *once* through *quince* are **vocabulary**, and *dieciséis* through *diecinueve* are **grammar**: one template, *dieci-* + *digit*, filled four times. Learn the template once and all four are already yours.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “dieciséis, diecisiete, dieciocho, diecinueve”
- the seam out loud — “diez y seis” then “dieciséis”
- the boundary — “quince” (remembered), “dieciséis” (built)

Before you move on

Count sixteen to nineteen. (*Dieciséis, diecisiete, dieciocho, diecinueve*.) Are these fused or transparent? (**Transparent** — plain “ten and X.”) Which of the two groups do you have to memorise, and which can you generate? (**Memorise 11-15; generate 16-19** from *dieci-* plus the digit.)

40.3 duodēvigintī — the quirk Spanish threw away

Dieciocho and *diecinueve* look like the least interesting words in the chapter — just two more ten-and-X compounds. They are actually the most interesting, because of what Latin said instead.

What to know first

- *dieciséis* — *diecinueve* — the *dieci-* plus digit template.

Why it's said this way

You would expect *dieciocho* and *diecinueve* to carry on whatever Latin did for 18 and 19. Latin did something else entirely. Its everyday words for those two numbers were **subtractive** — counted *down* from twenty:

number	Latin	literally
18	duodēvigintī	“two from twenty”
19	ūndēvigintī	“one from twenty”

(You still meet this habit in English clock-talk: “ten **to** four.”)

Spanish did not inherit either word. It built *dieciocho* and *diecinueve* fresh, on exactly the same simple template as 16 and 17 — quietly **regularising away** an irregularity that existed in its own parent language. Languages are usually described as wearing down and getting messier; here is a clean case of one tidying up.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- Latin's way — “two from twenty” — then Spanish's — “dieciocho”
- “dieciocho, diecinueve” — addition, not subtraction

Before you move on

How did Latin say 18 and 19? (**Subtractively** — *duodēvigintī*, “two from twenty,” and *ūndēvigintī*, “one from twenty.”) Did Spanish keep that? (**No** — it built *dieciocho* and *diecinueve* on the regular ten-and-X template.) So which language is the irregular one here? (**Latin** — Spanish simplified.)

40.4 veinte — the number the teens were counting toward

Latin's own 18 and 19 were counted *down from twenty*. So it is worth meeting twenty itself — the number the whole run has been aiming at.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

veinte (“twenty”) ← Latin **vīgintī**. It was worn down by ordinary sound change — the *g* softened away, the vowels shifted — but notice what did **not** happen to it: it was never **fused** out of two separate words the way *once* through *quince* were. *Vīgintī* was already a single word for a single round number, so there is no seam inside *veinte* to look for. Three different histories, then, in one short chapter:

words	what happened
<i>once</i> - <i>quince</i>	two words fused into one
<i>dieciséis</i> - <i>diecinueve</i>	two words built into one, seam visible
<i>veinte</i>	one word, simply worn

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “once, doce, trece, catorce, quince” — the five fused Latins
- “dieciséis, diecisiete, dieciocho, diecinueve” — built, not fused
- “veinte” — twenty, worn but never fused

Before you move on

Count eleven to twenty. Where is the boundary between remembering and building, and why is it there? (**After** *quince* — 11-15 are fused Latin compounds, 16-19 are *dieci-* plus a digit.) Did Spanish inherit Latin's subtractive 18 and 19? (**No** — it regularised them.) Was *veinte* fused from two words? (**No** — Latin *vīgintī* was already one word; it was only worn down.)

Chapter 41

Dog and Cat

Modes: 🗣 voice (2) 🖱 Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a dog and a cat in Spanish and say which of the two words still has no agreed origin.

Say gato and perro, trace cattus back toward Egypt, then admit that perro — which pushed out the older can — has no settled etymology at all.

41.1 gato — the word that travelled with the animal

Some etymologies can be followed all the way home. This one runs from your mouth back to ancient Egypt, and every step of it is documented.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

gato (“**cat**”) ← Latin **cattus**. But *cattus* was **not** Classical Latin’s word for cat. That was **fēlēs**, which survives today only in the scientific name *Felis catus* and in English **feline**.

Cattus entered Latin **later**, arriving with the animal itself as domestic cats spread along **Roman trade routes** from where they were domesticated — **Egypt**, around 2000 BCE. The word is most likely **Afro-Asiatic** in origin (compare Nubian **kadis**, “cat”).

So word and creature travelled together, out of Africa into Europe, and the newcomer pushed *fēlēs* out almost everywhere: Spanish *gato*, Italian *gatto*, French *chat*, Old Irish *cat*, Welsh *cath*, English *cat*. When a thing

arrives from abroad, its name usually arrives with it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “el gato” — the cat
- the trail — “kadis, cattus, gato”
- the word it replaced — “fēlēs,” now only in “feline”

Before you move on

What was Classical Latin’s actual word for cat, and where does it survive? (**Fēlēs** — in *Felis catus* and English *feline*.) Where did *cattus* most likely come from? (An **Afro-Asiatic** word, travelling with the domesticated cat out of **Egypt**.) Next: the other animal in this chapter, whose history nobody can trace at all.

41.2 perro — the word nobody can explain

Gato could be traced all the way to Egypt. **Perro** is the opposite kind of word, and it is worth knowing that such words exist: completely ordinary, used a thousand times a day, and **nobody knows where it came from**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

perro (“dog”). Roll the *rr*: *PEH-rrro*.

The word Spanish **should** have inherited is **canis** — the same root as English **canine**, French *chien*, Italian *cane*. And it did survive, as the now-archaic Spanish **can** (still readable in old poetry and in *canino*). But at some point *perro* pushed *can* almost entirely out of everyday use — and *perro* itself has no agreed origin.

Why it’s said this way

Three serious proposals, none confirmed:

proposal	the case for it	the problem
onomatopoeia — a growl, or a shepherd's call " <i>perr, perr</i> "	matches how herding calls become names elsewhere	no early written evidence
pre-Roman Iberian substrate	the <i>-rro</i> ending is a known marker of likely pre-Latin words in Spanish	the substrate languages are barely recorded
Persian <i>persus</i> , a hunting-dog breed	such breeds did spread in the late Empire	the sound match is loose

Notice what makes this a **good** open question rather than a shrug: each proposal predicts different evidence, and the evidence needed simply has not survived. *Perro* remains one of Spanish's genuinely unsolved puzzles, and a useful reminder that "we don't know" is a real answer in etymology, not a gap in your notes.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "el perro, el gato" — dog and cat
- "can" — the archaic word *perro* replaced, from Latin *canis*
- the contrast — "gato, traced to Egypt; perro, unsolved"

Before you move on

What archaic Spanish word did *perro* replace, and what is its Latin source? (**Can**, from **canis** — the root of English *canine*.) Does *perro* have a confirmed etymology? (**No** — onomatopoeic, pre-Latin substrate and Persian proposals all remain unconfirmed.) And *gato*'s origin, by contrast? (**Traceable** — Latin *cattus*, probably Afro-Asiatic, travelling out of Egypt.)

Chapter 42

Green and Yellow

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name green and yellow in Spanish and explain why amarillo is built on the word for bitter.

Say verde and amarillo, tie verde to virēre, to flourish, and amarillo to amarellus, a little bitter — the same root as everyday amargo.

42.1 verde — the colour named after being alive

After *azul*'s long journey from Afghanistan, here is a colour that stayed exactly where it started. It is also the one that names a **process** rather than a thing.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

verde (“**green**”) ← Latin **viridis** (worn down through *virdis*), which comes from the verb **virēre**, “**to be green, to flourish, to be vigorous.**”

So the adjective is built on a **verb of thriving**. Latin did not name the colour of leaves; it named what leaves are *doing*, and let the colour follow. The same root gives *vigour* its neighbours in English: **verdant**, **verdure**, and the green-tinged **verdigris** (“green of Greece”).

One careful non-connection: **verde is not a cousin of English green**. *Green* comes from a completely separate **Germanic** root, tied to *grow* and *grass* — which, funnily enough, is the same idea arrived at independently. Two families, two words, one metaphor: green is the colour of things that are growing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “verde” — green
- the root — “virēre, to flourish” → “verde”
- “verde” then English “verdant” — and *not* “green”

Before you move on

What Latin verb gives **verde**, and what does it mean? (**Virēre**, “to be green, to flourish.”) Is *verde* related to English *green*? (**No** — *green* is Germanic, from the same family as *grow* and *grass*; the two languages reached the same metaphor separately.) Next: a colour that is not named after a colour at all.

42.2 amarillo — the colour that started as a taste

Verde was exactly what you would expect from Latin. This one is not. Latin had three perfectly good words for yellow, and Spanish took none of them.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

amarillo (“**yellow**”) does **not** trace to *flāvus*, *gilvus* or *lūteus* — Latin’s actual yellow words. It comes from Late Latin **amarellus**, “**a little bitter**,” a diminutive of **amarus**, “**bitter**.”

A colour named after a **taste**. The bridge is medicine: yellow was the colour of **bile** and of **jaundice** (which Spanish still calls *ictericia*, but which folk speech long tied to bitterness), and of a great many bitter-tasting plants. A word meaning “somewhat bitter” came to mean “the yellowish look of a bitter thing,” then simply “yellowish,” and by Spanish’s Golden Age it had dropped the taste entirely and kept only the colour.

You can still check the family in a living word: **amargo** (“bitter”) is *amarillo*’s cousin, straight from the same *amarus*. Say them together and the shared *amar-* is right there.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “verde, amarillo” — green and yellow
- “amarillo, amargo” — hear the shared *amar-*
- the path — “a little bitter” → “yellowish” → “yellow”

Before you move on

Does **amarillo** come from a Latin word for yellow? (**No** — from *amarellus*, “a little bitter,” a diminutive of *amarus*.) What everyday Spanish word is its cousin? (**Amargo**, “bitter.”) And *verde*? (From **virēre**, “to flourish” — a colour named after being alive, as this one is named after a taste.)

Chapter 43

Four Verbs of the Mind

Modes: ⇄ voice (4) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I think, understand, read and write in Spanish, and break the stems of *pensar* and *entender* the way a stem-changer requires.

*Run *pensar* and *entender* through the $e \rightarrow ie$ boot, then *leer* and *escribir* as the pair that does not break, and close on the propped-up *e-* that turns *scribere* into *escribir* and *schola* into *escuela*.*

43.1 *pensar* — “to think”, and it started out meaning “to weigh”

You can already run an *-ar* verb: *hablo, hablas, habla*. Here is one that takes those same endings and then cracks its stem in the middle, the way *querer* did.

Sounds you’ll need

- diphthong-*ie* — under stress the *e* breaks open: **pienso** = *PYEN-so*.
- The *s* is always a clear hissing *s*, never an English *z* buzz.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

pensar (“to think”) ← Latin **pēnsāre**, “to weigh” — the repeating form of *pendere*, “to hang, to weigh out”. A Roman hung goods on a balance; the same verb slid across to weighing an idea.

English kept the whole family, and most of it still smells of money and scales:

- **pensive** — turning something over on the balance.
- **compensate** — *com-* “together” + weigh: settle one weight against another.
- **expense, dispense, pension** — payments were literally *weighed out*.
- **peso** — a coin whose name simply means “a weight”.
- **pansy** — from French *pensée*, “a thought”.

English reaches for the same picture without noticing it: you *weigh your options*, and an argument *carries weight*.

Grammar Lens: the same endings, a broken stem

The endings are the ordinary *-ar* set. Only the stressed *e* changes:

person	form	stem
yo	pienso	broken
tú	piensas	broken
él/ella/usted	piensa	broken
nosotros	pensamos	plain
ellos/ustedes	piensan	broken

Pensamos keeps the plain *e* because there the stress lands on the ending, not the stem — exactly the rule *querer* taught you.

Two small habits come with the verb: *pensar* **en** something means “think about” it (*pienso en ti*), and *pensar* followed by a bare infinitive means “plan to” (*pienso hablar* — I mean to speak).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pensar” then the set — “pienso, piensas, piensa, pensamos, piensan”
- “Pienso en ti” — I am thinking of you

- “pensar” then English “pensive, compensate, peso” — the weighing family

Before you move on

What did *pēnsāre* mean literally, and name two English cousins. (**To weigh**; *pensive, compensate, expense, peso*.) Which form keeps the plain *e*, and why? (*Pensamos* — the stress falls on the ending.) Which little word follows *pensar* for “think about”? (**En.**) Next: **entender**, which cracks the same way.

43.2 entender — “to understand”, built out of stretching

Pensar broke its stem under stress. So does this one — and it hands you the single most useful sentence a beginner owns: **no entiendo**, “I don’t understand.”

Sounds you’ll need

- diphthong-**ie** — **entiendo** = *en-TYEN-do*.
- **d-soft** — the *d* between vowels is soft, close to the *th* of English *this*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

entender (“to understand”) ← Latin **intendere**: **in-** (“toward”) + **tendere** (“to stretch”). Understanding something was *stretching your attention toward* it — leaning in.

tendere stretches right across English:

- **intend, intent, intense, intention** — the very same *in-* + stretch.
- **attend, attention** — *ad-* “toward”, stretch that way.
- **extend, contend, pretend, tension, tendon, and tent**, which is stretched cloth.

So *entiendo* and *I intend* are the same two Latin pieces landing in different places: Spanish went to “I grasp it”, English to “I mean to”.

Careful with a false friend. Spanish **pretender** is *not* English *pretend*. It means “to aim at, to be after” — *pretende ser médico*, “he means to become a doctor”. Same pieces, different landing.

Grammar Lens: an -er verb that cracks, and a calmer twin

Ordinary -er endings, stressed *e* broken to *ie*:

person	form	stem
yo	entiendo	broken
tú	entiendes	broken
nosotros	entendemos	plain
ellos/ustedes	entienden	broken

Spanish has a second verb for this job: **comprender** ← Latin *comprehendere*, “to seize together” (→ English **comprehend**, **apprehend**, **comprehensive**). It is a plain -er verb with no crack at all: *comprendo*, *comprendes*, *comprende*. Both mean “understand”. *Entender* is the everyday one; *comprender* leans a little more formal, and more toward grasping a whole thing than catching a word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “No entiendo” — I don’t understand
- “entiendo, entiendes, entendemos, entienden”
- “pienso” then “entiendo” — the same crack, twice
- “entender” then English “intend, intense, attention” — the stretching family

Before you move on

What does *tendere* mean, and what does *in-* add? (**To stretch**; “to-ward”.) Give the *yo* and *nosotros* forms. (*Entiendo*, *entendemos*.) Of *entender* and *comprender*, which one breaks its stem? (**Entender**.) And what does Spanish *pretender* mean? (**To aim at**, not to pretend.) Next: **leer**.

43.3 leer — “to read”, and before that, “to gather”

Two cracked verbs down. Here is a calm one — nothing breaks in the middle. The only difficulty is in your mouth: two *e*’s in a row that must stay two.

Sounds you’ll need

- **hiatus-ee** — **leer** is two syllables, *le-ER*, never one long English *ee*.
- **leo** is likewise two beats, *LE-o*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

leer (“to read”) ← Latin **legere**, “to gather, to pick out, to choose” — and only afterwards “to read”. A reader picks letters out of a row the way a farmhand picks olives off a branch.

That gathering root runs through an enormous amount of English:

- **legible**, **legend** (“things to be read”), **lecture**, **lectern**, and worn right down, **lesson**.
- built with prefixes: **collect** (*col-* “together”), **select** (*se-* “apart”), **elect** (*e-* “out”), **intellect** (*inter-* “between” — choosing between things).
- **diligent** and **elegant**, both of which meant “picking carefully”.

One honest limit: Greek *légein* (“to speak, to gather”) — which gives English *logic*, *dialogue*, *catalogue* — is a **cousin** of *legere* from the same ancient root, not its parent. Same family, separate journeys.

Grammar Lens: a plain -er verb, with a mouthful

Nothing irregular happens. Drop *-er*, add the ordinary endings:

person	form	said
yo	leo	LE-o
tú	lees	LE-es
él/ella/usted	lee	LE-e
nosotros	leemos	le-E-mos
ellos/ustedes	leen	LE-en
Every one of those is a syllable longer than an English speaker expects. Give each <i>e</i> its own beat and the word comes out right.		

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “leer” — *le-ER*, two beats
- “Leo un libro” — I read a book
- “No entiendo” then “Leo, pero no entiendo” — I read, but I don’t understand
- “leer” then English “legible, collect, select, elect”

Before you move on

What did *legere* mean before it meant “to read”? (**To gather, to pick out.**) Give two English words built on it with a prefix. (*Collect, select, elect, intellect.*) How many syllables in *leo*? (**Two** — *LE-o.*) Next: **escribir**, the other half of literacy.

43.4 escribir — “to write”, which once meant “to scratch”

Leer gathers letters off a page. This is the other half of the same skill — and its root remembers a time when writing was done with a sharp point in wax.

Sounds you'll need

- **st-no-e** — Spanish will not begin a word with *sc-*, *sp-*, *st-*, so it props one up with an **e-**: *es-cri-BIR*.
- **b-soft** — between vowels the *b* is soft, lips barely touching.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

escribir (“to write”) ← Latin **scribere**, whose first sense was “to scratch, to incise”. Writing was cutting a line into wax or stone before it was ever ink on paper.

The English family is huge, and every member still works with a pen:

- **scribe, scribble, script, scripture.**
- **describe** (*de-* “down”) and **description**; **prescribe** (*prae-* “before”) and **prescription**; **subscribe** (*sub-* “under” — you signed at the bottom); **inscription**; **transcript**; **postscript**.
- **manuscript** — *manus* “hand” + *scriptum*: written by hand.
- **conscription** — being *written into* an army.

The Spanish past participle is **escrito** (“written”), which is English **script** wearing different clothes.

Grammar Lens: an -ir verb, and a productive spelling rule

Escribir is a plain *-ir* verb, the family *vivir* opened:

person	form	ending
yo	escribo	-o
tú	escribes	-es
él/ella/usted	escribe	-e
nosotros	escribimos	-imos
ellos/ustedes	escriben	-en

That propped-up **e-** is a rule you can run yourself, not a quirk of one word: Latin *schola* became **escuela**, *spatha* became **espada** (sword), *stāre* became **estar**, *Hispania* became **España**. It is also why a Spanish speaker learning English says *eh-Spain*.

Now you can state a plan out loud: *Pienso escribir* — “I mean to write.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “escribo, escribes, escribe, escribimos, escriben”
- “Leo y escribo español” — I read and write Spanish
- “Pienso escribir” — I mean to write
- “escribir” then English “scribe, describe, manuscript” — the scratching family

Before you move on

What did *scribere* mean first? (**To scratch, to incise.**) Why does Spanish say *escuela* and *España*? (It refuses to open a word with *sc-* or *sp-*, so it props an **e-** in front.) Say “I read and write Spanish”. (*Leo y escribo español.*) And what does *legere* mean, from the lesson before? (**To gather, to pick out.**) Next chapter: taking, asking, helping — and a verb that runs backwards.

Chapter 44

Taking, Asking, Helping — and the Backwards Verb

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say I take, ask and help in Spanish, and build a sentence with *gustar* the way Spanish actually builds it — with the thing liked as the subject.

Say tomar, preguntar and ayudar, then turn gustar around: me gusta el libro is the book pleasing me, so the verb agrees with the thing and the person moves into the little word in front.

44.1 tomar — “to take”, and nobody knows where it came from

Every verb so far ran straight back to a Latin root you could name. Here is one that does not — and the gap is the useful part.

Sounds you’ll need

- **r-tap** — one soft tap of the tongue: *to-MAR*.
- **vowel-o** — a short, pure *o*, with no English glide toward *ow*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

tomar (“to take”) is a plain *-ar* verb: **tomo, tomas, toma, tomamos, toman**. It is one of the most common verbs in the language, and its origin is **genuinely unsettled**.

The leading proposal derives it from Latin *autumāre*, “to take as, to assert”, worn down through an intermediate *tumar*; a rival one points to a pre-Roman Iberian word Latin never recorded. Neither is proved, and careful dictionaries say so. “We don’t know” is a real answer in etymology.

It carries a second everyday sense across Latin America: **to drink**. A waiter asking ¿*Qué vas a tomar?* is asking what you would like.

Why it’s said this way

Latin’s own “gather up” verb survived perfectly well: **coger** ← **col-ligere**, which is *com-* (“together”) + *legere* — the very root you met in *leer*. English took that same Latin word twice: **collect** straight from the Latin, and **coil** by way of French.

In Spain *coger* is the plain everyday word: *coger el autobús*, catch the bus. In much of Latin America — Argentina, Mexico and well beyond — it is **coarse slang for sex**, and using it innocently will derail a conversation. *Tomar* is safe on both sides of the Atlantic, which is a large part of why it won.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “tomo, tomas, toma, tomamos, toman”
- “Tomo un café” — I’ll have a coffee
- “Tomo el autobús” — the safe way to say it anywhere
- “coger” then English “collect, coil” — one root, and one place to be careful

Before you move on

Does *tomar* have a confirmed etymology? (**No** — *autumāre* and a pre-Roman source are both unproved.) What Latin verb gives *coger*, and

which root sits inside it? (*Colligere*, holding *legere*, “to gather”, from *leer*.) Why reach for *tomar* instead? (*Coger* is coarse slang across much of Latin America.) Next: **preguntar**, and the two different asks.

44.2 **preguntar** — “to ask”, by sounding the water with a pole

English gets by with one verb, *ask*. Spanish splits the job in two, and picking the wrong half is a reliable beginner mistake. Here is the first half.

Sounds you’ll need

- **pr-cluster** — *pre-* is one crisp beat, *preh*, with a tapped *r*.
- **g-hard** — the *g* before *u* is hard, as in English *gun*: *pre-goon-TAR*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

preguntar (“to ask a question”) ← Vulgar Latin **praecunctāre**, itself a reshaping of classical **percontārī**, “to inquire”. And *percontārī* was built on **contus**, “a punting pole”: to *percontor* was to push a pole down through water and find out how deep it was.

Asking is taking a sounding. Unlike almost every other word here, *preguntar* left English nothing — the pole word died out — yet English rebuilt the same metaphor on its own: you *sound someone out*, you *probe*.

The verb is a plain *-ar* one: **pregunto**, **preguntas**, **pregunta**, **preguntamos**, **preguntan**. Its noun is **la pregunta** (fem.), and note that Spanish *makes* a question rather than asking one: *hacer una pregunta*.

Grammar Lens: one English “ask”, two Spanish verbs

Spanish sorts asking by **what you are after**:

what you want	verb	example
information	preguntar	<i>Te pregunto la hora</i> — I’m asking you the time
a thing or a favour	pedir	<i>Pido un café</i> — I’m asking for a coffee

Ask for a coffee with *preguntar* and you have said “I question a coffee”. The line is simple: a question takes *preguntar*, a request takes *pedir*. **pedir** ← Latin **petere**, “to make for, to aim at” — and *that* root stocked English generously: **petition**, **appetite**, **compete**, **impetus**, **perpetual**, **centripetal**. It cracks a third way, *e* → *i*: **pido**, **pides**, **pide**, **pedimos**, **piden**. Recognise *pido* for now; the pattern gets its own lesson later.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pregunto, preguntas, pregunta, preguntamos, preguntan”
- “Te pregunto la hora” — I’m asking you the time
- “Pido un café” then “Tomo un café” — I ask for one, I have one
- “pedir” then English “petition, appetite, compete” — the aiming family

Before you move on

What did *percontārī* picture literally? (**Sounding water with a pole.**) Which verb asks for a coffee, and which asks the time? (*Pedir* for the coffee; *preguntar* for the time.) What Latin root is *pedir* from, and one English cousin? (*Petere*, “to aim at” — *petition*, *appetite*, *compete*.) Next: **ayudar**, which is the same word as English *aid*.

44.3 **ayudar** — “to help”, and it is English “aid” in disguise

You can ask a question now. The next thing to ask for is a hand — and this verb is one you already own in English without

knowing it.

Sounds you'll need

- **vowel-a** — a clean, open *a*: *a-yoo-DAR*.
- **r-tap** — one tap at the end, not an English *r*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ayudar (“to help”) ← Latin **adiūtāre**, the repeating form of **adiuvāre**: **ad-** (“toward”) + **iuvāre** (“to help, to delight”). To help was to move toward someone.

English borrowed that identical verb through Old French *aidier* and calls it **aid**. So *ayudar* and *aid* are not merely cousins — they are the **same word** by two different roads. The family came with it:

- **aide**, and **aide-de-camp**, an officer who helps.
- **adjutant** — the officer whose whole job is assisting.
- **adjuvant** — a substance that helps another drug work.
- **coadjutor** — one who helps alongside.

The shape change is a rule, not an accident. Latin **-di-** before a vowel turned into Spanish **y**: *adiūtāre* → **ayudar**, *hodiē* → **hoy** (“today”), *podium* → *poyo*. Once you have that, the word stops looking arbitrary.

Grammar Lens: a plain -ar verb, and how to ask for a hand

Nothing breaks; the endings are the ones you started with:

person	form	meaning
yo	ayudo	I help
tú	ayudas	you help
nosotros	ayudamos	we help
ellos/ustedes	ayudan	they help

Its noun is **la ayuda** (fem.), “help” — the word on relief packages worldwide. Two sentences worth owning: *¿Me ayudas?* (“will you help me?” — Spanish uses the plain present where English needs *will*) and, politely, *¿Puedo ayudarle?*

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ayudo, ayudas, ayudamos, ayudan”
- “¿Me ayudas?” — will you help me?
- “Te pregunto” then “Me ayudas” — I ask you, you help me
- “ayudar” then English “aid, adjutant, adjuvant” — one word, two roads

Before you move on

What two Latin pieces build *adiuvāre*? (**Ad-** “toward” + **iuvāre** “to help”.) What everyday English word is *ayudar*, arriving by French? (**Aid**.) What sound-law turned *adiūtāre* into *ayudar*, and which other word shows it? (Latin **-di-** became Spanish **y**; *hodiē* → *hoy*.) Next: **gustar**, the verb that runs backwards.

44.4 gustar — the verb that runs backwards

Back in the introductions you learned **mucho gusto** — “much pleasure”. Here is the verb that noun belongs to, assembled the opposite way round from English. It is the single thing in Spanish that trips English speakers up hardest.

Sounds you’ll need

- **g-hard** — a hard *g* before *u*: *goos-TAR*.
- **s-clear** — a clean hissing *s*, never a *z* buzz.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

gustar ← Latin **gustāre**, “to taste”. English kept the root and stayed close to the tongue:

- **gusto** — doing something with relish, that is, with a taste for it.
- **gustatory** — of the sense of taste.
- **disgust** — *dis-* “away” + taste: what you spit back out.

- **degustation**, a tasting menu; and through French, **ragout**.

Spanish's own **el gusto** — the *gusto* of *mucho gusto* — still holds both senses: taste on the tongue, and pleasure taken in a thing. The verb followed the second: *gustar* means “**to please**”.

Grammar Lens: the thing you like is the subject

English says **I** like the book: the liker is the subject. Spanish has no such sentence. It says **Me gusta el libro** — “the book is pleasing **to me**”.

Everything follows from that:

- *el libro* is the **subject**, which is why the verb is *gusta*, third person.
- *me* is the person it happens **to**, not the one doing anything.

So the verb agrees with the **thing**, never with you:

what you mean	Spanish	why
I like the book	Me gusta el libro	one book, so <i>gusta</i>
I like books	Me gustan los libros	many books, so <i>gustan</i>
I like reading	Me gusta leer	one action, so <i>gusta</i>

To change who is pleased, change the little word in front, not the verb: **me** (to me), **te** (to you), **le** (to him, her, *usted*), **nos** (to us), **les** (to them).

Careful. There is no *yo gusto el libro*. *Yo gusto* is a real sentence — it means “**I** am pleasing” — just not the one you were reaching for.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “Me gusta el café” then “Me gustan los libros” — the verb follows the thing
- “Te gusta tomar café” — you like drinking coffee

- “Me gusta ayudar” — I like helping
- “gustar” then English “gusto, disgust, gustatory” — the tasting family

Before you move on

In *me gusta el libro*, what is the subject? (**El libro.**) Why is it *me gustan los libros*? (The verb agrees with *los libros*, which is plural.) What did *gustāre* mean, and name an English cousin. (**To taste; gusto, disgust.**) And what would *yo gusto* actually mean? (**I am pleasing.**)

Chapter 45

Hearing, Sleeping, Walking, Running

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say I hear, sleep, walk and run in Spanish, write *oír*’s *y* where the spelling demands it, and break *dormir*’s *o* to *ue* the way a boot verb does.

Run the chapter’s four verbs together and sort them by what they do to their stems: correr, caminar and andar leave theirs alone, dormir breaks o to ue, oír grows a g in oigo and writes y in oyes. Then name each verb’s source in turn — audīre, dormīre, Gaulish camminus, currere — and set the two words with no settled origin, andar and perro, against them.

45.1 *oír* — “to hear”, and the *y* that appears from nowhere

Say *Me gusta el café* once — the coffee is pleasing to me, and the coffee is the subject. Now a verb about the ears, and one of the most bent-out-of-shape words in the language.

Sounds you’ll need

- **accent-i** — the accent on *í* keeps the vowels apart: *o-EER*, two beats.
- **y-glide** — the *y* in *oyes* is the consonant of English *yes*: *O-yes*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

oír (“to hear”) ← Latin **audīre**, “to hear”. Spanish wore it right down: the *d* between vowels dropped away and *au-* collapsed to *o-*.

English never inherited it but borrowed it repeatedly, and the family keeps the *aud-* Spanish threw away: **audio**, **audible**, **audition**, **auditorium**, **audit**, **audience** — the people doing the hearing.

Then the surprise. **Obey** is Latin **oboedīre**, *ob-* (“toward”) + *audīre*: obeying is literally **listening toward** someone. **Obedient** comes with it.

Why it’s said this way

Spanish splits what English leaves joined. **Oír** is what your ears do whether you meant it or not. **Escuchar** is on purpose.

Escuchar has its own root: Latin **auscultāre**, “to listen to”, built on *auris*, “ear”. A doctor **auscultates** a chest; and when Old French wore *auscultāre* down to *escouter*, English borrowed it as **scout** — one sent out to listen. English can draw the line when it wants. Spanish makes you.

Grammar Lens: the -go yo-form, and a spelling rule

person	form
yo	oigo
tú	oyes
él/ella/usted	oye
nosotros	oímos
ellos/ustedes	oyen

Two separate things. The *yo*-form grows the hard **-g-** you know from *tengo*, *hago* and *digo*; *oír* joins that club.

The rest is **spelling**, not sound. Spanish will not write an unstressed **i** stranded between two vowels, so *oi-es* is impossible and the letter becomes **y**: *oyes*, *oye*, *oyen*. *Oímos* keeps its accent because there the *i* is stressed.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “oigo, oyes, oye, oímos, oyen”

- “¿Me oyes?” — can you hear me?
- “Me gusta oír” — hearing is pleasing to me
- “oír” then English “audio, audience, obey”

Before you move on

Which Latin verb is behind *oír*, and what has *obey* to do with it? (**Audīre**; *oboedīre* is “to listen toward”.) Why *oyes* and not *oies*? (Spanish will not leave an unstressed *i* between two vowels.) Which of *oír* and *escuchar* do you choose to do? (**Escuchar**.) And in *me gusta el café*, what is the subject? (**El café**.)

45.2 dormir — “to sleep”, and the boot’s other vowel

Run *oír* once more: *oigo*, *oyes*, *oye*, *oímos*, *oyen* — and remember that the *y* in *oyes* is a spelling rule, not a new sound. Now a verb whose stem cracks the way *pensar*’s did, but on a different vowel.

Sounds you’ll need

- **diphthong-ue** — under stress the *o* breaks open: **duermo** = *DWER-mo*.
- **r-tap** — one soft flick of the tongue in *dormir*, nothing like an English *r*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

dormir (“to sleep”) ← Latin **dormīre**, “to sleep” — one of the rare verbs Spanish inherited almost untouched. English took the root only through French and Latin, and every borrowing still points at a bed:

- **dormitory**, and its clipped **dorm** — the room where sleeping is done.
- **dormant** — from the French participle *dormant*, “sleeping”. A dormant volcano is a sleeping one.
- **dormer** — the window let into a roof, named for the

sleeping-loft behind it.

Spanish keeps its own branch: **el dormitorio** for the bedroom, and *la bella durmiente* for Sleeping Beauty.

The **dormouse** looks like the obvious member of this family, and careful dictionaries will not commit. An Anglo-Norman *dormeus*, “sleepy”, is the best guess, but the trail goes cold. Treat it as likely rather than proved.

Grammar Lens: the boot again, with o→ue

person	form	stem
yo	duermo	broken
tú	duermes	broken
él/ella/usted	duerme	broken
nosotros	dormimos	plain
ellos/ustedes	duermen	broken

Pensar broke **e→ie** under stress. *Dormir* breaks **o→ue** under exactly the same condition, and for exactly the same reason: the stress falls on the stem in four of these forms and on the ending in *dormimos*, so only *dormimos* keeps its plain *o*.

That is the whole of the rule. Spanish has two stressed vowels that will not sit still — *e* becomes *ie*, *o* becomes *ue* — and once you can hear where the stress lands, you can predict which forms crack without memorising a list.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “duermo, duermes, duerme, dormimos, duermen”
- “pienso” then “duermo” — *e* to *ie*, *o* to *ue*, one rule
- “No duermo bien” — I don’t sleep well
- “dormir” then English “dormitory, dormant, dormer” — the sleeping family

Before you move on

Which form of *dormir* keeps its plain *o*, and why? (*Dormimos* — the stress lands on the ending.) Name two English cousins of *dormire*. (*Dormitory*, *dormant*, *dormer*.) What did *pēnsāre*, behind *pensar*, mean literally? (**To weigh.**) And what is the *yo*-form of *oír*? (**Oigo.**)

45.3 caminar — “to walk”, from a word Rome borrowed from the Celts

Duermo, *duermes*, *duerme* — the *o* cracking to *ue*. Relax: the two verbs here do nothing of the kind. The interest is in where they came from.

Sounds you’ll need

- **k-hard** — the *c* before *a* is a hard *k*: *ka-mi-NAR*.
- **vowel-a** — a short clean *a*, the same in every syllable.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

caminar (“to walk”) was built on the noun **el camino**, “the road” — and *camino* is not a Latin word at all. Latin **camminus** was a loan from **Gaulish**, the Celtic language of pre-Roman France, from a word for a step or a way. It stocked the roads of every Romance language: *camino*, Portuguese *caminho*, Italian *cammino*, French *chemin*. Here the cousin web runs out, and that is worth saying plainly: this root reached English only inside borrowed French phrases. The Celtic layer did reach English by other doors — Latin also took Gaulish *carrus*, a wagon, behind **car** and **cargo**. *Camminus* never crossed.

A false friend that looks certain. Latin also had **camīnus**, “hearth”, from Greek *kaminos* — and *that* gave English **chimney**. Two nearly identical Latin words, no relation.

Grammar Lens: two plain verbs, and which to reach for

Spanish has a second everyday verb here, **andar**. Both take ordinary *-ar* endings and neither breaks its stem.

person	caminar	andar
yo	camino	ando
tú	caminas	andas
él/ella/usted	camina	anda
nosotros	caminamos	andamos
ellos/ustedes	caminan	andan

Caminar is walking as the thing you are doing. **Andar** is wider: to go about, and by extension to work at all — *no anda*, of a machine, means “it isn’t running”. Either serves for a walk.

Why it’s said this way

Camino has a clean history. *Andar* does not. It comes down from Medieval Latin **andāre**, and where *andāre* came from is **genuinely disputed**: *ambulāre* (“to walk about”) and *ambitāre* (“to go around”) are both proposed and neither is proved. If *ambulāre* is right, **amble** and **ambulance** are cousins — but that “if” carries real weight.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “camino, caminas, camina, caminamos, caminan”
- “ando, andas, anda, andamos, andan”
- “Camino una hora” — I walk for an hour
- “el camino” then “camino” — the road, and I walk it

Before you move on

Which language did Latin borrow *camminus* from? (**Gaulish**.) Which English word comes from the *other* Latin *camīnus*, the hearth? (**Chimney** — unrelated.) Is *andar*’s origin settled? (**No**.) Say “I walk for an hour”. (*Camino una hora*.) And the *nosotros* form of *dormir*? (*Dormimos*.)

45.4 correr — “to run”, and the root that runs through half of English

You can walk two ways now — *camino* and *ando*. Speed it up. This last verb of the chapter is the plainest to conjugate and the richest to trace.

Sounds you’ll need

- **rolled-rr** — the double *r* is a full trill: *ko-RRER*. It is a different letter from a single *r*, and swapping them swaps words.
- **vowel-o** — a short pure *o*, no glide toward English *ow*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

correr (“to run”) ← Latin **currere**, “to run”. English borrowed this root harder than almost any other, and the descendants have spread so far from running that they no longer look related:

- **current** — water that runs; **currency**, money running hand to hand.
- **curriculum** — a *running*, a racecourse. A course of study is a track you run.
- **courier**, a runner; **course**, **cursor**, **cursive** — writing that runs.
- **corridor** — a place for running along, by way of Italian.
- with prefixes: **occur** (*ob*-, to run up against), **recur**, **incur**, **precursor**, **excursion**.

And a cousin from the lesson before: Gaulish *carrus*, behind English **car** and **cargo**, comes from the very same Proto-Indo-European root **kers-**, “to run”. Latin took one road and Celtic another; English holds both ends.

Grammar Lens: a plain -er verb, and four verbs together

Correr breaks nothing and grows nothing: **corro**, **corres**, **corre**, **corremos**, **corren**. That makes it the clean case the chapter’s others stand out against:

verb	what it does to its stem
correr	nothing — <i>corro, corres, corre</i>
caminar, andar	nothing — <i>camino, ando</i>
dormir	breaks <i>o</i> to <i>ue</i> under stress — <i>duermo</i> , but <i>dormimos</i>
oír	grows <i>-g-</i> in <i>oigo</i> , and writes <i>y</i> in <i>oyes, oye, oyen</i>
Only two of the four misbehave, and each misbehaves by a rule you can state.	

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “corro, corres, corre, corremos, corren”
- “El perro corre” — the dog runs
- “Camino, no corro” — I walk, I don’t run
- “Corro el sábado” — I run on Saturday; Spanish uses the bare article where English says *on*
- “Oigo, duermo, camino, corro” — the whole chapter in four words
- “correr” then English “current, curriculum, corridor” — the running family

Before you move on

Name each verb’s source in turn: *oír*, *dormir*, *caminar*, *correr*. (**Audīre**; **dormīre**; Gaulish *camminus*, by way of *el camino*; **currere**.) Which of the four leave their stems alone? (*Caminar*, *andar* and *correr*.) Say “the dog runs”. (*El perro corre*.) Two words here have no settled origin — which? (*Andar*, and *perro*, whose three proposals all lack the evidence to decide between them.) And which English everyday word is a cousin of *correr* through Celtic? (**Car**.)

Chapter 46

Opening, Closing, Sitting Down, Standing Up

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say I open, close, sit down and stand up in Spanish, and use the reflexive pronoun that makes *sentarse* and *levantarse* land the action back on me.

Say the chapter in one breath — abro el libro, me siento, cierro el libro, me levanto — then separate the two features it taught: sentarse is reflexive and a stem-changer, levantarse is reflexive only. Name the shared recipe behind both body-position verbs (a Latin present participle, sedēns and levāns), pick abierto out as the one irregular participle, and reach back to la mano for why the article stays feminine.

46.1 abrir — “to open”, and the one part of it that misbehaves

Say *corro* and *camino* once — two verbs that gave you no trouble. This one is nearly as easy, and its one misbehaving piece is a word you will read on a shop door before you ever say it.

Sounds you’ll need

- **b-soft** — between vowels the *b* barely closes the lips: *a-BREER*.
- **r-tap** — a single flick for the final *r*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

abrir (“to open”) ← Latin **aperīre**, “to open, to uncover”. The *p* softened to *b* between vowels on the way into Spanish — the slide that turned *sapere* into *saber* and *lupus* into *lobo*.

English took the root through two doors and does not notice they are one word:

- straight from Latin *apertūra*: **aperture**, the opening a lens makes.
- through French *ouvrir* and its participle *ouvert*: **overt** (“out in the open”) and **overture**, an opera’s opening.
- **aperitif**, a drink that *opens* the appetite; Spanish, **el aperitivo**.

The cousin that is not one. *April* looks like it belongs here — the opening month. That is old folk etymology and is not accepted: the better proposals point at an Etruscan *Apru*, borrowed from Aphrodite, or at an Italic word meaning “the next one”. A hook this pretty is the kind to check.

Grammar Lens: regular everywhere but the participle

In the present, *abrir* is a plain *-ir* verb, the family *escribir* belongs to: **abro, abres, abre, abrimos, abren**. Nothing breaks, nothing grows. The **past participle** is where the irregularity lives. A regular *-ir* verb would give *abrido*. Spanish says **abierto**, straight down from Latin *apertum*, keeping the *e* that broke to *ie* under stress long ago.

You will meet that participle long before the tense it belongs to, because it is a word on doors: **ABIERTO** on the sign, **está abierto** for “it is open now”. *Escribir* does the same with **escrito**. Both refuse the regular ending because both inherited a Latin participle whole.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “abro, abres, abre, abrimos, abren”
- “Abro el libro” then “Está abierto”
- “abrir” then English “aperture, overt, overture”

- “correr” then English “current, curriculum” — still there from before

Before you move on

What is the past participle of *abrir*, and what would a regular verb have given? (**Abierto**; *abrido*.) Name two English words from *aperire*. (*Aperture, overt, overture, aperitif*.) Is *April* one? (**No** — folk etymology.) Which other verb keeps an inherited Latin participle? (*Escribir* → *escrito*.) And which Latin verb is behind *correr*? (**Currere**.)

46.2 cerrar — “to close”, from the bar across the door

Abro, abres, abre — and the sign saying **ABIERTO**. Here is the sign on the other side of the day, and a verb that cracks its stem.

Sounds you’ll need

- **soft-c** — *c* before *e* is soft: a *th* across most of Spain, an *s* across Latin America.
- **rolled-rr** — the double *r* is fully trilled: *se-RRAR*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

cerrar (“to close”) ← Late Latin **serāre**, “to bolt, to fasten”, from the noun **sera**: the **bar you drop across a door**. Closing here is a physical object being put in place, not an abstraction.

Its Romance siblings kept the pressure: Italian *serrare*, French *serrer*, “to squeeze, to tighten”. English holds one of that branch, **serried**, as in ranks pressed shut against each other. Reference works generally connect *sera* to Latin **serere**, “to join in a row”, which would make **series** and **insert** distant relatives — usual, but not certain.

Why it’s said this way

Latin had a perfectly good verb for closing: **claudere**. English is full of it — **close, closet, closure, clause, cloister, include, exclude, conclude, recluse**.

Spanish let it go. For shutting a door it took *serāre* instead, and kept

claudere only in words scholars borrowed back much later: **incluir, excluir, concluir, clausura**. That inversion is worth sitting with: the bigger English family belongs to the verb Spanish gave up. A cousin web maps what each language kept, and these two kept opposite halves.

Grammar Lens: e→ie, and the sign on the door

person	form
yo	cierro
tú	cierras
él/ella/usted	cierra
nosotros	cerramos
ellos/ustedes	cierran

Dormir broke **o→ue**. *Cerrar* breaks **e→ie** — the same boot, the other vowel, the same trigger: stress on the stem. *Cerramos* is plain because there the stress moves to the ending.

Its participle, unlike *abierto*, is regular: **cerrado**. The two signs on one door are built differently — *abierto* inherited whole from Latin, *cerrado* made by rule.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “cierro, cierras, cierra, cerramos, cierran”
- “Abro el libro” then “Cierro el libro”
- “ABIERTO” then “CERRADO” — the two signs
- “aperīre, aperture” then “serāre, serried” — the two doors’ roots

Before you move on

What was a *sera*, and does *cerrar* come from *claudere*? (**The bar dropped across a door**; and **no** — Spanish kept *claudere* only in *incluir, excluir, concluir*.) Which form of *cerrar* keeps its plain *e*, and why? (*Cerramos* — the stress moves to the ending, as in *dormimos*.) Which participle is irregular, *abierto* or *cerrado*? (*Abierto*.) And what did *intendere*, behind *entender*, mean literally? (**To stretch**

toward.)

46.3 sentarse — “to seat oneself”, which is how Spanish thinks about sitting down

Two things in hand. *Cierro* — the *e* cracking to *ie*. And *me llamo*, “I call **myself**”, where the little *me* bounced the action back onto you. This verb needs both at once.

Sounds you’ll need

- **diphthong-*ie*** — the stressed *e* breaks: **me siento** = *me SYEN-to*.
- **s-clear** — a clean hissing *s*, never a *z* buzz.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

sentar ← Vulgar Latin *sedentāre*, built not on the Latin verb but on its **present participle**: *sedēns*, “sitting”, from *sedēre*, “to sit”. Spanish made a new verb out of being in a sitting state.

Sedēre is one of the great English suppliers, and hardly any descendant still looks like sitting: **sedentary**, **sediment**, **sedate**; **session** and **siege** (an army sitting down outside a city); **preside**, **reside**; **assess**, **obsess**, **possess**. By way of Greek *hedra*, “seat”, it also gives **cathedral** and **chair**.

Then the other branch. English **sit**, **seat**, **settle**, **saddle** and **nest** come down from the very same root, *sed-*, through Germanic rather than Latin. Neither borrowed from the other: they are siblings, exactly as *padre* and *father* are, each branch reshaping the sounds its own way.

Grammar Lens: seating someone, and seating yourself

Plain **sentar** means to seat somebody *else*. To sit down yourself, you send the action back with the pronoun that made *me llamo* “I call myself”:

person	form
yo	me siento
tú	te sientas
él/ella/usted	se sienta
nosotros	nos sentamos
ellos/ustedes	se sientan

Two patterns run at once, and you have both. The pronoun changes with the person — *me, te, se, nos, se* — and the stem breaks *e→ie* wherever the stress lands on it, leaving *nos sentamos* plain. The pronoun stands before a conjugated verb and clips onto an infinitive, hence the name **sentarse**.

Two verbs, one shape. *Me siento* is also the *yo*-form of *sentirse*, “to feel”: *me siento bien* is “I feel fine”. Only what follows tells them apart.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “me siento, te sientas, se sienta, nos sentamos, se sientan”
- “me llamo” then “me siento” — the same little me, twice
- “Cierro el libro y me siento” — I close the book and sit down
- “sentarse” then English “session, sedentary, preside”

Before you move on

What does *sentarse* say literally, and which Latin form was it built on? (**To seat oneself**; the participle *sedēns*.) Are English *sit* and Latin *sedēre* parent and child, or siblings? (**Siblings** — separate branches of one root, like *father* and *padre*.) Which form keeps its plain *e*, and what was a *sera*? (*Nos sentamos*; **the bar across a door**.)

46.4 levantarse — “to raise oneself”, and how Spanish says “stand”

Me siento put you in the chair, the little *me* bouncing the action back onto you. Now get out of it. The pronoun works the same way; this time the stem does not crack at all.

Sounds you’ll need

- **v-b** — Spanish *v* and *b* are one sound: *le-ban-TAR*.
- **nasal-n** — a clean *n* before the *t*, not swallowed.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

levantar ← Vulgar Latin *levantāre*, from *levāns*, the present participle of *levāre*, “to raise, to lighten” — itself from *levis*, “light, not heavy”. Notice the shape: a Latin **present participle**, made into a new verb — the identical recipe that gave *sentar* from *sedēns*. Spanish built both of its body-position verbs out of a word for the state rather than the act. *Levāre* is everywhere in English: **lever**, **elevate**, **elevator** for raising; **levity**, **levitate**, **alleviate**, **relieve** for lightening; **leaven**, what raises the bread, and **levy**, a tax *raised*. And **the Levant**, from French *levant*, “rising”: from western Europe it lay where the sun came up. English **light**, the opposite of heavy, is the Germanic cousin of *levis*, as *sit* is of *sedēre*.

Grammar Lens: raising a thing, raising yourself, standing still

Levantar on its own raises something else. **Levantarse** raises *you*:

Spanish	what it means
Levanto la mano	I raise my hand
Levanto la cabeza	I lift my head
Me levanto	I get up, I stand up

The endings are ordinary *-ar* throughout — **me levanto**, **te levantas**, **se levanta**, **nos levantamos**, **se levantan** — and nothing breaks. So the chapter has now shown its two features apart: *sentarse* is reflexive **and** a stem-changer; *levantarse* is reflexive **only**.

For standing as a *state*, Spanish uses no verb. It says **estar de pie** — “to be on foot”, *el pie* being the foot. English’s single “stand” splits in

two: *me levanto* for getting up, *estoy de pie* for being up.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “me levanto, te levantas, se levanta, nos levantamos, se levantan”
- “Levanto la mano” then “Levanto la cabeza” then “Me levanto”
- “Estoy de pie” — I am standing
- “Abro el libro, me siento, cierro el libro, me levanto”
- “levantar” then English “lever, elevate, Levant”

Before you move on

Say the chapter’s four verbs, then say how you are standing. (*Abro, cierro, me siento, me levanto; estoy de pie.*) What do *sentar* and *levantar* share in their making, and which also breaks its stem? (Both from a Latin **present participle**, *sedēns* and *levāns*; *sentarse* breaks *e→ie*.) Name the two roots on that door, and which participle is irregular. (**Aperīre** and **serāre** — *not claudere; abierto.*) Why *la* mano? (*Manus* was feminine in Latin.)

Chapter 47

Telling What Happened

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can tell a short connected story about something that happened — ordering the events with *luego*, giving a reason with *porque*, and choosing the imperfect for the scene and the preterite for the events.

Tell a four-sentence story out loud: Llovía. Me levanté, luego bebí café. No corrí, porque llovía mucho. Me senté y leí. Every word in it has been taught in this book, and the two pasts divide the work between scene and event.

47.1 luego — a word you already have, doing a job you have not seen it do

Nothing new to learn here — you have said **luego** every time you said *hasta luego*. What is new is that it can stand alone, between two events, and put them in order.

Sounds you'll need

- diphthong-ue — *ue* is one glide, not two syllables.
- g-soft-gw — between vowels the *g* softens; **luego** is *LWEH-gho*, not the hard stop English puts in *go*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

You already know where it comes from: Latin **locō**, the ablative of **locus**, “place” — “in that place”, a word about *where* that slid into a word about *when*. That is why *hasta luego* is “until later”.

What you have not been shown is how much else *locus* is holding up. It gives **local**, **locate**, **location**, **locus**, **allocate**, **dislocate**. And through French *lieu*, “place”, it gives **lieutenant** — literally the officer *holding the place* of another.

A leftover worth knowing. *Desde luego* means “of course”. It was built on an older sense of *luego*, “**immediately**”, so its literal force was nearer “from this moment on”. The bare word has since drifted to “later”; the phrase kept the old sense.

Grammar Lens: luego between two events

Out of the farewell, *luego* is not glued to a verb. It marks the join between two events and sits at the front of the second:

Me siento. Luego leo.	I sit down. Then I read.
Bebo café y luego escribo.	I drink coffee and then I write.
Me levanto y luego corro.	I get up and then I run.

Two events, in order, with one word doing the ordering — and it is a word you have been saying since chapter five.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hasta luego” then just “luego” — same word, standing alone
- “Me siento. Luego leo.”
- “Me levanto y luego corro.”
- “luego” then English “local, locate, lieutenant”

Before you move on

What job does *luego* do here that it does not do in *hasta luego*? (It **joins two events in order**, instead of sitting inside a fixed farewell.) Which English officer's title hides the same *locus*? (**Lieutenant** — the one holding another's place.) Which older sense of *luego* is frozen inside *desde luego*? (**Immediately** — not “later”.)

47.2 porque — “because”, and the reason a sequence turns into a story

With *luego* you can put two events in order. But order is not yet a story. *I sat down, then I read* tells nobody **why**. One more word closes that gap, and it is two words wearing a single coat.

Sounds you'll need

- **k-hard** — *qu* before *e* is a plain *k*; the *u* is silent. **porque** = *POR-keh*.
- **r-tap** — a single flick of the tongue, not the rolled *rr*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

porque = **por** + **que**, fused.

por descends from Latin *prō*, “for, in front of, on behalf of” — the same *prō* standing at the front of **provide**, **proceed**, **protect**, **propose**, and surviving whole in the English phrase *quid pro quo*.

que descends from Latin *quid*, “what” — and then quietly took over every job Latin had given *quod*, without taking its form.

And this is the good part. That Latin *qu-* is one branch of the Proto-Indo-European interrogative root **k^wo-*. The other branch went into Germanic, where **k^w-* softened to *hw-* — Grimm's Law turning a stop into a breath — and came out as English **who**, **what**, **when**, **where**, **why**.

So Spanish *que* and English *what* are not borrowed from one another. They are **siblings** — the same ancient question-word, walked down two different roads. *Quid pro quo* puts both Latin halves of *porque* side by side in an English sentence.

Grammar Lens: porque, por qué, el porqué

Three spellings, three jobs, and they are genuinely distinct in writing:

written	stress	job
porque	one word, no accent	because — gives the reason
por qué	two words, accent on <i>qué</i>	why — asks for the reason
el porqué	one word, accent, with <i>el</i>	the reason — a noun

¿**Por qué** te levantas? — **Why** do you get up? *Me levanto **porque** corro.* — I get up **because** I run. *No entiendo **el porqué**.* — I don't understand **the reason**.

The accent is not decoration. It marks *qué* as the questioning one, exactly as it does on other question words.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “porque” — *POR-keh*, silent *u*
- “Me siento porque leo.” — I sit down because I read.
- “Me levanto y luego corro, porque hace sol.”
- the three shapes — “porque, por qué, el porqué”

Before you move on

What two Latin words are fused inside *porque*? (*prō* and *quid*.) Are Spanish *que* and English *what* parent and child, or siblings? (**Siblings** — Latin *qu-* and Germanic *wh-* from one root, **k^wo-*.) Which of the three spellings asks a question? (**Por qué** — two words, accent on *qué*.)

47.3 llovía / llovió — the same rain, told two ways

You already have both past tenses. The imperfect — *hablaba*, *comía* — came in chapter sixteen, with its three irregulars. Noth-

ing here is a new form. What is new is **which one to reach for**, and that turns out to be the whole trick of telling a story.

Sounds you'll need

- double-l-y — *ll* is a *y* glide: **llovía** = *yo-VEE-a*.
- accent-i — the accent splits the vowels: *llo-VÍ-a*, three beats.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

The name is the lesson, and it is worth having.

Imperfecto is Latin *imperfectus*: *in-* (“not”) plus *perfectus*, “carried all the way through” — itself *per-* (“through”) plus *facere* (“to do, to make”). That *facere* is everywhere in English: **fact**, **factory**, **effect**, **manufacture**, and **perfect** itself, which still means *finished through*. So the imperfect is the **not-carried-through** tense. Not unfinished in quality — unfinished in *time*. It shows an action still running, with no edge on it. That is not a label bolted on afterwards; it is a description of the job.

Grammar Lens: the scene and the events

Take one fact — it rained — and watch the tense decide what *kind* of fact it is:

Llovía.	It was raining. (<i>no edge — the weather that day</i>)
Llovió.	It rained. (<i>edged — a thing that happened</i>)

Neither is more correct. They answer different questions. A told story needs both, in a division of labour that never varies:

The **imperfect paints the scene** — what was going on, what things were like. The **preterite drops the events into it** — what then happened.

Llovía. Luego me levanté. — It was raining (*scene*). Then I got up (*event*).

English has no separate form for this, which is the only reason it feels hard. English leans on *was -ing* and *used to* and lets context carry the rest. Spanish decided it once, in the ending.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the pair — “llovía” then “llovió”
- scene, then event — “Llovía. Luego me levanté.”
- “No corrí, porque llovía.” — the reason is a scene, the running an event
- “Comía pan porque llovía.”

Before you move on

What does *imperfectus* literally say, and which English word shares its second half? (**Not carried through; perfect** — and *fact, factory*.) In a story, which tense paints the background and which drops in the events? (**Imperfect** paints; **preterite** drops in.) Which of *llovía* and *llovió* has an edge on it? (**Llovió** — a thing that happened.)

47.4 contar — to tell a story, which is also to count it up

Three pieces are in your hands: *luego* to order events, *porque* to explain them, the imperfect to hold the background still. This lesson adds no fourth piece — it puts the three together, under the verb that names the act.

Sounds you’ll need

- diphthong-ue — the stem breaks under stress: **cuento** = *KWEN-to*, but **contamos** stays plain.
- k-hard — *c* before *o* is a hard *k*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

contar means **to count** — and **to tell a story**. One verb, both jobs, and not a pun.

It descends from Latin *computāre*, “to reckon up”: *com-* (“together”) plus *putāre*, which meant “to prune”, then “to settle an account”, then

simply “to reckon”. *Putāre* gives **amputate, dispute, deputy**; *computāre* gives **count, compute, account**.

English carries the same double sense — to **recount** an event, to give an **account** of yourself — but those are the very same word, borrowed through Old French from *computāre*. Spanish’s relatives, not an independent echo.

The independent echo is **tell**: Germanic, unrelated, and it *also* once meant “to count” — hence a bank **teller**, and *all told*. Two unrelated languages, one thought: **a story is a reckoning-up of events in order**.

Grammar Lens: the backbone of a told story

Contar breaks *o* to *ue* under stress:

person	form
yo	cuento
tú	cuentas
él/ella/usted	cuenta
nosotros	contamos
ellos/ustedes	cuentan

Here is the shape of a told story:

Llovía. Me **levanté**, luego **bebí** café. No **corrí**, **porque** **llovía** mucho. Me **senté** y **leí**.

>

It was raining. I got up, then I drank coffee. I didn’t run, because it was raining hard. I sat down and read.

Watch the two pasts divide the work. **Llovía** — imperfect, holding the scene still. **Me levanté, bebí, me senté, leí** — preterite, dropping events in. *Luego* orders them; *porque* explains one.

That is a narration, and every word in it is one this book has taught you.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “cuento, cuentas, cuenta, contamos, cuentan”
- “Cuento hasta cinco.” — I count to five. Same verb.
- the scene, then the event — “Llovía. Luego me levanté.”
- the whole thing — “Llovía. Me levanté, luego bebí café. No corrí, porque llovía mucho.”
- “contar” then English “count, account, recount, teller”

Before you move on

Contar does two jobs — which two, and what Latin verb explains both? (**Count** and **tell**; *computāre*, “to reckon up”.) Which English word carries the same double sense? (**Recount** — or *an account*; and *tell* itself, as in a bank *teller*.) In your story, which tense held the rain and which one poured the coffee? (**Imperfect** *llovía*; **preterite** *bebí*.) Name the two joining words you used. (*Luego* for order, *porque* for reason.)

Chapter 48

Bringing, Getting, Playing, Meeting

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say I bring, get, play and meet in Spanish, and name what each verb does to its yo-form or its stem: traigo grows a hard g, consigo breaks e to i and drops a silent u, juego breaks u to ue alone in the language, and conozco keeps a cluster the other forms lost.

Run the chapter's four verbs in the yo-form — traigo, consigo, juego, conozco — and say what each one does to itself, then name its Latin root and what that root meant: trahere to drag, cōnsequi to follow, iocārī to joke, cognōscere to begin to know. Choose conocer for a person and saber for a fact, and say which of the four carries a thing toward you rather than away. The chapter also reaches back for oigo, the yo-form that first grew a hard g, and for padre beside English father, the model for saying that Spanish and English words can be siblings rather than borrowings.

48.1 traer — “to bring”, and the direction baked into it

Me levanto, and now *estoy de pie*. Up, and carrying something. The verb for that has a direction inside it that English leaves open.

Sounds you'll need

- **r-tap** — one flick of the tongue: *tra-ER*, two beats.
- **g-hard** — the *g* of *traigo* is hard, as in English *go*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

traer (“to bring”) ← Latin *trahere*, “to drag, to pull”. Bringing started out as hauling.

Latin built a second stem, *tract-*, and English helped itself to both: **tractor**, **traction**, **attract**, **contract**, **subtract**, **extract**, **distract**, **retract** — and **abstract**, *abs-* + *trahere*, something “dragged away” from anything particular.

Then the worn-down half, through French: **trace**, **train** (what is dragged along behind), **trail**, **portray** ← *prōtrahere*, “to draw forth”, and **retreat** ← *retrahere*, “to draw back”.

Grammar Lens: the hard g, for the second time

person	form
yo	traigo
tú	traes
él/ella/usted	trae
nosotros	traemos
ellos/ustedes	traen

Oír grew a hard **-g-** in *oigo* and nowhere else in its present. *Traer* does the identical thing: **traigo**, and then four ordinary *-er* endings. One club, two members so far, and neither one announces itself.

Why it's said this way

English lets one verb wander: *bring me the bread*, *bring it to the café* — same word, opposite journeys. Spanish will not.

Traer moves a thing **toward you**. **Llevar** moves it **away**. *Traigo el pan* is the bread arriving here; *llevo el pan* is the bread leaving with me. You choose by where you are standing, never by what you are carrying. And **llevar** ← Latin *levāre*, “to raise” — the verb already behind *levantarse*. To carry a load was first to lift it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “traigo, traes, trae, traemos, traen”
- “Traigo el pan” then “Llevo el pan” — here, then away
- “oigo” then “traigo” — the same hard g
- “traer” then English “tractor, attract, abstract”

Before you move on

Which way does *traer* carry a thing, and which verb goes the other way? (**Toward you**; *llevar*.) What did *trahere* mean, and name two English words from it. (**To drag**; *tractor, attract, abstract, retreat*.) Which form of *traer* misbehaves, and which verb showed you that same misbehaviour first? (**Traigo**; *oigo*.) And say you are standing. (*Estoy de pie*.)

48.2 conseguir — “to get”, by following a thing until you have it

Traigo carries a thing that is already yours. *Coger* grabs what is in front of you. This verb is for the getting that took some work.

Sounds you’ll need

- **g-hard** — the *gu* in *conseguir* is one hard *g*; the *u* is silent.
- **s-clear** — a clean hissing *s*: *con-se-GEER*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

conseguir (“to get, to obtain, to manage to”) ← Latin **cōnsequī**: *com-* (“along with”) + **sequī**, “to follow”. You got a thing by following it until it was yours.

Sequī is one of Latin’s great English suppliers: **sequence, sequel, consequence, subsequent, consecutive; second**, from *secundus*, “the one following”; **execute** and **prosecute**; **obsequious**, following some-

one about; and through French, **pursue**, **ensue** and **suit**.

Spanish also keeps the formal partner **obtener** ← *obtinēre*, “to hold onto” — English **obtain**. It behaves exactly like *tener*, so its *yo*-form is *obtengo*. *Conseguir* is the everyday one.

Grammar Lens: the third crack, and a silent u that leaves

person	form
yo	consigo
tú	consigues
él/ella/usted	consigue
nosotros	conseguimos
ellos/ustedes	consiguen

You have met *dormir* breaking **o→ue** and *pido* quietly breaking **e→i**. Here is that third pattern in full: stress on the stem turns *e* into *i*, and *conseguimos* stays plain because the stress moved to the ending.

Now the spelling. Spanish writes *gu* only to keep a *g* hard in front of *e* and *i*. Once the *e* becomes *i*, there is nothing in front to guard against, so the *u* has no job and goes: **consigo**, not *consiguo*. Two changes, one form, and only one of them is a sound.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “consigo, consigues, consigue, conseguimos, consiguen”
- “Traigo el café” then “Consigo el café” — carried, then obtained
- “sequi, sequence, second” then “conseguir”

Before you move on

What did *sequi* mean, and name two English words from it. (**To follow**; *sequence*, *second*, *consequence*, *pursue*.) Why is it *consigo* and not *consiguo*? (The *u* only guards a hard *g* before *e* and *i*.) Name the three stem cracks you now have, with a verb for each. (*Cerrar* **e→ie**, *dormir* **o→ue**, *conseguir* **e→i**.) And which Latin verb is behind *traer*? (**Trahere**.)

48.3 jugar — “to play”, and the only verb of its kind

Consigo cracked its *e* to *i*. Here is a verb that cracks a vowel no other verb in Spanish cracks — and it started life as a joke.

Sounds you’ll need

- j-jota — the *j* is scraped at the back of the throat: *khoo-GAR*.
- diphthong-ue — *juego* is three beats, *KHWE-go*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

jugar (“to play”) ← Latin *iocārī*, “to joke, to jest”, built on the noun *iocus*, “a joke”. Playing and joking were one word, and Spanish kept the joking one for both.

English holds *iocus* in several shapes: **joke**; through French **jocular**; **juggler**, from *ioculātor*, an entertainer; and **jeopardy**, from Old French *jeu parti*, “an evenly divided game” — a position so balanced that either side might lose. The Spanish family stays close: **el juego**, a game; **el juguete**, a toy.

Why it’s said this way

Latin’s ordinary word for playing was *lūdere*, and Spanish dropped it exactly as it dropped *claudere* for shutting doors. English kept the whole family instead: **illusion**, **allude**, **elude**, **delude**, **collude**, **prelude**, **interlude**, **ludicrous**.

Claudere and *lūdere* tell one story: the large English family belongs to the Latin verb Spanish walked away from.

Grammar Lens: the fourth crack, with one member

person	form
yo	juego
tú	juegas
él/ella/usted	juega
nosotros	jugamos
ellos/ustedes	juegan

Dormir breaks **o→ue**. *Jugar* breaks **u→ue**, and it is the **only verb in**

Spanish that does: the *o* of *iocārī* had already slid irregularly to *u*, so the crack landed on a vowel no other verb offers. *Jugamos* stays plain, because the stress moves to the ending.

One more habit: Spanish plays **at** a thing rather than simply playing it. *El fútbol* is football, and you say *juego al fútbol*, with *a + el* fused into *al*. With a companion rather than a game it is *con*: *juego con el perro*, I play with the dog.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “juego, juegas, juega, jugamos, juegan”
- “Juego con el perro”
- “duermo” then “juego” — *o* to *ue*, then *u* to *ue*
- “iocus, joke, jocular, juggler”

Before you move on

What did *iocārī* mean, and which English words carry it? (**To joke**; *joke, jocular, juggler, jeopardy*.) What is unusual about *juego* among Spanish verbs? (**U→ue**, and no other verb does it.) Which two Latin verbs did Spanish drop while English kept their families? (*Claudere* and *ludere*.) And which vowel does *conseguir* break? (**E to i**.)

48.4 conocer — “to meet”, because knowing has a first moment

Juego — the one *u→ue* in the language. Now the chapter’s last verb, and its oddity is not in the vowel but in what the word means.

Sounds you’ll need

- **soft-c** — *conoces* has a soft second *c*: a *th* in Spain, an *s* elsewhere.
- **k-hard** — but *conozco* is *ko-NOTH-ko*, soft then hard, back to

back.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

conocer ← Latin **cognōscere**, *com-* + *(g)nōscere*. Its *-sc-* is Latin’s “**begin to**” marker, so *nōscere* was never “to know” — it was “**to come to know**”. Latin said *nōvī*, “I have come to know”, for actually knowing a thing.

Spanish built its verb from the *beginning* half. That is the whole lesson: *conocer a alguien* is **to meet** someone, and Spanish puts a small **a** before a person who is the object — *conozco a María*.

The root fills English: **cognition**, **recognize**, **incognito**, and through French **notice**, **notion**, **notorious** and **noble**, “the knowable one”. English **know** and **ken** are its Germanic siblings — the same standing that *padre* has beside English *father*, neither one borrowed from the other.

Grammar Lens: conocer and saber

what you know	verb
a person, a city, a book	conocer
a fact, or how to do something	saber

English says *know* for both. Spanish will not: **conocer** is being **acquainted** — you have met the thing. **Saber** is having the information. *Conozco Madrid* means I have been there; *sé dónde está* means I have the fact.

The *yo*-form keeps a hard cluster the rest lost: **conozco**, **conoces**, **conoce**, **conocemos**, **conocen**. Every *-cer* verb after a vowel does the same, and it is a third kind of odd *yo*-form beside *traigo* and *oigo*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “conozco, conoces, conoce, conocemos, conocen”
- “Conozco a María” then “Conozco Madrid”
- “traigo, consigo, juego, conozco” — the chapter’s four *yo*-forms
- “padre, father” then “conocer, know” — siblings, not borrowings

Before you move on

Say the chapter's four verbs in the *yo*, then say what each one does to itself. (*Traigo* grows a hard *g*; *consigo* breaks *e*→*i* and loses a silent *u*; *juego* breaks *u*→*ue*, alone in the language; *conozco* keeps a hard cluster.) Name their four Latin roots and what each meant. (**Trahere** to drag, **cōnsequī** to follow, **iocārī** to joke, **cognōscere** to begin to know.) Which verb do you use for a person, and which for a fact? (*Conocer*; *saber*.) And which of the four moves a thing toward you? (*Traer* — *llevar* goes away.)

Chapter 49

Waiting, Answering, Buying

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say I wait, answer and buy in Spanish — three verbs whose endings never surprise me — and I know that *esperar* alone carries wait, hope and expect, so context does the work English hands to three separate verbs.

Run *espero*, *contesto* and *compro* — three verbs that break nothing, whose whole difficulty is meaning — and give each root and its sense: *spērāre* to hope, *contestārī* to call witnesses, *comparāre* to procure. Refuse the lookalike: English *compare* descends from a different Latin *comparāre* built on *compār*, so it is not a relative. Then buy — *compro el pan*, *el vino y un café*, *por favor* — and reach back for what *pānis* gave *compañero*, which English words *vīnum* reached, why *café* is masculine, and what *por favor* says word for word.

49.1 *esperar* — one verb for waiting, hoping and expecting

Four verbs that each did something odd to themselves — *juego* the strangest of them. Here is one that does nothing odd at all, and is still the hardest word in these two chapters.

Sounds you'll need

- **st-no-e** — the *e-* is a run-up: *es-pe-RAR*, never *spe-*.
- **r-tap** — one flick for the *r* in the middle.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

esperar ← Latin **spērāre**, “to hope”, from **spēs**, “hope”. That front *e-* is the same run-up that turned *scribere* into *escribir* and *studēre* into *estudiar*: Spanish will not start a word with *s* plus a consonant.

English took the root by its negative: **despair** ← **dēspērāre**, *dē-* + *spērāre* — literally **to un-hope** — and with it **desperate**, and **desperado**, which English shaped from Spanish *desesperado*. **Prosper** is traditionally read as *prō* + *spēs*, “according to one’s hope”, though that reading is the traditional one rather than a settled one.

Spanish keeps the hope in plain sight: **la esperanza**. So does **Esperanto** — its inventor published as *Doktoro Esperanto*, “Doctor One-Who-Hopes”.

Grammar Lens: three English verbs, one Spanish word

Spanish	what it means
Espero a María	I am waiting for María
Espero el pan	I am expecting the bread
Espero que sí	I hope so

One verb, three English words, and nothing in the Spanish tells them apart. Context does all of it, and a learner has to stop translating and start reading the situation. *Hope* and *expect* were never far from waiting: to wait for a thing is to think it is coming.

Note the small **a** before a person, the same one that stands in *conozco a María*. And after three chapters of cracking stems, *esperar* is perfectly regular: **espero, esperas, espera, esperamos, esperan**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “espero, esperas, espera, esperamos, esperan”
- “Espero a María” then “Espero el pan” then “Espero que sí”
- “spērāre, esperanza” then English “despair, desperate”

Before you move on

Give the three English verbs *esperar* covers. (**Wait, hope, expect.**) What does *dēspērāre* take apart into? (*Dē-* + *spērāre*, **to un-hope.**) Name two other Spanish verbs whose *e-* is a run-up, with their Latin roots. (*Escribir* ← *scrībere*, *estudiar* ← *studēre*.) Would you use *conocer* or *saber* for a city? (*Conocer*.) And what did the *-sc-* inside *cognōscere* mark? (**Beginning** — to *come* to know.)

49.2 contestar — “to answer”, from a Roman courtroom

Pregunto pushes the pole down to sound the water. *Espero* waits. Now the other half of a conversation — and a word that began as an oath.

Sounds you’ll need

- **s-clear** — a clean *s* in the middle: *con-tes-TAR*.
- **stress-final** — the beat lands on the last syllable, with no written accent.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

contestar (“to answer”) ← Latin **contestārī**, “to call witnesses”: *com-* + *testārī*, from **testis**, “a witness”. In Roman law, *contestārī litem* was the formal opening of a lawsuit — both sides calling their witnesses so the argument could begin.

From that one act the two languages walked in opposite directions. **English kept the fight**: to *contest* a thing is to dispute it. **Spanish kept the reply** — first “say back what the other side said”, then simply *answer*.

The *testis* family is shared: **testify, testimony, testament, attest, protest, detest**.

Grammar Lens: contestar and responder

Spanish has a second answering verb, and it is built on a different promise.

responder ← Latin **respondēre**, *re-* + **spondēre**, “to pledge

solemnly”. Answering is pledging *back*. English holds that whole branch: **respond, response, responsible, sponsor, and spouse**, from *spōn-sus*, “one who has been pledged”.

verb	where it lives
contestar	the everyday one: a question, the phone, a letter
responder	weightier — responding <i>to</i> something

Both are regular, one *-ar* and one *-er*: **contesto, contestas, contesta, contestamos, contestan; respondo, respondes, responde**. The noun is the odd part: the answer is **la respuesta**, borrowed from *responder*, never from *contestar*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “contesto, contestas, contesta, contestamos, contestan”
- “Te pregunto la hora y me contestas”
- “testis, testify, contest” then “contestar”

Before you move on

What did *contestārī* mean literally, and what did English make of it? (**To call witnesses; contest.**) What does *respondēre* take apart into? (*Re-* + *spondēre*, **to pledge back.**) Which verb asks for information and which asks for a thing? (*Preguntar; pedir.*) And name the three English verbs inside *esperar*. (**Wait, hope, expect.**)

49.3 comprar — “to buy”, and a cousin that is not one

You can ask, answer and wait. Now pay for the bread, with a verb whose obvious English relative turns out to be a stranger.

Sounds you'll need

- **pr-cluster** — *-pr-* is one beat: *kom-PRAR*, never *kom-pe-rar*.
- **vowel-o** — a short pure *o*, with no glide toward *ow*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

comprar (“to buy”) ← Latin **comparāre**: *com-* + **parāre**, “to make ready, to furnish, to procure”. Latin already used it for buying — you procured a thing — and the middle syllable wore away, *comparāre* to *comprar*.

Parāre stocked English well: **prepare**, **repair**, **apparatus**, **apparel**, **separate**, **parade**, and **emperor**, from *imperāre*, “to give orders”. Spanish keeps *preparar*, and *parar*, “to stop”.

That *com-* is the same one already inside *compañero* — “the one you share bread with” — and inside *conseguir*, *conocer* and *contestar*.

Why it's said this way

English **compare** looks like the obvious relative. It is not one.

Latin had **two** verbs spelled *comparāre*. One is *com-* + *parāre*, “procure”, and Spanish *comprar* comes from it. The other is built on **com-pār**, “equal, matched”, and means “to set side by side” — that is the one English *compare* comes from. Two different words that fell together in spelling.

Comprender is a stranger too: it is *comprehendere*, “to seize together”. Same prefix, unrelated second halves. A resemblance is a question, never an answer.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “compro, compras, compra, compramos, compran”
- “Compro el pan y el vino”
- “Un café, por favor”
- “parāre, prepare, repair” then “comprar”

Before you move on

Run the chapter: *espero*, *contesto*, *compro* — three verbs that break nothing, whose difficulty is meaning. Give each root and what it meant. (**Spērāre** to hope, **contestārī** to call witnesses, **comparāre** to procure.) Is English *compare* a relative of *comprar*? (**No** — a different Latin *comparāre*, built on *compār*, “equal”.) Now buy: *compro el pan*, *el vino y un café*, *por favor* — then say what *pānis* gave *compañero*, which English words *vīnum* reached, why *café* is masculine, and what *por favor* is word for word. (**One who shares bread**; *wine*, *vine*, *vinegar*; *café* arrived as a masculine loan out of Arabic *qahwa*; “for a favour”.) And which verb gets a thing by following it? (*Conseguir*.)

Chapter 50

Saying Why

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can give a reason for what I think and what I plan — stating an opinion with *creo que*, running forward to its consequence with *así que*, and naming an obligation with *debo*.

Answer ¿Por qué no corres? in four moves — Creo que llueve. No corro porque llueve, así que leo. Debo estudiar. Opinion, cause, consequence, obligation, each with its own word, and every word in it taught by this book.

50.1 creer — to put your heart somewhere

You have **pensar** — to think, and underneath it *pēnsāre*, “to weigh”. Spanish has a second verb for the inside of your head, and it does a different job. Where *pensar* weighs, this one commits.

Sounds you’ll need

- **hiatus-ee** — the two *e*’s do not merge: **creer** = *kreh-EHR*, two beats.
- **r-tap** — a single flick, not the rolled *rr*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

creer = “to believe”, and in everyday use “to think” in the sense of *hold an opinion*.

It comes from Latin *crēdere*, “to entrust, to believe” — and *crēdere* is a compound so old that Latin had already forgotten it was one. It is PIE **kred-dʰeh₁-*: “to put **kred-*”.

What is that first half? Traditionally, the **heart** word — the root of Latin *cor*, *cordis* and of English **heart**. Be honest that the step is **disputed**: that root normally appears as **kēr*, never **kred-*. The compound is not in doubt; only what it was built on.

Taking the traditional reading:

from *crēdere*

from *cor*, *cordis*

credit, creed, credo

cordial, courage

credential, incredible

record, accord, discord

To **record** is to bring something back to the *cor* — for a Roman the seat of **memory**, not of feeling. To have **courage** is to have heart.

Grammar Lens: creer que

Creer almost always drags a **que** behind it, and then a whole clause:

Creo que llueve.

I think it’s raining.

Creo que hace frío.

I think it’s cold.

No creo que llueva.

I don’t think it’s raining.

Look hard at that third row. *Creo que llueve* — but *no creo que llueva*. Negating *creer* flips the clause into the **subjunctive** from chapter eighteen: stop vouching for something and Spanish stops using the tense that states facts.

Pienso is the weighing; *creo* is where it landed. Treat that as a way to feel the difference, not a rule — both take *que* and a clause, and a speaker may use either. But *creo que* is the ordinary opening for an opinion.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “creer” — *kreh-EHR*, two beats, not one
- “Creo que llueve.”
- the pair — “pienso” (I weigh) then “creo” (I hold)

- “creer” then English “credit, creed, cordial, record”

Before you move on

What shape is *crēdere*, under the surface? (**A compound** — **kred-* + *d^heh₁-*, “to put **kred-*.”) What is the traditional reading of that first half, and why hedge it? (**Heart** — but the heart root is **kēr*, never **kred-*, so the step is disputed.) *Pensar* weighs; what does *creer* do? (It **lands** — it holds the opinion the weighing produced.)

50.2 así que — “so”, and a word you have been saying since yes

Porque runs from a claim back to its reason. This runs the other way — from the reason forward to what follows. Same two facts, opposite arrow, and you need both to explain anything.

Sounds you’ll need

- **s-clear** — a clean hiss in **así**, never a *z* buzz.
- **k-hard** — *qu* is a plain *k*; the *u* is silent.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

así = “so, thus, in that way”. **así que** = “so, and therefore”.

Así is Latin *sīc*, “thus” — with an *a-* that Spanish added later, the same one it put on *apenas* and *afuera*. And you have met *sīc* before: it is the whole of Spanish **sí**, “yes”. Latin *sīc* meant “thus, in this way”, and saying *thus* in answer to a question is how a language gets a word for yes.

So *sí* and *así* are the same Latin adverb, one bare and one with the *a-* attached. English borrowed it raw and never translated it: **sic**, the mark an editor puts after a quoted mistake — “thus it stood”.

Grammar Lens: the two arrows

The pair is worth drilling as a pair, because they carry the same two facts in opposite orders:

No corro porque llueve.	I'm not running because it's raining.
Llueve, así que no corro.	It's raining, so I'm not running.
<i>Porque</i> points backwards to the cause. <i>Así que</i> points forwards to the consequence. Which you reach for depends only on which fact you want to say first — and that is a choice about emphasis, not about grammar.	
Hace frío, así que bebo café.	It's cold, so I drink coffee.
Creo que llueve, así que leo.	I think it's raining, so I read.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “sí” then “así” — the same Latin word, one with an *a-* on the front
- “Llueve, así que no corro.”
- the same two facts the other way — “No corro porque llueve.”
- “Creo que hace frío, así que bebo café.”

Before you move on

Which Latin adverb is hiding in both *sí* and *así*? (*Sīc*, “thus”.) Which way does *porque* point, and which way *así que*? (*Porque* **backwards** to the cause; *así que* **forwards** to the consequence.) What does an editor's *sic* mean? (**Thus it stood** — the same word, borrowed whole.)

50.3 deber — to owe, and therefore to ought

You can now say what you think and what follows from it. This verb adds the third move in any explanation: what somebody **ought** to do about it. It gets there from an unexpected direction — money.

Sounds you'll need

- **b-soft** — between vowels the *b* softens: **deber** = *deh-BEHR*.
- **r-tap** — one flick at the end, not a roll.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

deber does two jobs: “to owe”, and “ought to, should”.

Latin *dēbēre* explains both, because it is a compound: *dē-* (“from”) plus *habēre* (“to have”). To *dēbēre* something is **to have it from someone** — which is exactly what owing is. You are holding what is theirs.

English helped itself to this verb four times over — three of them from the participle *dēbitum* rather than the verb — and the spellings record each route:

English	how it came
debt	through French, then re-spelled to show the Latin <i>b</i>
debit	straight from Latin bookkeeping
due	through French <i>deü</i> , the <i>b</i> worn away
duty	built on <i>due</i>

One more came the long way round, and not by borrowing. French turned *dēbēre* into *devoir*, “duty”. English **translated** the phrase *mettre en devoir* — to put oneself under an obligation — half-way, as *put in dever*, and the last two words later fused into **endeavour**.

Grammar Lens: debo + infinitive

Deber is regular, and for “ought to” it takes a bare infinitive straight after it — no *que*, no preposition:

person	form
yo	debo
tú	debes
él/ella/usted	debe
nosotros	debemos
ellos/ustedes	deben

Debo estudiar. — I ought to study. **Llueve, así que debo leer.** — It’s raining, so I ought to read.

The obligation is softer than a command and firmer than a wish, which is the register an explanation usually wants.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “debo, debes, debe, debemos, deben”
- “Debo trabajar.”
- “Hace frío, así que debo beber café.”
- “Creo que llueve, así que debo leer.”
- “deber” then English “debt, debit, due, duty”

Before you move on

What two Latin pieces build *dēbēre*, and what do they say together? (*Dē-* + *habēre* — “to have **from** someone”, which is owing.) Name two of the four English words it became. (Any of **debt**, **debit**, **due**, **duty**.) What follows *debo* — a *que*, or a bare infinitive? (**A bare infinitive**: *debo estudiar*.)

50.4 explicar — to unfold

Three pieces are in your hands: *creo que* to state an opinion, *así que* to run forward to what follows, *debo* to say what ought to happen. This lesson puts all three in a row, under the verb that names the act.

Sounds you’ll need

- k-hard — *c* before *a* is a hard *k*: **explicar** = *eks-plee-KAR*.
- l-clear — a clean *l* in the *pl*, no vowel slipped in between.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

explicar = Latin *explicāre*: *ex-* (“out”) + *plicāre* (“to fold”). **To explain is to unfold** — something was folded shut, and you open it.

Plicāre is one of the great suppliers of English. Some came from Latin directly, some through French, and the sound changed on the way:

straight from Latin	through French
explicate	explicit, application
complicated (<i>com-</i> + fold)	employ, deploy
duplicate	display — a doublet of <i>deploy</i>

And **simple** is *sim-plex* — “**one**-fold”. Something simple has been folded only once. Something **complicated** has been folded *together*, over and over, which is why it needs unfolding. The metaphor is consistent all the way down, and Spanish keeps it in the plainest verb of the set.

Grammar Lens: the shape of an explanation

Explicar is regular — it takes the plain *-ar* endings of *hablar*, with no stem change at all: **explico, explicas, explica, explicamos, explican**. (*Contar*, back in chapter 38, breaks its *o* to *ue*; this one does not, and there is nothing to remember.)

Here is a whole explanation, with every piece something this book has taught:

— ¿Por qué no corres? — **Creo que** llueve. No corro **porque** llueve, **así que** leo. **Debo** estudiar.

>

— *Why aren't you running?* — *I think it's raining. I'm not running because it's raining, so I read. I ought to study.*

Four moves, four words: an **opinion** (*creo que*), a **cause** (*porque*), a **consequence** (*así que*), an **obligation** (*debo*). That is what an explanation is made of, and you can now build one in either direction — cause first or claim first — because *porque* and *así que* let you choose.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “explico, explicas, explica, explicamos, explican”
- “Explico bien.” — I explain well.

- the four moves — “Creo que llueve, porque hace frío, así que debo leer.”
- “explicar” then English “explicit, complicated, simple, display”

Before you move on

What does *explicāre* literally say? (**To fold out** — *ex-* + *plicāre*.) What is *simple*, folded? (**Once** — *sim-plex*; *complicated* is folded together, again and again.) Name the four moves of an explanation and the word for each. (Opinion ***creo que***, cause ***porque***, consequence ***así que***, obligation ***debo***.)

Pronunciation — a reference, not a chapter

Not to be read before the lessons — every lesson tells you the one or two sounds its own word needs, right where you need them. This page sits at the back so the whole system is *somewhere* you can find it: look things up as curiosity strikes.

The five pure vowels

Spanish has exactly five vowel sounds, one per letter, every time — unlike English, which reuses each vowel letter for several sounds.

- **a** — as in *father*. Always.
- **e** — as in *bed*. Always.
- **i** — as the *ee* in *see* (not English *i*). The most common vowel slip for English speakers.
- **o** — as in *note*, short and clean, no *w*-glide.
- **u** — as the *oo* in *food*. Always.

Consonants that differ from English

- **h** — always silent. *hola* is *OH-la*.
- **qu** — a hard *k*, with a **silent u**: *quiero* is *KYEH-ro*.
- **ll** — like English *y*: *llamo* is *YA-mo*.
- **ñ** — the *ny* of *canyon*: *español*.

- **rr** — a rolled *r*; single *r* between vowels is a light tap (*pero* vs. *perro*).
- **j** — a throat-*h*, like Scottish *loch*: *jueves*.
- **c** before *e/i* — soft (*s* in Latin America, *th* in much of Spain): *gracias*.
- **d** between vowels — softens toward *th* in *this*.
- **v** and **b** — essentially identical, a soft *b*.

Stress and written accents

- Ends in a vowel, *n*, or *s* → stress the second-to-last syllable (*ca-SA*).
- Ends in another consonant → stress the last syllable (*ha-BLAR*).
- A written accent (´) overrides both and marks the stress exactly (*ha-BLÓ*, *DÍ-as*); it also separates look-alike words (*qué/que*, *tú/tu*).
- Questions and exclamations open with an inverted mark (¿, ¡) so the intonation is signalled up front.

Glossary

This glossary collects every word and phrase taught in the book. Pronunciation appears when it differs from the written form; chapter numbers show where each entry is introduced.

abrir

to open — a regular -ir verb with one irregular part, the participle abierto
Introduced in Chapter 46.

adiós

goodbye
Introduced in Chapter 11.

amarillo

yellow — from “a little bitter,” not from any Latin word for yellow at all
Introduced in Chapter 42.

así que

thus, in that way — and with que after it, “so”; built on the same *sīc* that gave you *sí*
Introduced in Chapter 50.

ayudar

to help — literally the same word as English “aid”, arriving by a different road
Introduced in Chapter 44.

azul

blue — an Arabic loan that became the plain everyday word, where French’s cousin stayed poetic
Introduced in Chapter 31.

beber

to drink (another -er verb — cementing the pattern)
Introduced in Chapter 17.

bien

well / good / fine
Introduced in Chapter 1.

buenas noches

good evening / good night
Introduced in Chapter 2.

buenas tardes

good afternoon

Introduced in Chapter 2.

buenos días

good morning (literally “good days”)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

café

coffee / a café — one useful noun before the polite request that follows

Introduced in Chapter 13.

caminar

to walk — built on a Celtic word for a path, beside andar, whose own past is unsettled

Introduced in Chapter 45.

cerrar

to close — from the bar dropped across a door, not from the Latin verb English inherited

Introduced in Chapter 46.

comer

to eat (your first -er verb)

Introduced in Chapter 17.

comí

the regular singular -er preterite — comí, comiste, comió

Introduced in Chapter 25.

cómo

how — a whole Latin phrase, quo modo, worn smooth into one word

Introduced in Chapter 5.

comprar

to buy — from Latin’s “get ready, procure”, and not from the verb behind English compare

Introduced in Chapter 49.

conocer

to meet, to be acquainted with — a verb built out of the moment knowing begins

Introduced in Chapter 48.

conseguir

to get, to obtain — getting as following a thing until you have it

Introduced in Chapter 48.

contar

to tell a story — and also to count, because in Spanish, as once in English, a story is something you reckon up

Introduced in Chapter 47.

contestar

to answer — a Roman courtroom word that English turned into a fight and Spanish turned into a reply

Introduced in Chapter 49.

correr

to run — a plain -er verb sitting on one of the largest roots English ever borrowed
Introduced in Chapter 45.

creer

to believe, to think — putting your heart somewhere, where pensar weighs it up
Introduced in Chapter 50.

de nada

you're welcome (literally "of nothing")
Introduced in Chapter 6.

deber

should, ought to — and to owe, because the word is literally "to have something from someone"
Introduced in Chapter 50.

decir

to say or tell — with the singular present forms digo, dices, and dice
Introduced in Chapter 22.

día

day (el día — masculine)
Introduced in Chapter 1.

dieciséis — diecinueve

16-19 — not words to memorise but a formula, diez y X, with the seam still visible
Introduced in Chapter 40.

dónde

where?
Introduced in Chapter 17.

dormir

to sleep — and the other half of the boot, where a stressed o breaks to ue
Introduced in Chapter 45.

e → ie and o → ue

comparing the two vowel changes inside the learned singular forms
Introduced in Chapter 21.

el / la

the (masculine / feminine)
Introduced in Chapter 1.

el agua

water — a word that barely changed from Latin, and takes el without ever stopping being feminine
Introduced in Chapter 35.

el hermano, la hermana

brother and sister — NOT from frater/soror, but from an adjective meaning "of the same seed"
Introduced in Chapter 32.

el padre, la madre

father and mother — among the oldest reconstructible words in the whole family
Introduced in Chapter 32.

el pan

bread — and the *compañero* who shares it with you
Introduced in Chapter 35.

el tiempo

the one noun that covers both “time” and “weather” — because Latin *tempus* already did
Introduced in Chapter 39.

el vino

wine — one Latin root that reached English by three separate roads, plus one English built at home
Introduced in Chapter 35.

entender

to understand — literally “to stretch toward”; the second *e*→*ie* stem-changer
Introduced in Chapter 43.

escribir

to write — from a Latin verb meaning “to scratch”, and the reason Spanish puts an *e*- in front
Introduced in Chapter 43.

español

“Spanish” — the language, the people, and the Roman name for the peninsula underneath it
Introduced in Chapter 16.

esperar

to wait — and to hope, and to expect, all in one verb
Introduced in Chapter 49.

está en...

is in or at... — locate someone with *estar* and the already-known *en*
Introduced in Chapter 19.

estar

to be — but the *standing* kind, straight from Latin *stāre*
Introduced in Chapter 7.

estás / está

what *estar* is for — a current state or location — and the only two forms you need this chapter
Introduced in Chapter 7.

estudiar

to study (a third -ar verb — the pattern is automatic now)
Introduced in Chapter 16.

explicar

to explain — literally to unfold, and the verb that names what this whole chapter has been building
Introduced in Chapter 50.

fui

the shared singular preterite of *ser* and *ir* — *fui*, *fuiste*, *fue*
Introduced in Chapter 24.

gato

cat — a word that travelled out of Africa with the animal, pushing Latin’s own *felēs* aside
Introduced in Chapter 41.

gracias

thank you
Introduced in Chapter 6.

gustar

to please — the verb English calls “to like”, built the other way round
Introduced in Chapter 44.

hablar

to speak / to talk — at root, “to tell stories”
Introduced in Chapter 15.

Hablo español

your first sentence built from parts — and the rule that languages take no article
Introduced in Chapter 16.

hablo, hablas, habla

the -ar present-tense template, and why Spanish leaves the subject pronoun out
Introduced in Chapter 15.

hace calor, hace frío, hace sol

the three weather words Spanish reports with *hacer* — “it makes heat,” “it makes cold,” “it makes sun”
Introduced in Chapter 39.

hacer

to do or make — with the singular present forms *hago*, *haces*, and *hace*
Introduced in Chapter 22.

hasta

until / up to
Introduced in Chapter 11.

hasta luego

see you later (literally “until later”)
Introduced in Chapter 12.

hasta mañana

see you tomorrow (literally “until tomorrow”)
Introduced in Chapter 12.

hasta pronto

see you soon (literally “until soon”)

Introduced in Chapter 12.

hola

hello / hi

Introduced in Chapter 1.

ir

to go — with the three singular present forms voy, vas, and va

Introduced in Chapter 20.

jugar

to play — from Latin’s word for joking, and the only verb in the language that breaks u to ue

Introduced in Chapter 48.

la cabeza

the head — Spanish KEPT Latin’s real word, unlike French, which replaced it with slang for “pot”

Introduced in Chapter 33.

la hora

hour / o’clock — telling the time, and a word Spanish inherited almost unchanged from Latin

Introduced in Chapter 38.

la mano

the hand — feminine despite ending in -o, Spanish’s most famous gender exception

Introduced in Chapter 33.

la noche

night / evening (la noche — feminine)

Introduced in Chapter 2.

la primavera, el verano, el otoño, el invierno

the four seasons — three straightforward, and one whose MEANING quietly shifted from “spring” to “summer”

Introduced in Chapter 34.

la tarde

afternoon (la tarde — feminine; also: late)

Introduced in Chapter 2.

leer

to read — from a Latin verb meaning “to gather, to pick out”

Introduced in Chapter 43.

levantarse

to get up, to stand up — “to raise oneself”, built from a participle exactly as sentarse was

Introduced in Chapter 46.

llamo

I call (from llamar, to call)

Introduced in Chapter 3.

llovía / llovió

the same rain in two tenses — how a story uses the imperfect for the scene and the preterite for the events

Introduced in Chapter 47.

llueve

rain refuses the hacer pattern and brings its own verb — and its ll- is the sound change you already met in llamar

Introduced in Chapter 39.

lo siento

I'm sorry — literally “I feel it,” a naming of the feeling rather than a claim about yourself

Introduced in Chapter 29.

los meses

the months — Roman gods and emperors, marching almost unchanged from Latin

Introduced in Chapter 36.

luego

then, next — a word you already own from hasta luego, now doing a second job: joining two events in order

Introduced in Chapter 47.

lunes, martes, miércoles, jueves, viernes

the weekdays (Monday–Friday) — worn-down planet-god names

Introduced in Chapter 30.

más despacio

“more slowly” — the request that makes the last sentence solvable

Introduced in Chapter 14.

me

me / myself

Introduced in Chapter 3.

me llamo

my name is (literally “I call myself”)

Introduced in Chapter 3.

mediodía, medianoche

noon and midnight — both halves still fully alive as ordinary Spanish words, unlike French's worn-down midi/minuit

Introduced in Chapter 37.

mi, tu, su

my, your informal, and your formal or his or her — before a singular noun

Introduced in Chapter 20.

mucho

much / a lot

Introduced in Chapter 5.

mucho gusto

pleased to meet you (literally “much pleasure”)

Introduced in Chapter 5.

negro, blanco

black and white — the two words, and the straight-line Latin history of the first one

Introduced in Chapter 31.

no

no / not

Introduced in Chapter 6.

no entiendo

“I don’t understand” — the most useful sentence a beginner owns

Introduced in Chapter 14.

nuestro, nuestra

our — matching a known masculine or feminine singular noun

Introduced in Chapter 21.

oír

to hear — the half of listening you do not choose, and a verb that sprouts a y

Introduced in Chapter 45.

once — quince

11-15 — five single opaque words, each one a Latin compound worn down until the seam disappeared

Introduced in Chapter 40.

pensar

to think — at root “to weigh”, and a stem-changer that breaks e→ie

Introduced in Chapter 43.

perdón

the other sorry — “give completely” — for fault and for getting past people, where lo siento is for regret

Introduced in Chapter 29.

perro

dog — a genuinely unsolved etymology, and the Latin word it pushed out

Introduced in Chapter 41.

poder

to be able or can — with the singular present forms puedo, puedes, and puede

Introduced in Chapter 21.

poner

to put or place — with the singular present forms pongo, pones, and pone

Introduced in Chapter 23.

por favor

please (literally “for [a] favour”)

Introduced in Chapter 13.

porque

because — two tiny words fused into one, and the reason a sequence becomes a story

Introduced in Chapter 47.

preguntar

to ask (a question) — and the reason English’s one “ask” becomes two Spanish verbs

Introduced in Chapter 44.

qué

what? (a new question word for verbs you already know)

Introduced in Chapter 17.

querer

to want — with the singular present forms quiero, quieres, and quiere

Introduced in Chapter 21.

regular

so-so / not great (also “más o menos”)

Introduced in Chapter 8.

rojo

red — a cousin of French rouge and English red, but by a different branch of the same very old family

Introduced in Chapter 31.

sábado, domingo

the weekend (Saturday, Sunday) — where religion overwrote astronomy

Introduced in Chapter 30.

salir

to leave or go out — with the singular present forms salgo, sales, and sale

Introduced in Chapter 23.

se llama

he/she calls himself; you (formal) call yourself

Introduced in Chapter 5.

seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez

the numbers 6–10 and the old counting hidden in month names

Introduced in Chapter 18.

sentarse

to sit down — literally “to seat oneself”, the reflexive that lands the action back on you

Introduced in Chapter 46.

ser

to be — the verb used here to identify someone or say what someone is

Introduced in Chapter 19.

ser vs estar

identify with *ser*; describe a current state or location with *estar*
Introduced in Chapter 19.

sí

yes
Introduced in Chapter 6.

soy de...

I am from... — use *ser* with *de* to state origin
Introduced in Chapter 19.

tener

to have — a common verb with two visible changes
Introduced in Chapter 18.

tengo · hago · digo

comparing the three learned *yo* forms that end in -go
Introduced in Chapter 22.

tomar

to take (and, across Latin America, to drink) — an everyday word with no settled origin
Introduced in Chapter 44.

trabajar

to work (a second -ar verb — same pattern)
Introduced in Chapter 16.

traer

to bring — Latin's word for dragging, and a verb with a direction built into it
Introduced in Chapter 48.

tú / usted

two of the three words Spanish uses to one person — and the one English quietly retired
Introduced in Chapter 4.

tú o usted

the choice English lost — and the surprise that *usted* takes he/she verb forms
Introduced in Chapter 4.

uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco

the numbers 1–5
Introduced in Chapter 18.

veinte

twenty — the ceiling of the teens, and a word that was worn but never fused
Introduced in Chapter 40.

venir

to come — with the singular present forms *vengo*, *vienes*, and *viene*
Introduced in Chapter 23.

ver

to see — veo, ves, ve
Introduced in Chapter 26.

verde

green — from a verb meaning “to flourish,” and a cousin of verdant but not of English green
Introduced in Chapter 42.

viví

the regular singular -ir preterite — viví, viviste, vivió
Introduced in Chapter 25.

vivir

to live (your first -ir verb)
Introduced in Chapter 17.

vos

“you” across a large part of the Spanish-speaking world — to recognise, not to say
Introduced in Chapter 4.

voy a + infinitive

I am going to... — the near future with ir, a, and a known infinitive
Introduced in Chapter 20.

y / ¿y tú?

and / and you? — a tiny connector that hands the conversation back
Introduced in Chapter 8.

¿cómo está usted?

how are you? — assemble the formal question from cómo, estar, and usted
Introduced in Chapter 7.

¿cómo se llama usted?

what’s your name? (formal)
Introduced in Chapter 5.

¿Cuántos años tienes?

how old are you? — literally, how many years do you have?
Introduced in Chapter 18.

Review Questions

Try these without looking ahead. Every prompt comes from the same canonical lesson data as its chapter. Answers begin in the next section.

Chapter 1

1.1 *Grammatical gender — the two noun classes behind el and la*
How many grammatical noun classes does Spanish keep?

Chapter 2

2.1 *buenos or buenas — the rule you have been using all along*
Why does bueno become buenos in buenos dias?

2.2 *buenos or buenas — the rule you have been using all along*
And why buenas in buenas tardes?

Chapter 10

10.1 *Where does ¿ begin? — bracket the spoken span*
In 'Roberto, ¿cómo estás?', is Roberto inside the question?

Chapter 17

17.1 *comer — “to eat,” and the second verb family*
Give the three singular forms of comer in order: I, tú, usted.

17.2 *vivir — “to live,” and the third family (that’s barely new)*
Give the three singular forms of vivir in order: I, tú, usted.

17.3 *beber* — “to drink,” and the pattern is yours

Say ‘I drink coffee’ in Spanish.

17.4 *qué* — “what”, a new question word

Ask one friend ‘What do you drink?’ in Spanish.

17.5 *dónde* — “where?”

Say ‘I live in Madrid’ in Spanish.

17.6 *Practice* — asking real questions

Give the yo forms of comer, vivir, and beber, in that order.

17.7 *Practice* — asking real questions

Ask one friend ‘What do you drink?’ in Spanish.

17.8 *Practice* — asking real questions

Answer ‘Where do you live?’ with Madrid.

Chapter 18

18.1 *uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco* — counting to five

Write the Spanish numbers 1 through 5 in order.

18.2 *uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco* — counting to five

Say ‘one coffee’ in Spanish.

18.3 *seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez* — and the calendar’s old count

Write the Spanish numbers 6 through 10 in order.

18.4 *seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez* — and the calendar’s old count

Were July and August inserted into the Roman calendar or were older months renamed?

18.5 *tener* — “to have,” with two visible changes

Give the yo, tú, and él/ella forms of tener, in that order.

18.6 *¿Cuántos años tienes?* — asking age

Ask one friend ‘How old are you?’ in Spanish.

18.7 *¿Cuántos años tienes?* — asking age

Answer ‘I am eight years old’ using the Spanish age frame.

18.8 *Practice* — counting, having, and age

Write the Spanish numbers 1 through 10 in order.

18.9 *Practice* — counting, having, and age

Give the three learned singular forms of tener: yo, tú, then él/ella.

18.10 *Practice* — counting, having, and age

Answer *¿Cuántos años tienes?* with nine years.

Chapter 19

19.1 *ser* — another way to say “to be”

Give the three learned singular forms of *ser*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

19.2 *ser* — another way to say “to be”

Complete the identification for formal you: Usted _____ Ana.

19.3 *ser vs estar* — identity or current state?

Choose *es* or *está*: ¿_____ usted Ana?

19.4 *ser vs estar* — identity or current state?

Choose *es* or *está*: ¿_____ usted bien?

19.5 *soy de...* — saying where you are from

Ask one friend ‘Where are you from?’ in Spanish.

19.6 *soy de...* — saying where you are from

Answer ‘I am from Madrid’ in Spanish.

19.7 *está en...* — saying where someone is

Ask formal you ‘Where are you?’ in Spanish.

19.8 *está en...* — saying where someone is

Say ‘Ana is in Madrid’ in Spanish.

19.9 *Practice* — identity, origin, state, and location

Complete with *es* or *está*: ¿_____ usted Ana?

19.10 *Practice* — identity, origin, state, and location

Say ‘I am from Madrid’ in Spanish.

19.11 *Practice* — identity, origin, state, and location

Say ‘Ana is in Madrid’ in Spanish.

19.12 *Practice* — identity, origin, state, and location

Complete with *es* or *está*: ¿_____ usted bien?

Chapter 20

20.1 *ir* — “to go,” from more than one historical stem

Give the three learned singular present forms of *ir*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

20.2 *ir* — “to go,” from more than one historical stem

Complete the formal question: ¿Dónde _____ usted?

20.3 *voy a + infinitive* — moving toward the near future

Say ‘I am going to speak’ in Spanish.

20.4 *voy a + infinitive* — moving toward the near future

Say ‘You are going to eat’ to one friend in Spanish.

20.5 *mi, tu, su — whose café?*

Say 'my coffee' in Spanish.

20.6 *mi, tu, su — whose café?*

Addressing usted, say 'your coffee' in Spanish.

20.7 Practice — going, approaching events, and ownership

Give the learned singular forms of ir: yo, tú, then usted.

20.8 Practice — going, approaching events, and ownership

Ask formal you 'Where are you going?' in Spanish.

20.9 Practice — going, approaching events, and ownership

Say 'I am going to speak' in Spanish.

20.10 Practice — going, approaching events, and ownership

Addressing usted, say 'your coffee' in Spanish.

Chapter 21

21.1 *querer — wanting with one familiar vowel change*

Give the learned singular present forms of querer: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

21.2 *querer — wanting with one familiar vowel change*

Say 'I want to speak' in Spanish.

21.3 *poder — ability with the o → ue change*

Give the learned singular present forms of poder: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

21.4 *poder — ability with the o → ue change*

Say 'You can eat' to one friend in Spanish.

21.5 *e → ie and o → ue — compare the singular forms*

Give the learned yo forms of querer and poder, in that order.

21.6 *e → ie and o → ue — compare the singular forms*

Give the learned tú forms of tener, querer, and poder, in that order.

21.7 *nuestro, nuestra — “our” with singular gender agreement*

Say 'our day' in Spanish.

21.8 *nuestro, nuestra — “our” with singular gender agreement*

Say 'our night' in Spanish.

21.9 Practice — wanting, ability, and our known nouns

Give the learned singular forms of querer: yo, tú, then usted.

21.10 Practice — wanting, ability, and our known nouns

Give the learned singular forms of poder: yo, tú, then usted.

21.11 Practice — wanting, ability, and our known nouns

Say 'I want to speak' in Spanish.

21.12 Practice — *wanting, ability, and our known nouns*

Say 'You can eat' to one friend in Spanish.

21.13 Practice — *wanting, ability, and our known nouns*

Say 'our night' in Spanish.

Chapter 22

22.1 hacer — *doing or making with three singular forms*

Give the learned singular present forms of *hacer*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

22.2 hacer — *doing or making with three singular forms*

Say 'I make coffee' in Spanish.

22.3 decir — *saying with the same small person frame*

Give the learned singular present forms of *decir*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

22.4 decir — *saying with the same small person frame*

Say 'I say hello' in Spanish.

22.5 decir — *saying with the same small person frame*

Ask one friend 'How do you say hello?' in Spanish.

22.6 tengo · hago · digo — *compare only what you know*

Give the learned yo forms of *tener*, *hacer*, and *decir*, in that order.

22.7 tengo · hago · digo — *compare only what you know*

Which learned yo form means 'I do' or 'I make'?

22.8 Practice — *doing, making, and saying in the singular*

Give the learned singular forms of *hacer*: yo, tú, then usted.

22.9 Practice — *doing, making, and saying in the singular*

Give the learned singular forms of *decir*: yo, tú, then usted.

22.10 Practice — *doing, making, and saying in the singular*

Give the learned yo forms of *tener*, *hacer*, and *decir*, in that order.

22.11 Practice — *doing, making, and saying in the singular*

Say 'I make coffee' in Spanish.

22.12 Practice — *doing, making, and saying in the singular*

Ask one friend 'How do you say hello?' in Spanish.

Chapter 23

23.1 poner — *putting or placing with three singular forms*

Give the learned singular present forms of *poner*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

23.2 *poner* — putting or placing with three singular forms

What two English verbs does poner cover?

23.3 *salir* — leaving with three singular forms

Give the learned singular present forms of salir: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

23.4 *salir* — leaving with three singular forms

Say 'I leave Madrid' in Spanish.

23.5 *venir* — coming with three singular forms

Give the learned singular present forms of venir: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

23.6 *venir* — coming with three singular forms

Say 'I come from Madrid' in Spanish.

23.7 *venir* — coming with three singular forms

Give the tú forms of venir and tener, in that order.

23.8 *Practice* — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular

Give the learned singular forms of poner: yo, tú, then usted.

23.9 *Practice* — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular

Give the learned singular forms of salir: yo, tú, then usted.

23.10 *Practice* — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular

Give the learned singular forms of venir: yo, tú, then usted.

23.11 *Practice* — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular

Say 'I leave Madrid; I come from Madrid' in Spanish.

23.12 *Practice* — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular

Give the learned yo forms of tener, hacer, decir, poner, salir, and venir, in that order.

23.13 *Practice* — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular

Match each Spanish verb to one English cousin: poner, salir, venir.

Chapter 24

24.1 *fui* — one past set shared by ser and ir

Give the shared singular preterite forms of ser and ir: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

24.2 *fui* — one past set shared by ser and ir

Say 'I went to Madrid' in Spanish.

24.3 *fui* — one past set shared by ser and ir

In 'Fue Roberto', which verb does fue express?

24.4 *hablé* — a regular singular past from a known verb

Give the singular completed-past forms of hablar: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

24.5 *hablé* — a regular singular past from a known verb

Say 'I spoke Spanish' in Spanish.

24.6 *hablé* — a regular singular past from a known verb

Which form means 'I spoke' as a completed event: *hablo* or *hablé*?

24.7 *Practice* — two singular ways to talk about a completed past

Give the three learned forms shared by *ser* and *ir*.

24.8 *Practice* — two singular ways to talk about a completed past

Give the three learned completed-past forms of *hablar*.

24.9 *Practice* — two singular ways to talk about a completed past

Which sentence uses the shared form as *ir*, 'to go': *Fui a Madrid* or *Fue Roberto*?

24.10 *Practice* — two singular ways to talk about a completed past

Give 'I speak Spanish' and then 'I spoke Spanish.'

24.11 *Practice* — two singular ways to talk about a completed past

Which two of *hablé*, *hablaste*, *habló* carry written accents?

Chapter 25

25.1 *comí* — one regular -er singular past

Give the singular completed-past forms of *comer*: *yo*, *tú*, then *él/ella/usted*.

25.2 *comí* — one regular -er singular past

Which form means 'I ate' as a completed event: *como* or *comí*?

25.3 *comí* — one regular -er singular past

Did Spanish *-í*, *-iste*, *-ió* arise by simple letter-dropping alone, or by sound change plus analogy?

25.4 *viví* — reuse one past pattern with an -ir verb

Give the singular completed-past forms of *vivir*: *yo*, *tú*, then *él/ella/usted*.

25.5 *viví* — reuse one past pattern with an -ir verb

Say 'I lived in Madrid' in Spanish.

25.6 *viví* — reuse one past pattern with an -ir verb

Which three singular past endings do *comer* and *vivir* share?

25.7 *tuve* — let the strong stem carry the stress

Give the singular completed-past forms of *tener*: *yo*, *tú*, then *él/ella/usted*.

25.8 *tuve* — let the strong stem carry the stress

Say 'I had coffee' in Spanish.

25.9 *tuve* — let the strong stem carry the stress

Which phrase best describes *tuve*: a letter-for-letter copy of *tenuī*, or a historically reshaped strong form?

25.10 *hice* — the strong pattern with one third-person swerve

Give the singular completed-past forms of *hacer*: *yo*, *tú*, then *él/ella/usted*.

25.11 *hice* — *the strong pattern with one third-person swerve*

Say 'I made coffee' in Spanish.

25.12 *hice* — *the strong pattern with one third-person swerve*

Which Latin strong-perfect form lies behind the historical development of *hice*?

25.13 *estuve* — *a third known verb joins the strong pattern*

Give the singular completed-past forms of *estar*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

25.14 *estuve* — *a third known verb joins the strong pattern*

Say 'I was well' as a completed past statement in Spanish.

25.15 *estuve* — *a third known verb joins the strong pattern*

Which known strong form helped shape the family resemblance in *estuve*: *tuve* or *hice*?

25.16 *Practice* — *six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary*

Give the learned yo past forms of *hablar*, *comer*, and *vivir*, in that order.

25.17 *Practice* — *six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary*

Give the learned yo past forms of *tener*, *hacer*, and *estar*, in that order.

25.18 *Practice* — *six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary*

Say 'I made coffee' in Spanish.

25.19 *Practice* — *six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary*

Say 'I lived in Madrid' in Spanish.

25.20 *Practice* — *six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary*

Say 'I was well' as a completed event in Spanish.

25.21 *Practice* — *six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary*

Which pair carries written accents: *comí/comió* or *tuve/tuvo*?

25.22 *Practice* — *six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary*

Which learned form is especially described as analogically remodeled beside *tuve*: *comí*, *hice*, or *estuve*?

Chapter 26

26.1 *hablaba* — *let a past action stay open*

Give the learned singular imperfect forms of *hablar*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

26.2 *hablaba* — *let a past action stay open*

Which form leaves 'I spoke' open or habitual: *hablé* or *hablaba*?

26.3 *hablaba* — *let a past action stay open*

Which consonant links Latin *-ābam* with Spanish *-aba*?

26.4 *comía* — *hear both vowels*

Give the learned singular imperfect forms of *comer*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

26.5 *comía* — hear both vowels

Which form means 'I was eating': *comí* or *comía*?

26.6 *comía* — hear both vowels

Write *comía* with syllable breaks.

26.7 *vivía* — reuse the complete -er row

Give the learned singular imperfect forms of *vivir*: *yo*, *tú*, then *él/ella/usted*.

26.8 *vivía* — reuse the complete -er row

Which two infinitive classes share the learned imperfect endings *-ía*, *-ías*, *-ía*?

26.9 *vivía* — reuse the complete -er row

Say 'I was living in Madrid' in Spanish.

26.10 *ver* — learn the verb before its past

What does Spanish *ver* mean?

26.11 *ver* — learn the verb before its past

Give the learned present forms of *ver*: *yo*, *tú*, then *él/ella/usted*.

26.12 *ver* — learn the verb before its past

Which Latin verb stands behind Spanish *ver*: *vidēre* or *īre*?

26.13 *era* — an old root in an open past

Give the learned singular imperfect forms of *ser*: *yo*, *tú*, then *él/ella/usted*.

26.14 *era* — an old root in an open past

Which *ser* form presents a background past: *era* or *fue*?

26.15 *era* — an old root in an open past

Which Latin form stands directly behind Spanish *era*: *eram* or *ībam*?

26.16 *iba* — *ir* returns to its inherited past

Give the learned singular imperfect forms of *ir*: *yo*, *tú*, then *él/ella/usted*.

26.17 *iba* — *ir* returns to its inherited past

Say 'I was going to Madrid' in Spanish.

26.18 *iba* — *ir* returns to its inherited past

Which inherited Latin verb stands behind *iba*: *īre* or *vidēre*?

26.19 *veía* — keep the extra *e* you already met

Give the learned singular imperfect forms of *ver*: *yo*, *tú*, then *él/ella/usted*.

26.20 *veía* — keep the extra *e* you already met

Which sentence means 'I was seeing coffee': *Veó café* or *Veía café*?

26.21 *veía* — keep the extra *e* you already met

Which earlier Spanish form makes the extra *e* of *veía* easier to see: *veer* or *ir*?

26.22 *Practice* — keep the past open or close it

Give the imperfect *yo* forms of *hablar*, *comer*, and *vivir*, in that order.

26.23 *Practice* — keep the past open or close it

Give the imperfect *yo* forms of *ser*, *ir*, and *ver*, in that order.

26.24 Practice — *keep the past open or close it*

Say 'I was speaking Spanish' in Spanish.

26.25 Practice — *keep the past open or close it*

Say 'I was living in Madrid' in Spanish.

26.26 Practice — *keep the past open or close it*

Say 'I was going to Madrid' in Spanish.

26.27 Practice — *keep the past open or close it*

Choose the open past: comí or comía.

26.28 Practice — *keep the past open or close it*

Match the three forms to their historical bridges: era, iba, veía — eram, ībam, veer.

Chapter 27

27.1 hablaré — *keep the infinitive, add the future*

Give the learned singular future forms of hablar: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

27.2 hablaré — *keep the infinitive, add the future*

Say 'I will speak Spanish' in Spanish.

27.3 hablaré — *keep the infinitive, add the future*

Which Latin verb meaning 'to have' contributed material to the Romance future endings?

27.4 comeré — *the same endings keep -er*

Give the learned singular future forms of comer: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

27.5 comeré — *the same endings keep -er*

Use the learned -er future pattern to say 'I will drink coffee' in Spanish.

27.6 comeré — *the same endings keep -er*

Which endings do hablaré and comeré share across the learned singular row?

27.7 viviré — *one future row for three verb families*

Give the learned singular future forms of vivir: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

27.8 viviré — *one future row for three verb families*

Say 'I will live in Madrid' in Spanish.

27.9 viviré — *one future row for three verb families*

Give the future yo forms of hablar, comer, and vivir, in that order.

27.10 hablaría — *the whole infinitive meets -ía*

Give the learned singular conditional forms of hablar: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

27.11 hablaría — *the whole infinitive meets -ía*

Say 'I would speak Spanish' in Spanish.

27.12 *hablaría* — *the whole infinitive meets -ía*

Write *hablaría* with the final three syllables separated.

27.13 *comería* — *keep -er before “would”*

Give the learned singular conditional forms of *comer*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

27.14 *comería* — *keep -er before “would”*

Give the yo pair ‘I will eat; I would eat’ in Spanish.

27.15 *comería* — *keep -er before “would”*

Which endings do *hablaría* and *comería* share across the learned singular row?

27.16 *viviría* — *the regular conditional closes its small frame*

Give the learned singular conditional forms of *vivir*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

27.17 *viviría* — *the regular conditional closes its small frame*

Say ‘I would live in Madrid’ in Spanish.

27.18 *viviría* — *the regular conditional closes its small frame*

Give the conditional yo forms of *hablar*, *comer*, and *vivir*, in that order.

27.19 *haré · tendré · podré* — *three stems, two ending sets*

Give the pair ‘I will make coffee; I would make coffee’ in Spanish.

27.20 *haré · tendré · podré* — *three stems, two ending sets*

Give the future and conditional yo forms of *tener*, in that order.

27.21 *haré · tendré · podré* — *three stems, two ending sets*

Give the pair ‘I will be able to speak Spanish; I could speak Spanish’ in Spanish.

27.22 *Practice* — *one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Give the future yo forms of *hablar*, *comer*, and *vivir*, in that order.

27.23 *Practice* — *one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Give the conditional yo forms of *hablar*, *comer*, and *vivir*, in that order.

27.24 *Practice* — *one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Say ‘I will speak Spanish’ in Spanish.

27.25 *Practice* — *one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Say ‘I would live in Madrid’ in Spanish.

27.26 *Practice* — *one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Give the pair ‘I will make coffee; I would make coffee’ in Spanish.

27.27 *Practice* — *one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Give the learned stems for *hacer*, *tener*, and *poder*, in that order.

27.28 *Practice* — *one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Which Latin ‘have’ verb contributed material to both Romance constructions?

Chapter 28

28.1 *Hablas español · Quiero que hables español — fact or wanted event?*
Which form asserts that one friend speaks: hablas or hables?

28.2 *Hablas español · Quiero que hables español — fact or wanted event?*
Say 'I want to speak Spanish' in Spanish.

28.3 *Hablas español · Quiero que hables español — fact or wanted event?*
Say 'I want you to speak Spanish' to one friend.

28.4 *hable · hables · hable — the singular -ar row*
Give the learned singular present-subjunctive forms of hablar: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

28.5 *hable · hables · hable — the singular -ar row*
Which present form gives the stem for regular hable: hablo or habla?

28.6 *hable · hables · hable — the singular -ar row*
What joining idea sits inside the Latin source of subjuntivo?

28.7 *coma · comas · coma — let -er cross to a*
Give the learned singular subjunctive forms of comer: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

28.8 *coma · comas · coma — let -er cross to a*
Which form belongs after quiero que for one friend: comes or comas?

28.9 *coma · comas · coma — let -er cross to a*
Say 'I want you to eat' to one friend.

28.10 *viva · vivas · viva — -ir joins -er*
Give the learned singular subjunctive forms of vivir: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

28.11 *viva · vivas · viva — -ir joins -er*
Which two regular verb families share -a, -as, -a here?

28.12 *viva · vivas · viva — -ir joins -er*
Say 'I want you to live in Madrid' to one friend.

28.13 *quiera · quieras · quiera — keep the change you know*
Give the learned singular subjunctive forms of querer: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

28.14 *quiera · quieras · quiera — keep the change you know*
Which known present yo form gives the stem quier-?

28.15 *quiera · quieras · quiera — keep the change you know*
Complete 'Quiero que ____ hablar español' for one friend.

28.16 *pueda · puedas · pueda — one more known stem change*
Give the learned singular subjunctive forms of poder: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

28.17 *pueda · puedas · pueda — one more known stem change*
Which known present yo form gives the stem pued-?

28.18 *pueda · puedas · pueda — one more known stem change*

Say 'I want you to be able to speak Spanish' to one friend.

28.19 *haga · hagas · haga — hago lends its stem*

Give the learned singular subjunctive forms of *hacer*: yo, tú, then él/ella/usted.

28.20 *haga · hagas · haga — hago lends its stem*

Which known present yo form gives the stem *hag-*?

28.21 *haga · hagas · haga — hago lends its stem*

Say 'I want you to make coffee' to one friend.

28.22 *ojalá + subjunctive — a wish borrowed through Arabic*

Say 'I hope you speak Spanish' to one friend using *ojalá*.

28.23 *ojalá + subjunctive — a wish borrowed through Arabic*

Does the learned *ojalá* frame require *que* before *hables*? Answer yes or no.

28.24 *ojalá + subjunctive — a wish borrowed through Arabic*

Through which historical language variety did Spanish receive *ojalá*?

28.25 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Choose the wanted-event form: *hablas* or *hables*.

28.26 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Give the pair 'I want to speak Spanish; I want you to speak Spanish.'

28.27 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Give the tú subjunctive forms of *hablar*, *comer*, and *vivir*, in that order.

28.28 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Which present-person form supplies the stem in this chapter's recipe?

28.29 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Give the learned singular subjunctive row of *querer*.

28.30 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Say 'I want you to be able to speak Spanish' to one friend.

28.31 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Say 'I want you to make coffee' to one friend.

28.32 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Say 'I hope you live in Madrid' to one friend using *ojalá*.

28.33 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

What does the Latin source *subiūnctīvus* help you picture?

28.34 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Name the historical language variety through which *ojalá* entered Spanish.

Answer Key

The first response is the canonical display answer. When a question accepts other authored forms, they appear underneath.

Chapter 1

1.1 *Grammatical gender — the two noun classes behind el and la*

Answer: two

Also accepted: 2

Chapter 2

2.1 *buenos or buenas — the rule you have been using all along*

Answer: it agrees with masculine plural dias

Also accepted: agreement with masculine plural dias; dias is masculine plural; because dias is masculine and plural

2.2 *buenos or buenas — the rule you have been using all along*

Answer: tardes is feminine plural

Also accepted: because tardes is feminine; feminine plural; tardes is feminine and plural

Chapter 10

10.1 *Where does ¿ begin? — bracket the spoken span*

Answer: no

Also accepted: no it is not; it is not

Chapter 17

17.1 *comer — “to eat,” and the second verb family*

Answer: como, comes, come

Also accepted: como comes come; como / comes / come

17.2 *vivir* — “to live,” and the third family (that’s barely new)**Answer:** vivo, vives, vive**Also accepted:** vivo vives vive; vivo / vives / vive**17.3** *beber* — “to drink,” and the pattern is yours**Answer:** Bebo café.**Also accepted:** Bebo café; bebo cafe; bebo cafe.**17.4** *qué* — “what”, a new question word**Answer:** ¿Qué bebes?**Also accepted:** Qué bebes?; ¿Qué bebes; Qué bebes**17.5** *dónde* — “where?”**Answer:** Vivo en Madrid.**Also accepted:** Vivo en Madrid; Yo vivo en Madrid.; Yo vivo en Madrid**17.6** *Practice* — asking real questions**Answer:** como, vivo, bebo**Also accepted:** como vivo bebo; como / vivo / bebo**17.7** *Practice* — asking real questions**Answer:** ¿Qué bebes?**Also accepted:** Qué bebes?; ¿Qué bebes; Qué bebes**17.8** *Practice* — asking real questions**Answer:** Vivo en Madrid.**Also accepted:** Vivo en Madrid; Yo vivo en Madrid.; Yo vivo en Madrid

Chapter 18

18.1 *uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco* — counting to five**Answer:** uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco**Also accepted:** uno dos tres cuatro cinco**18.2** *uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco* — counting to five**Answer:** un café**Also accepted:** un cafe**18.3** *seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez* — and the calendar’s old count**Answer:** seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez**Also accepted:** seis siete ocho nueve diez**18.4** *seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez* — and the calendar’s old count**Answer:** older months were renamed**Also accepted:** renamed; they were renamed; the older months were renamed**18.5** *tener* — “to have,” with two visible changes**Answer:** tengo, tienes, tiene**Also accepted:** tengo tienes tiene; tengo / tienes / tiene**18.6** *¿Cuántos años tienes?* — asking age**Answer:** ¿Cuántos años tienes?**Also accepted:** Cuántos años tienes?; ¿Cuántos años tienes; Cuantos anos tienes?

18.7 *¿Cuántos años tienes? — asking age***Answer:** Tengo ocho años.**Also accepted:** Tengo ocho años; tengo ocho anos; tengo ocho anos.**18.8 Practice — counting, having, and age****Answer:** uno, dos, tres, cuatro, cinco, seis, siete, ocho, nueve, diez**Also accepted:** uno dos tres cuatro cinco seis siete ocho nueve diez**18.9 Practice — counting, having, and age****Answer:** tengo, tienes, tiene**Also accepted:** tengo tienes tiene; tengo / tienes / tiene**18.10 Practice — counting, having, and age****Answer:** Tengo nueve años.**Also accepted:** Tengo nueve años; tengo nueve anos; tengo nueve anos.

Chapter 19

19.1 *ser — another way to say “to be”***Answer:** soy, eres, es**Also accepted:** soy eres es; soy / eres / es**19.2** *ser — another way to say “to be”***Answer:** es**Also accepted:** Usted es Ana.; usted es ana**19.3** *ser vs estar — identity or current state?***Answer:** es**Also accepted:** ¿Es usted Ana?; Es usted Ana?**19.4** *ser vs estar — identity or current state?***Answer:** está**Also accepted:** ¿Está usted bien?; Esta usted bien?; esta**19.5** *soy de... — saying where you are from***Answer:** ¿De dónde eres?**Also accepted:** De dónde eres?; ¿De dónde eres; De donde eres?**19.6** *soy de... — saying where you are from***Answer:** Soy de Madrid.**Also accepted:** Soy de Madrid**19.7** *está en... — saying where someone is***Answer:** ¿Dónde está usted?**Also accepted:** Dónde está usted?; ¿Dónde está usted; Donde esta usted?**19.8** *está en... — saying where someone is***Answer:** Ana está en Madrid.**Also accepted:** Ana está en Madrid; ana esta en madrid; ana esta en madrid.**19.9 Practice — identity, origin, state, and location****Answer:** es**Also accepted:** ¿Es usted Ana?; Es usted Ana?

19.10 Practice — *identity, origin, state, and location***Answer:** Soy de Madrid.**Also accepted:** Soy de Madrid**19.11 Practice** — *identity, origin, state, and location***Answer:** Ana está en Madrid.**Also accepted:** Ana está en Madrid; ana esta en madrid; ana esta en madrid.**19.12 Practice** — *identity, origin, state, and location***Answer:** está**Also accepted:** ¿Está usted bien?; Esta usted bien?; esta

Chapter 20

20.1 ir — *“to go,” from more than one historical stem***Answer:** voy, vas, va**Also accepted:** voy vas va; voy / vas / va**20.2 ir** — *“to go,” from more than one historical stem***Answer:** va**Also accepted:** ¿Dónde va usted?; Donde va usted?**20.3 voy a + infinitive** — *moving toward the near future***Answer:** Voy a hablar.**Also accepted:** Voy a hablar**20.4 voy a + infinitive** — *moving toward the near future***Answer:** Vas a comer.**Also accepted:** Vas a comer**20.5 mi, tu, su** — *whose café?***Answer:** mi café**Also accepted:** mi cafe**20.6 mi, tu, su** — *whose café?***Answer:** su café**Also accepted:** su cafe**20.7 Practice** — *going, approaching events, and ownership***Answer:** voy, vas, va**Also accepted:** voy vas va; voy / vas / va**20.8 Practice** — *going, approaching events, and ownership***Answer:** ¿Dónde va usted?**Also accepted:** Dónde va usted?; Donde va usted?; ¿Donde va usted?**20.9 Practice** — *going, approaching events, and ownership***Answer:** Voy a hablar.**Also accepted:** Voy a hablar**20.10 Practice** — *going, approaching events, and ownership***Answer:** su café**Also accepted:** su cafe

Chapter 21

21.1 *querer — wanting with one familiar vowel change*

Answer: quiero, quieres, quiere

Also accepted: quiero quieres quiere; quiero / quieres / quiere

21.2 *querer — wanting with one familiar vowel change*

Answer: Quiero hablar.

Also accepted: Quiero hablar

21.3 *poder — ability with the o → ue change*

Answer: puedo, puedes, puede

Also accepted: puedo puedes puede; puedo / puedes / puede

21.4 *poder — ability with the o → ue change*

Answer: Puedes comer.

Also accepted: Puedes comer

21.5 *e → ie and o → ue — compare the singular forms*

Answer: quiero, puedo

Also accepted: quiero puedo; quiero / puedo

21.6 *e → ie and o → ue — compare the singular forms*

Answer: tienes, quieres, puedes

Also accepted: tienes quieres puedes; tienes / quieres / puedes

21.7 *nuestro, nuestra — “our” with singular gender agreement*

Answer: nuestro día

Also accepted: nuestro día

21.8 *nuestro, nuestra — “our” with singular gender agreement*

Answer: nuestra noche

Also accepted: nuestra noche.

21.9 *Practice — wanting, ability, and our known nouns*

Answer: quiero, quieres, quiere

Also accepted: quiero quieres quiere; quiero / quieres / quiere

21.10 *Practice — wanting, ability, and our known nouns*

Answer: puedo, puedes, puede

Also accepted: puedo puedes puede; puedo / puedes / puede

21.11 *Practice — wanting, ability, and our known nouns*

Answer: Quiero hablar.

Also accepted: Quiero hablar

21.12 *Practice — wanting, ability, and our known nouns*

Answer: Puedes comer.

Also accepted: Puedes comer

21.13 *Practice — wanting, ability, and our known nouns*

Answer: nuestra noche

Also accepted: nuestra noche.

Chapter 22

22.1 *hacer — doing or making with three singular forms*

Answer: hago, haces, hace

Also accepted: hago haces hace; hago / haces / hace

22.2 *hacer — doing or making with three singular forms*

Answer: Hago café.

Also accepted: Hago café; Hago cafe; Hago cafe.

22.3 *decir — saying with the same small person frame*

Answer: digo, dices, dice

Also accepted: digo dices dice; digo / dices / dice

22.4 *decir — saying with the same small person frame*

Answer: Digo hola.

Also accepted: Digo hola

22.5 *decir — saying with the same small person frame*

Answer: ¿Cómo dices ‘hola’?

Also accepted: ¿Cómo dices hola?; Cómo dices hola?; Como dices hola?; ¿Como dices hola?

22.6 *tengo · hago · digo — compare only what you know*

Answer: tengo, hago, digo

Also accepted: tengo hago digo; tengo / hago / digo

22.7 *tengo · hago · digo — compare only what you know*

Answer: hago

Also accepted: yo hago

22.8 *Practice — doing, making, and saying in the singular*

Answer: hago, haces, hace

Also accepted: hago haces hace; hago / haces / hace

22.9 *Practice — doing, making, and saying in the singular*

Answer: digo, dices, dice

Also accepted: digo dices dice; digo / dices / dice

22.10 *Practice — doing, making, and saying in the singular*

Answer: tengo, hago, digo

Also accepted: tengo hago digo; tengo / hago / digo

22.11 *Practice — doing, making, and saying in the singular*

Answer: Hago café.

Also accepted: Hago café; Hago cafe; Hago cafe.

22.12 *Practice — doing, making, and saying in the singular*

Answer: ¿Cómo dices ‘hola’?

Also accepted: ¿Cómo dices hola?; Cómo dices hola?; Como dices hola?; ¿Como dices hola?

Chapter 23

23.1 *poner* — putting or placing with three singular forms

Answer: pongo, pones, pone

Also accepted: pongo pones pone; pongo / pones / pone

23.2 *poner* — putting or placing with three singular forms

Answer: to put or to place

Also accepted: put or place; to put and to place; put and place

23.3 *salir* — leaving with three singular forms

Answer: salgo, sales, sale

Also accepted: salgo sales sale; salgo / sales / sale

23.4 *salir* — leaving with three singular forms

Answer: Salgo de Madrid.

Also accepted: Salgo de Madrid

23.5 *venir* — coming with three singular forms

Answer: vengo, vienes, viene

Also accepted: vengo vienes viene; vengo / vienes / viene

23.6 *venir* — coming with three singular forms

Answer: Vengo de Madrid.

Also accepted: Vengo de Madrid

23.7 *venir* — coming with three singular forms

Answer: vienes, tienes

Also accepted: vienes tienes; vienes / tienes

23.8 *Practice* — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular

Answer: pongo, pones, pone

Also accepted: pongo pones pone; pongo / pones / pone

23.9 *Practice* — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular

Answer: salgo, sales, sale

Also accepted: salgo sales sale; salgo / sales / sale

23.10 *Practice* — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular

Answer: vengo, vienes, viene

Also accepted: vengo vienes viene; vengo / vienes / viene

23.11 *Practice* — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular

Answer: Salgo de Madrid; vengo de Madrid.

Also accepted: Salgo de Madrid. Vengo de Madrid.; Salgo de Madrid, vengo de Madrid; Salgo de Madrid y vengo de Madrid

23.12 *Practice* — putting, leaving, and coming in the singular

Answer: tengo, hago, digo, pongo, salgo, vengo

Also accepted: tengo hago digo pongo salgo vengo; tengo / hago / digo / pongo / salgo / vengo

23.13 Practice — *putting, leaving, and coming in the singular***Answer:** poner—position; salir—salient; venir—convene**Also accepted:** poner position salir salient venir convene; poner: position; salir: salient; venir: convene; position salient convene**Chapter 24****24.1 fui** — *one past set shared by ser and ir***Answer:** fui, fuiste, fue**Also accepted:** fui fuiste fue; fui / fuiste / fue**24.2 fui** — *one past set shared by ser and ir***Answer:** Fui a Madrid.**Also accepted:** Fui a Madrid**24.3 fui** — *one past set shared by ser and ir***Answer:** ser**24.4 hablé** — *a regular singular past from a known verb***Answer:** hablé, hablaste, habló**Also accepted:** hablé hablaste habló; hablé / hablaste / habló**24.5 hablé** — *a regular singular past from a known verb***Answer:** Hablé español.**Also accepted:** Hablé español**24.6 hablé** — *a regular singular past from a known verb***Answer:** hablé**24.7 Practice** — *two singular ways to talk about a completed past***Answer:** fui, fuiste, fue**Also accepted:** fui fuiste fue; fui / fuiste / fue**24.8 Practice** — *two singular ways to talk about a completed past***Answer:** hablé, hablaste, habló**Also accepted:** hablé hablaste habló; hablé / hablaste / habló**24.9 Practice** — *two singular ways to talk about a completed past***Answer:** Fui a Madrid.**Also accepted:** Fui a Madrid**24.10 Practice** — *two singular ways to talk about a completed past***Answer:** Hablo español. Hablé español.**Also accepted:** Hablo español; hablé español; Hablo español. Hablé español; hablo español hablé español**24.11 Practice** — *two singular ways to talk about a completed past***Answer:** hablé and habló**Also accepted:** hablé habló; hablé y habló; hablé / habló

Chapter 25

25.1 *comí* — one regular -er singular past

Answer: comí, comiste, comió

Also accepted: comí comiste comió; comí / comiste / comió

25.2 *comí* — one regular -er singular past

Answer: comí

25.3 *comí* — one regular -er singular past

Answer: sound change plus analogy

Also accepted: sound change and analogy; sound change, plus analogy

25.4 *viví* — reuse one past pattern with an -ir verb

Answer: viví, viviste, vivió

Also accepted: viví viviste vivió; viví / viviste / vivió

25.5 *viví* — reuse one past pattern with an -ir verb

Answer: Viví en Madrid.

Also accepted: Viví en Madrid

25.6 *viví* — reuse one past pattern with an -ir verb

Answer: -í, -iste, -ió

Also accepted: í iste ió; -í -iste -ió; -í / -iste / -ió

25.7 *tuve* — let the strong stem carry the stress

Answer: tuve, tuviste, tuvo

Also accepted: tuve tuviste tuvo; tuve / tuviste / tuvo

25.8 *tuve* — let the strong stem carry the stress

Answer: Tuve café.

Also accepted: Tuve café

25.9 *tuve* — let the strong stem carry the stress

Answer: a historically reshaped strong form

Also accepted: historically reshaped strong form; a reshaped strong form

25.10 *hice* — the strong pattern with one third-person swerve

Answer: hice, hiciste, hizo

Also accepted: hice hiciste hizo; hice / hiciste / hizo

25.11 *hice* — the strong pattern with one third-person swerve

Answer: Hice café.

Also accepted: Hice café

25.12 *hice* — the strong pattern with one third-person swerve

Answer: *fēcī*

Also accepted: feci

25.13 *estuve* — a third known verb joins the strong pattern

Answer: estuve, estuviste, estuvo

Also accepted: estuve estuviste estuvo; estuve / estuviste / estuvo

25.14 *estuve* — a third known verb joins the strong pattern

Answer: Estuve bien.

Also accepted: Estuve bien

25.15 *estuve* — a third known verb joins the strong pattern

Answer: tuve

25.16 *Practice* — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary

Answer: hablé, comí, viví

Also accepted: hablé comí viví; hablé / comí / viví

25.17 *Practice* — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary

Answer: tuve, hice, estuve

Also accepted: tuve hice estuve; tuve / hice / estuve

25.18 *Practice* — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary

Answer: Hice café.

Also accepted: Hice café

25.19 *Practice* — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary

Answer: Viví en Madrid.

Also accepted: Viví en Madrid

25.20 *Practice* — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary

Answer: Estuve bien.

Also accepted: Estuve bien

25.21 *Practice* — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary

Answer: comí and comió

Also accepted: comí comió; comí/comió; comí y comió

25.22 *Practice* — six singular patterns, no hidden vocabulary

Answer: estuve

Chapter 26

26.1 *hablaba* — let a past action stay open

Answer: hablaba, hablabas, hablaba

Also accepted: hablaba hablabas hablaba; hablaba / hablabas / hablaba

26.2 *hablaba* — let a past action stay open

Answer: hablaba

26.3 *hablaba* — let a past action stay open

Answer: b

Also accepted: the b; b sound

26.4 *comía* — hear both vowels

Answer: comía, comías, comía

Also accepted: comía comías comía; comía / comías / comía

26.5 *comía* — hear both vowels

Answer: comía

26.6 *comía* — hear both vowels

Answer: co-mí-a

26.7 *vivía* — reuse the complete -er row

Answer: vivía, vivías, vivía

Also accepted: vivía vivías vivía; vivía / vivías / vivía

26.8 *vivía* — reuse the complete -er row

Answer: -er and -ir

Also accepted: er and ir; -er / -ir; er ir

26.9 *vivía* — reuse the complete -er row

Answer: Vivía en Madrid.

Also accepted: Vivía en Madrid

26.10 *ver* — learn the verb before its past

Answer: to see

Also accepted: see

26.11 *ver* — learn the verb before its past

Answer: veo, ves, ve

Also accepted: veo ves ve; veo / ves / ve

26.12 *ver* — learn the verb before its past

Answer: vidēre

Also accepted: videre

26.13 *era* — an old root in an open past

Answer: era, eras, era

Also accepted: era eras era; era / eras / era

26.14 *era* — an old root in an open past

Answer: era

26.15 *era* — an old root in an open past

Answer: eram

26.16 *iba* — ir returns to its inherited past

Answer: iba, ibas, iba

Also accepted: iba ibas iba; iba / ibas / iba

26.17 *iba* — ir returns to its inherited past

Answer: Iba a Madrid.

Also accepted: Iba a Madrid

26.18 *iba* — ir returns to its inherited past

Answer: īre

Also accepted: ire

26.19 *veía* — keep the extra e you already met

Answer: veía, veías, veía

Also accepted: veía veías veía; veía / veías / veía

26.20 *veía* — keep the extra e you already met

Answer: Veía café.

26.21 *veía* — keep the extra e you already met

Answer: veer

26.22 *Practice* — keep the past open or close it

Answer: hablaba, comía, vivía

Also accepted: hablaba comía vivía; hablaba / comía / vivía

26.23 *Practice* — keep the past open or close it

Answer: era, iba, veía

Also accepted: era iba veía; era / iba / veía

26.24 *Practice* — keep the past open or close it

Answer: Hablaba español.

Also accepted: Hablaba español

26.25 *Practice* — keep the past open or close it

Answer: Vivía en Madrid.

Also accepted: Vivía en Madrid

26.26 *Practice* — keep the past open or close it

Answer: Iba a Madrid.

Also accepted: Iba a Madrid

26.27 *Practice* — keep the past open or close it

Answer: comía

26.28 *Practice* — keep the past open or close it

Answer: era—eram; iba—ibam; veía—veer

Also accepted: era eram iba ibam veía veer; era-eram, iba-ibam, veía-veer

Chapter 27

27.1 *hablaré* — keep the infinitive, add the future

Answer: hablaré, hablarás, hablará

Also accepted: hablaré hablarás hablará; hablaré / hablarás / hablará

27.2 *hablaré* — keep the infinitive, add the future

Answer: Hablaré español.

Also accepted: Hablaré español

27.3 *hablaré* — keep the infinitive, add the future

Answer: habēre

Also accepted: habere; haber

27.4 *comeré* — the same endings keep -er

Answer: comeré, comerás, comerá

Also accepted: comeré comerás comerá; comeré / comerás / comerá

27.5 *comeré* — the same endings keep -er

Answer: Beberé café.

Also accepted: Beberé café; Bebere cafe; Bebere cafe.

27.6 *comeré — the same endings keep -er*

Answer: -é, -ás, -á

Also accepted: é ás á; -é -ás -á

27.7 *viviré — one future row for three verb families*

Answer: viviré, vivirás, vivirá

Also accepted: viviré vivirás vivirá; viviré / vivirás / vivirá

27.8 *viviré — one future row for three verb families*

Answer: Viviré en Madrid.

Also accepted: Viviré en Madrid

27.9 *viviré — one future row for three verb families*

Answer: hablaré, comeré, viviré

Also accepted: hablaré comeré viviré; hablaré / comeré / viviré

27.10 *hablaría — the whole infinitive meets -ía*

Answer: hablaría, hablarías, hablaría

Also accepted: hablaría hablarías hablaría; hablaría / hablarías / hablaría

27.11 *hablaría — the whole infinitive meets -ía*

Answer: Hablaría español.

Also accepted: Hablaría español

27.12 *hablaría — the whole infinitive meets -ía*

Answer: ha-bla-rí-a

Also accepted: habla-rí-a; rí-a

27.13 *comería — keep -er before “would”*

Answer: comería, comerías, comería

Also accepted: comería comerías comería; comería / comerías / comería

27.14 *comería — keep -er before “would”*

Answer: Comeré; comería.

Also accepted: Comeré comería; comeré / comería

27.15 *comería — keep -er before “would”*

Answer: -ía, -ías, -ía

Also accepted: ía ías ía; -ía -ías -ía

27.16 *viviría — the regular conditional closes its small frame*

Answer: viviría, vivirías, viviría

Also accepted: viviría vivirías viviría; viviría / vivirías / viviría

27.17 *viviría — the regular conditional closes its small frame*

Answer: Viviría en Madrid.

Also accepted: Viviría en Madrid

27.18 *viviría — the regular conditional closes its small frame*

Answer: hablaría, comería, viviría

Also accepted: hablaría comería viviría; hablaría / comería / viviría

27.19 *haré · tendré · podré — three stems, two ending sets*

Answer: Haré café; haría café.

Also accepted: Haré café Haría café; haré café / haría café

27.20 *haré · tendré · podré — three stems, two ending sets*

Answer: tendré, tendría

Also accepted: tendré tendría; tendré / tendría

27.21 *haré · tendré · podré — three stems, two ending sets*

Answer: Podré hablar español; podría hablar español.

Also accepted: Podré hablar español Podría hablar español; podré hablar español / podría hablar español

27.22 *Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Answer: hablaré, comeré, viviré

Also accepted: hablaré comeré viviré; hablaré / comeré / viviré

27.23 *Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Answer: hablaría, comería, viviría

Also accepted: hablaría comería viviría; hablaría / comería / viviría

27.24 *Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Answer: Hablaré español.

Also accepted: Hablaré español

27.25 *Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Answer: Viviría en Madrid.

Also accepted: Viviría en Madrid

27.26 *Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Answer: Haré café; haría café.

Also accepted: Haré café Haría café; haré café / haría café

27.27 *Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Answer: har-, tendr-, podr-

Also accepted: har tendr podr; har- / tendr- / podr-

27.28 *Practice — one infinitive frame, two futures of thought*

Answer: habēre

Also accepted: habere; haber

Chapter 28

28.1 *Hablas español · Quiero que hables español — fact or wanted event?*

Answer: hablas

28.2 *Hablas español · Quiero que hables español — fact or wanted event?*

Answer: Quiero hablar español.

Also accepted: Quiero hablar español

28.3 *Hablas español · Quiero que hables español — fact or wanted event?*

Answer: Quiero que hables español.

Also accepted: Quiero que hables español

28.4 *hable · hables · hable — the singular -ar row*

Answer: hable, hables, hable

Also accepted: hable hables hable; hable / hables / hable

28.5 *hable · hables · hable — the singular -ar row*

Answer: hablo

28.6 *hable · hables · hable — the singular -ar row*

Answer: subjoined or joined under

Also accepted: subjoined; joined under

28.7 *coma · comas · coma — let -er cross to a*

Answer: coma, comas, coma

Also accepted: coma comas coma; coma / comas / coma

28.8 *coma · comas · coma — let -er cross to a*

Answer: comas

28.9 *coma · comas · coma — let -er cross to a*

Answer: Quiero que comas.

Also accepted: Quiero que comas

28.10 *viva · vivas · viva — -ir joins -er*

Answer: viva, vivas, viva

Also accepted: viva vivas viva; viva / vivas / viva

28.11 *viva · vivas · viva — -ir joins -er*

Answer: -er and -ir

Also accepted: er and ir; -er / -ir

28.12 *viva · vivas · viva — -ir joins -er*

Answer: Quiero que vivas en Madrid.

Also accepted: Quiero que vivas en Madrid

28.13 *quiera · quieras · quiera — keep the change you know*

Answer: quiera, quieras, quiera

Also accepted: quiera quieras quiera; quiera / quieras / quiera

28.14 *quiera · quieras · quiera — keep the change you know*

Answer: quiero

28.15 *quiera · quieras · quiera — keep the change you know*

Answer: quieras

28.16 *pueda · puedas · pueda — one more known stem change*

Answer: pueda, puedas, pueda

Also accepted: pueda puedas pueda; pueda / puedas / pueda

28.17 *pueda · puedas · pueda — one more known stem change*

Answer: puedo

28.18 *pueda · puedas · pueda — one more known stem change*

Answer: Quiero que puedas hablar español.

Also accepted: Quiero que puedas hablar español

28.19 *haga · haga · haga — hago lends its stem*

Answer: haga, haga, haga

Also accepted: haga haga haga; haga / haga / haga

28.20 *haga · hagas · haga — hago lends its stem*

Answer: hago

28.21 *haga · hagas · haga — hago lends its stem*

Answer: Quiero que hagas café.

Also accepted: Quiero que hagas café; Quiero que hagas cafe

28.22 *ojalá + subjunctive — a wish borrowed through Arabic*

Answer: Ojalá hables español.

Also accepted: Ojalá hables español; Ojala hables espanol

28.23 *ojalá + subjunctive — a wish borrowed through Arabic*

Answer: no

28.24 *ojalá + subjunctive — a wish borrowed through Arabic*

Answer: Hispanic Arabic

Also accepted: Arabic; Andalusí Arabic; Hispano-Arabic

28.25 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Answer: hables

28.26 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Answer: Quiero hablar español; quiero que hables español.

Also accepted: Quiero hablar español Quiero que hables español; Quiero hablar español / quiero que hables español

28.27 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Answer: hables, comas, vivas

Also accepted: hables comas vivas; hables / comas / vivas

28.28 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Answer: the yo form

Also accepted: yo; present yo form

28.29 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Answer: quiera, quieras, quiera

Also accepted: quiera quieras quiera; quiera / quieras / quiera

28.30 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Answer: Quiero que puedas hablar español.

Also accepted: Quiero que puedas hablar español

28.31 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Answer: Quiero que hagas café.

Also accepted: Quiero que hagas café; Quiero que hagas cafe

28.32 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Answer: Ojalá vivas en Madrid.

Also accepted: Ojalá vivas en Madrid; Ojala vivas en Madrid

28.33 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Answer: a clause subjoined or joined under another

Also accepted: subjoined; joined under

28.34 *Practice — assert the event or want it*

Answer: Hispanic Arabic

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tuve — let the strong stem carry the stress

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 25, p. 173

twenty — the ceiling of the teens, and a word that was worn but never fused *veinte*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 40, p. 263

two of the three words Spanish uses to one person — and the one English quietly retired *tú / usted*

Chapter 4, p. 27

U

until / up to *hasta*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 11, p. 79

Until When

chapter topic; Chapter 12, p. 85

V

veía — keep the extra e you already met

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 26, p. 183

Verbs That Break in the Middle — the Stem Changers

chapter topic; Chapter 21, p. 145

viva · vivas · viva — -ir joins -er

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 28, p. 203

vivía — reuse the complete -er row

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 26, p. 183

viviré — one future row for three verb families

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 27, p. 193

viviría — the regular conditional closes its small frame

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 27, p. 193

***vuestra merced* → *usted* — respect compressed into one word**

etymology topic; explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 4, p. 27

W

Waiting, Answering, Buying

chapter topic; Chapter 49, p. 325

water — a word that barely changed from Latin, and takes el

without ever stopping being feminine *el agua*

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 35, p. 241

Water, Wine, and Bread

chapter topic; Chapter 35, p. 241

well / good / fine *bien*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

what? (a new question word for verbs you already know) *qué*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 17, p. 113

what *estar* is for — a current state or location — and the only two forms you need this chapter *estás / está*

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 7, p. 61

what's your name? (formal) *¿cómo se llama usted?*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 5, p. 35

When You Don't Understand

chapter topic; Chapter 14, p. 97

where? *dónde*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 17, p. 113

Where does *¿* begin? — bracket the spoken span

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 10, p. 71

wine — one Latin root that reached English by three separate roads, plus one English built at home *el vino*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 35, p. 241

Y

yellow — from “a little bitter,” not from any Latin word for

yellow at all *amarillo*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 42, p. 273

yes *sí*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 6, p. 47

“you” across a large part of the Spanish-speaking world — to

recognise, not to say *vos*

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 4, p. 27

you're welcome (literally “of nothing”) *de nada*

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 6, p. 47

your first sentence built from parts — and the rule that

languages take no article *Hablo español*

explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 16, p. 105

Your First Verb

chapter topic; Chapter 15, p. 101